

BW

www.businessworld.in

BUSINESSWORLD

RNINO.39847/81 | 03 OCTOBER 2026

INDIA'S HOTTEST ENTREPRENEURS

*After a decade of startup highs,
hard lessons and funding swings,
BW 40 UNDER 40 features
entrepreneurs and intrapreneurs
building for the long run*

Abhimanyu Asija, Abhinav Parashar, Adrija Agarwal, Adwaita Nayar, Akis Evangelidis, Ambrish Miyani, Ankita Aditya Parakh, Ankur Tyagi, Ashonal Clery Pereira, Avinash Chenreddy, Bhuman Dani, Binitha Manohar Dalal, Binnita Shah, Dhruv Sayani, Hamza Patel, Harday Gupta, Himanshu Ratnoo, Keshav Bhajanka, Kritika Singh, Mangesh Zope, Mohit Gulyani, Niharika Joshi, Nitin Vinod Kalra, Piyush Goyal, Priyam Parikh, Ragini Varma, Rishikesh SR, Saloni Satish Wagh, Shreya Verma, Sneha Shah, Sneha Sharma, Sneha Roy, Sridhar Sampathirao, Swati Babel, Taranjit Shah Singh, Uplaksh Tewary, Varun Karad, Varun Kumar Modi, Vijay Kumar Gond, Vinayak Bhavnani, Viraj Sheth, Yashovardhan Agarwal



8 906209 450399



Soch kar
Samajh kar
Invest kar



VERIFY BROKER DETAILS ON **SEBI'S WEBSITE** BEFORE INVESTING



Be Smart.
Scan Now.



BW BUSINESSWORLD

www.businessworld.in

RNINO.39847/81 | 03 OCTOBER 2026



INDIA'S HOTTEST ENTREPRENEURS

After a decade of startup highs, hard lessons and funding swings,
BW 40 UNDER 40 features entrepreneurs and intrapreneurs building for the long run





Bisleri
greener
promise

At Bisleri, our purpose is to create a greener future for all.

Through our initiatives in recycling, conservation and sustainability, we are water positive and plastic neutral, promising to give back more to nature than we take.

For more information visit www.bisleri.com/greenerPromise

Presenting

The Kia Sorento

Global Icon. Reimagined for India.

Kia AI Assistant (Real-time Generative AI) | Hybrid & Diesel Powertrains | All-Wheel Drive with Terrain Modes | 6 & 7-Seater Options | ADAS Level 2+ with 30 Features & 10 Airbags

Introductory price starts at ₹ 27 99 000*



Movement that inspires

Scan to book
your Sorento



Book now

Call 1800 108 5005

Visit www.kia.com

Kia Sorento

Look for "Kia India" @

Kia Service
Connected • Adaptive • Responsive • Engage



Kia Care Network
Kia Genuine
Spare Parts



3 Years Unlimited km
Warranty
Extendable up to 5 Years*



24x7 Nationwide
Roadside Assistance*
My Convenience Plus



Smart Services
360° Digital
Experience*



Warranty on High Voltage
Battery (on Hybrid)
8 Years/ 1 60 000 km

*Terms & Conditions Apply. Ex-showroom price all India. The product & feature images shown in this ad is for representation purpose only. Features and specifications as shown may not be part of standard fitment and may vary.

INNOCEAN-032/26

THE TEST OF STAYING POWER



ANNURAG BATRA

✉ anurag.batra@businessworld.in

INDIA HAS SPENT the past decade celebrating initiatives — a promising idea, a first round of funding, an app that finds its users, a young company that challenges an established category — and every start has earned attention. The entrepreneurial energy behind them has widened the choices available to consumers and the ambitions open to a generation of Indians. The less visible work begins after the applause. Companies have to keep customers, earn their trust, manage capital and build teams capable of carrying the business through a difficult year. The past decade has witnessed successes worth admiring and failures worth studying. It has also demonstrated how quickly the terms on which capital is available can change. Growth matters, but so does the ability to support it.

That is the conundrum that this issue of *BW Businessworld* is wrapped around. As BW celebrates the tenth edition of 40 Under 40 achievers, we look at a generation whose opportunity is greater than simply launching something new. The next decade will ask them to create businesses with a reason to exist beyond a funding cycle, and to make decisions that hold up when conditions are less generous. A consumer brand, a mobility network and a company built around industrial technology face different tests. Each has to find a way to turn early conviction into lasting value. Durability does not mean playing safe. It can demand investment in research, entry into difficult markets and the courage to test a model when easy money retreats. The discipline lies in knowing which risks a business can afford to take.

This issue also makes room for intrapreneurs. Entrepreneurship is often associated with someone leaving an organisation to start another. Yet change can be just as demanding within a business that already has customers, people and established ways of working. Younger leaders who open a new category, rebuild a process or make an existing enterprise more competitive, carry an entrepreneurial responsibility of their own. They must persuade others to move with them while remaining accountable for what already works. This year's cohort draws achievers from different sectors and different kinds of organisations. We recognise their achievements so far without pretending that the recognition settles the question of what comes next. That will depend on the choices they make as leaders, especially when speed and discipline pull in different directions.

A decade of startup ambition has changed India's business landscape. The more consequential story may be how many of these ideas, ventures and renewed enterprises are still creating value ten years from today.



B-school Issue

- ▶ BW B-school Rankings & Survey 2026
- ▶ Trends in management education, employability, and pedagogy
- ▶ Expert views from academia and corporate leaders shaping next-gen

Block
your
pages...



**Ensure Your Brand's Presence in
this Special Issue!!!**

Aparna Sengupta, aparna@businessworld.in, +91 9958000128

Anjeet Trivedi, anjeet@businessworld.in, +91 9818122217

Ravi Khatri, ravi.khatri@businessworld.in, +91 9891315715

Somyajit Sengupta, somyajit@businessworld.in, +91 9818247444

Kiran Dedhia, kiran@businessworld.in, +91 9833399009

For Editorial:
Noor Fathima Warsia,
nfw@businessworld.in



To Subscribe Scan or Visit
subscribe.businessworld.in

BW BUSINESSWORLD

VOL. 45, ISSUE 25 ■ 03 OCTOBER 2026

GROUP CHAIRMAN & EDITOR-IN-CHIEF:

GROUP EDITORIAL DIRECTOR

Noor Fathima Warsia

MANAGING EDITOR: Palak Shah

EDITORIAL TEAM

Deputy Editors: Ashish Sinha, Jyotsna Sharma

Assistant Editor: Tarannum Manjul, Urvi Shrivastav

Principal Correspondent – Tech & Video Lead: Deep Majumdar

Sr. Correspondents: Sangeet Kumar Sanu

Regional Editor (Technology & South): Rohit Chintapali

Jr. Correspondents: Krishankant Chourasia, Kishan Singh

DESK TEAM

Deputy Editor: Mukul Rai

Associate Editors: Madhumita Chakraborty; Smita Kulshreshth

ART TEAM

Art Directors: Dinesh Banduni, Raja Mourya

Assistant Art Director: Rajinder Kumar

Manager – Design: Arun Kumar

Assistant Images Editor: Sanjay Jakhmola

PHOTO TEAM

Sr. Photo Researcher: Kamal Kumar

Photographer: Naval Kishor

VIDEO EDITORIAL TEAM

Video Team: Pappu Kumar Singh, Hitesh Singh

Senior Camera & Production Lead: Ratneshwar Kumar Singh

BW APPLAUSE & EVERYTHING EXPERIENTIAL: Ruhail Amin

BW AUTO WORLD: Utkarsh Agarwal

BW DISRUPT: Senior Editorial Lead: Resham Suhail

BW EDUCATION: Senior Copy Editor: Upasana, Correspondent: Shriya Mishra

BW HEALTHCARE WORLD & BW WELLBEING WORLD:

Assistant Manager-Industry Interaction & Conference Production: Sanjana Deb

Senior Editorial Lead: Kavi Bhandari, Jr. Correspondent: Arya Rakshita

BW HOTELIER: Editor: Saurabh Tankha, Sr. General Manager: Ajith Kumar LR

BW TRAVEL: Senior Correspondent: Palak Chawla

Jr. Correspondent: Kumud

BW MARKETING WORLD: Senior Editorial Lead: Reema Bhaduri, Soumya Sehgal

BW HINDI: Senior Correspondent: Ritu Rana

BW PEOPLE: Shibul Pavithran, Savi Khanna

BW LEGAL WORLD: Krishnendra Joshi

BW SECURITY WORLD: Asst. GM – Community & Editorial: Shilpa Chandel

BW POLICE WORLD: Ujjawala Nayudu

Dr. ANNURAG BATRA

CEO, BW COMMUNITIES

Bhuvanesh Khanna

CEO & CHIEF INNOVATION OFFICER

Hoshie Ghaswalla (CEO-BW Engage)

DIRECTOR: Prasara Sharma

GROUP PRESIDENT: Aparna Sengupta

GROUP SR. VICE PRESIDENT – STRATEGY, OPERATIONS & MARKETING

Tanvie Ahuja (tanvie@businessworld.in)

CEO, BW HEALTHCARE WORLD & BW WELLBEING WORLD:

Harbinder Narula

DIRECTOR SALES: Ravi Khatri

DIRECTOR BUSINESS & OPERATIONS: Vivek Mittal (BW Hotelier & BW Travel)

SALES TEAM:

NORTH: Anjeet Trivedi, Rajeev Chauhan, Somyajit Sengupta,

Abdulla Masum Mazumder, Agrata Nigam

WEST: Kiran Dedhia, Nilesh Argekar

BW COMMUNITIES BUSINESS LEADS/CURATORS

Priya Saraf (BW Education),

Chetan Mehra (BW Disrupt),

Priyanshi Khandelwal (BW Sustainability)

Sharon Verma (BW Main & BW People)

Devika Kundu Sengupta, (BW Wellbeing and Fintech)

Bilquis Naqvi (BW People)

Ashish Kumar (BW People)

Amit Bhasin (BW Hotelier & BW Travel)

MARKETING & DESIGN TEAM: Rahul Gupta, Mohd. Salman Ali, Rishabh Verma,

Moksha Khimasiya, Shweta Boyal, Mudit Tyagi, Arti Chhipa, Kumari Supriya

Manager – Design: Kuldeep Kumar

EVENTS TEAM

Tarun Ahuja, Akash Kumar Pandey, Anupama Agrawal, Atul Joshi, Kuldeep

Prajapati, Binita Burnwal, Madhav Prasad, Prashant Kumar, Biren Singho, Rakhi

Pathak, Pragya, Deepak Katoch, Parul Gupta, Vansh Sharma, Kavita Kumari,

Jyoti, Mahima Chauhary, Abhishek Singh Rathore, Chetna Malhotra, Rohit Arora

CIRCULATION TEAM

General Manager – Circulation, Subscription & Sales:

Vinod Kumar (vinod@businessworld.in)

NORTH: Vijay Kumar Mishra, Mukhtadir Malik, Kamlesh Prasad

WEST: Gorakshanath Sanap

SOUTH: Sarvothama Nayak K

Senior Manager (Production & Printing): Shiv Singh

FINANCE TEAM

Ankit Kumar, Ishwar Sharma, Shrikant Sharma, Vijay Jangra

IT SUPPORT: Brijender Wahal

ADMIN SUPPORT:

Executive Assistant to MD: Himani Saxena (himani.saxena@businessworld.in)

Executive: Aman Mishra (aman@businessworld.in)

GENERAL MANAGER-HR & ADMIN: Namrata Tripathi (namrata@businessworld.in)

LEGAL ADVISOR: Sudhir Mishra (Trust Legal)

BW Businessworld Media Private Limited

EDITORIAL OFFICES

BW Businessworld Media Pvt. Ltd.

74-75, Scindia House, Connaught Place,

New Delhi-110001

■ Phone: 9818063325

ADVERTISEMENT / CIRCULATION / SUBSCRIPTION ENQUIRIES

BW Businessworld Media Pvt. Ltd.

74-75, Scindia House, Connaught Place,

New Delhi-110001

■ Phone: 9818063325

SUBSCRIPTION SERVICE

Vinod Kumar +91 9810961195, vinod@businessworld.in, subscription@businessworld.in

Subscription rates: ONE YEAR - Rs 2,999 TWO YEARS - Rs 5,599 THREE YEARS - Rs 9,499

BW Businessworld does not accept responsibility for returning unsolicited manuscripts and photographs. All unsolicited material should be accompanied by self-addressed envelopes and sufficient postage. Published and printed by Annurag Batra for and on behalf of the owners, BW Businessworld Media Private Limited. Published at 74-75, Scindia House, Connaught Place, New Delhi-110001, and printed at Thomson Press India Limited. Editor : Annurag Batra.

© Reproduction in whole or in part without written permission of the publisher is prohibited. All rights reserved. R.N.I.No. 39847/81

BW APPLAUSE
www.bwapplause.com



PRESENT

#BWAplauseAwards

8th Edition

EXPERIENTIAL MARKETING

SUMMIT & AWARDS 2026

IN ASSOCIATION WITH

BW MARKETING
WORLD
www.bwmarketingworld.com

BW BUSINESSWORLD
www.businessworld.in

OCT 2026



Nominate Now !!!

JURY PANEL



DR. ANNURAG BATRA
Chairman & Editor-in-Chief,
BW Businessworld, & Founder,
exchange4media



SHEKHAR SAURABH
Head Marketing,
TATA AIG General Insurance



RAJIV DUBEY
Vice President Marketing,
Dabur India



PRIYANKA SETHI
Director & Head Marketing,
Haier Appliances India



KARUN ARORA
General Manager & Head
Marketing Communications,
Vivo India



BINDU DEY
Group CMO,
Knight Rider Sports



SHEENA KAPOOR
Head Marketing
Corp Comms & CSR,
ICICI Lombard



ISHITA GROVER
Marketing Director,
OnePlus



JASMEET SINGH
Deputy General Manager -
Cardiovascular & Diabetes,
Lupin



RAGHUVVEER SINGH
Vice President Social Media &
Content Marketing - India &
Global, ZEE5



ANUJ SOMANI
Senior Marketing Manager -
Brand, Retailer, Digital & PR,
Volvo Car India



AKASH MISHRA
AVP - Group Brand Marketing,
Donear Group



PRATIP FRANCIS
GM - Brand Marketing,
MRF Tyres



ABHINAV IYER
Chief General Manager -
Marketing & Strategy,
The Muthoot Group



APURVA JANI
Marketing Director,
Intel



GERALD MARTIN JOSEPH
Senior General Manager -
Marketing, Aachi Masala food



SAARTHAK SETHI
Sr. Vice President - Marketing,
Tata Realty & Infrastructure



RAJ KIRAN
SVP - Marketing,
Ujjivan Small Finance Bank



JANANI KANDASWAMY
Head Marketing,
Pickyourtrail



PUNEET KUSUMBIA
Vice President Marketing,
Heritage Food



SONAL BHARTI
Deputy Director Marketing-
Offline Brands, Myntia



KARAN KUMAR
Chief Marketing Officer,
Hero Realty



SUJOY JAIN
Sr. Manager Head - Brand &
Marketing, Air India Express



VIDHI ATTRI
Head-Marketing,
Elan Group

EVENT PARTNERS



For more information, please contact:

Vansh Sharma, **+91 7037789202**, vansh.sharma@businessworld.in



MAILBOX

YOUR COMMENTS

GROWTH IN THE PREMIUM SEGMENT

This refers to the editorial (“**Housing’s Great Squeeze**,” BW, September 19). The author rightly identifies that India’s housing market appears to be undergoing a structural shift, with growth increasingly concentrated in the premium segment. JLL’s Q1 2026 data showed residential sales rising 8 per cent year-on-year to 70,631 units. However, the headline growth figure masked a significant divergence across price categories. Sales of homes priced above Rs 1 crore grew 30 per cent, while sales of properties below Rs 1 crore declined 24 per cent. ANAROCK’s Q2 data points to a similar trend in the supply landscape. Homes priced between Rs 80 lakh and Rs 1.5 crore accounted for the largest share of new supply, at 27 per cent, followed by properties in the Rs 1.5–2.5 crore bracket at 25 per cent and homes priced above Rs 2.5 crore at 22 per cent.

JUHI MEHTA, EMAIL

MDR MAKES A COMEBACK

This refers to the editorial (“**A Decade Of UPI**,” BW, September 19). The article highlights a significant shift in the economics of India’s digital payments ecosystem, with the government opening the legal pathway for selectively imposing charges on merchant transactions after years of zero-cost UPI payments. The re-emergence of the Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) in policy discussions marks a turning point in the financial sustainability of the UPI ecosystem. The proposed framework seeks to balance two objectives: preserving UPI’s accessibility for consumers while creating a revenue pathway for payment ecosystem participants.

KIRAN CHAUHAN, EMAIL

TALKBACK

Submissions to BW Businessworld

should include the writer’s name and address and be sent by email to the editor at editor@businessworld.in or by mail to 74-75, Scindia House, Connaught Place, New Delhi-110001

**BLIPP
THIS PAGE
TO GIVE US
YOUR FEEDBACK
INSTANTLY**



3rd EDITION

#BWHealthcare30Under30



**NOMINATE
NOW**

OUR JURY MEMBERS

OCTOBER 2026, NEW DELHI

Co-Jury Chair



DR. VIJAY AGARWAL
President,
CAHO



DR. ANNURAG BATRA
Chairman & Editor-in-Chief,
BW Businessworld & Founder,
exchange4media



DR. KARAN THAKUR
Vice President, Corporate Affairs &
Sustainability, Apollo Hospitals
Enterprise



DR. ANUPAM SACHDEVA
Chairman, Dept. of Pediatrics & Director,
Pediatric Hemato-Oncology & BMT,
Sir Ganga Ram Hospital



DR. SUNIL KHETARPAL
Deputy Director General
AIPI



VISHAL LATHWAL
CEO,
Apollo Homcare



CAPT BOBBY RAMESH
Group Director Nursing
Excellence,
Sarvodaya Healthcare



DR. INDU BANSAL AGGARWAL
Group Director & HOD, Radiation
Oncology, Paras Health,
Gurgaon



DR. RAVI GAUR
Chairman, Medical Advisory
Committee Oncquest Laboratories
Ltd. & Founder, DRG Path Lab



RAJIT MEHTA
MD & CEO,
Antara Senior Care.



DR. SHARAN SHIVARAJ PATIL
Chairman and Chief Orthopedic
Surgeon of SPARSH Group of
Hospitals, Bangalore



DR. TANVI CHAWLA
Country Manager,
OSSEOLABS



HARBINDER NARULA
CEO, BW Healthcare World,
BW Wellbeing World &
BW Pharma World

EVENT PARTNERS



For Nominations Opportunity:
Rakhi Pathak
+91 9870405465,
rakhi.pathak@businessworld.in

For Speaking Opportunity:
Sanjana Deb
+91 8910172015,
sanjana@businessworld.in

For Sponsorship Opportunities:
Harbinder Narula
+91 9911773666
harbinder@businessworld.in

CONTENTS

VOLUME 45, ISSUE 25 ■ 03 OCTOBER 2026



AI Created Representation

16 Jottings

Prices are rising and not just of food; India's firepower; One grid, one clock; Now comes the execution test, and more

18 Columns

Vikas Singh (p. 18); Krishan Kalra (p. 20); Raghav Chandra (p. 24); Amit Kapoor & Meenakshi Ajith (p. 28); Srinath Sridharan (p. 30); Sunandan Bhanja Choudhary (p. 32); Kiran Karnik (p. 35)

39 Ad Infinitum

How turning Vi's latest campaign into lasting brand equity will depend on delivering a product experience that lives up to the promise

40 Impromptu

Martin Sorrell, Executive Chairman, S4Capital/ Monks on why the top line

is now the central test, how Monks. Flow should drive growth and why S4 must achieve greater scale in India

42 In Conversation

Lupin's Ramesh Swaminathan on the capital allocation framework behind the company's GLP-1 licensing deals, the Kaveri Therapeutics spin-out, appetite for specialty M&A, and more

46 Scaling Ambition

How Saint-Gobain India is scaling glass, gypsum and insulation capacity while building an export and innovation hub

40 UNDER 40 PROFILES

54 Abhimanyu Asija, Sommet Group

55 Abhinav Parashar, Digio

56 Adwaita Nayar, Nykaa

50

India's Hottest Entrepreneurs

The 10th edition of BW Disrupt 40 Under 40 puts the spotlight on the founders driving India's next wave of entrepreneurial growth

Cover design by DINESH S BANDUNI

58 Akis Evangelidis, Nothing
59 Ambrish Miyani, Indo Era
60 Ankita Aditya Parakh, Ashoka Health City
61 Ankur Tyagi, Rosier Foods
62 Ashonal Clery Pereira, Mancunianz
63 Avinash Chenreddy, Constelli Signals
64 Bhuman Dani, WickedGud
65 Binnita Shah, Venbridge Real Estate Advertising
66 Dhruv Sayani, Ccigmaa Lifestyle
67 Hamza Patel, AP Group
68 Harday Gupta, The Right PR
70 Himanshu Ratnoo, EMotorad
71 Keshav Bhajanka, Century Plyboards
72 Kritika Singh, HiVoco
73 Mangesh Zope, Peaceful Loans
74 Mohit Gulyani, RexEdge
75 Niharika Joshi, Cumin Co.
76 Nitin Vinod Kalra, Let's Try
77 Piyush Goyal, Volks Energie
78 Priyam Parikh, Gujarat Tea Processors & Packers
79 Ragini Varma, Fynd
80 Rishikesh SR, Rapido
81 Saloni Satish Wagh, Supriya Lifescience
82 Shreya Verma, Skills Caravan
84 Sneha Shah, Aimtron Electronics
85 Sneha Sharma, Dogsee
86 Sneha Roy, Murf AI
87 Sridhar Sampathirao, Thoucentric
88 Swati Babel, Globizera Services FZCO
89 Taranjit Shah Singh, Berry Brothers



90 Uplaksh Tewary, Campus Activewear
91 Varun Karad, REnergy Dynamics

92 Varun Kumar Modi, Bright Money

93 Vijay Kumar Gond, PeakAmp

94 Vinayak Bhavnani, Chalo Mobility

95 Viraj Sheth, Monk Entertainment

120 Creativity den

Sabyasachi's new 26,000 ft Mehrauli space which feels as much museum as store

125

Last Word

Commvault's Sanjay Mirchandani on why AI strategy is moving into the boardroom, the growing risks around non-human identities and why resilience needs to be built into AI systems from day one



TOTAL NO. OF PAGES INCLUDING COVER 128

The pages in BW Businessworld that are labelled BWi or Promotions contain sponsored content. They are entirely generated by an advertiser or the marketing department of BW Businessworld. Also, the inserts being distributed along with some copies of the magazine are advertorials / advertisements. These pages should not be confused with BW Businessworld's editorial content.

#BWPeopleHRvoices

READY TO LEVEL UP YOUR HR GAME?

Bringing the HR industry's heavy hitters straight to you

TOTAL VIBES
NO FLUFF
NO JARGON

We're talking unfiltered chats, game-changing strategies and the real-talk you need to stay ahead of the curve

FRESH EPISODES
DROPPING WEEKLY



Scan to watch on
YOUTUBE



Scan to follow on
LINKEDIN

SPILL
THE TEA WITH
**SAVI
KHANNA**



CANDID
CONVERSATIONS
WITH
**BILQUIS
NAQVEE**



**LAURA
LINDEMAN**
SENIOR DIRECTOR &
HEAD OF WORK
IN FINLAND UNIT,
BUSINESS FINLAND



**DR SANJEEV
RASTOGI**
CEO - ADANI GLOBAL
CAPABILITY CENTRE



**PROF MUKTI
KANTA MISHRA**
CO-FOUNDER -
CENTURION UNIVERSITY
OF TECHNOLOGY
& MANAGEMENT



**KRISTEN
SOLER**
EVP & CHRO
ADVANCE AUTO PARTS



**RAJAT
SINHA**
MD & HEAD OF HR,
BNP PARIBAS,
INDIA & PHILIPPINES GCC



**PROF
D. N. RAO**
CO-FOUNDER & VP,
CENTURION UNIVERSITY
OF TECHNOLOGY
AND MANAGEMENT



**AMITESH
OSTA**
CHRO
MRG GROUP



**KABILAN
JAYATHUNGAN**
CHRO
L&T SEMICONDUCTOR
TECHNOLOGIES



**SMRITI
MATHUR**
VP, PEOPLE INDIA &
GLOBAL TALENT ADVISORY,
PEGASYSTEMS



**PRIYANKA
ANAND**
VP AND HEAD OF HR FOR
SOUTH EAST ASIA,
OCEANIA AND INDIA, ERICSSON

Prices are Rising and Not Just of Food

Photograph by Saraanees98765



INFLATION, IT SEEMS, has decided that its brief summer holiday is over. The Consumer Price Index (CPI) rose to 4.8 per cent in August 2026 from 4.5 per cent in July, with pressures broadening across food and non-food categories. Chief Economist at CRISIL, D.K. Joshi, says the resurgence warrants attention, particularly as food inflation could remain under pressure amidst uneven rainfall during this Monsoon season.

The concern has shifted from acreage to productivity, with cotton, pearl millet (*bajra*), maize, pigeon pea (*tur* or *arhar*), groundnut and soybean among crops facing elevated rainfall risks. Add a high-base statistical effect and the food basket suddenly looks considerably less comfortable. External pressures are hardly helping. Joshi expects Brent crude at \$88-93 a barrel in FY2027, translating into a 25 per cent to 32 per cent annual rise. Higher energy costs are already spreading through the economy, with the wholesale price index reaching 9.9 per cent in August and core inflation rising to 4.2 per cent from 3.9 per cent.

Aditi Nayar, Chief Economist, ICRA, expects food and beverages inflation to cross seven per cent by October, pushing headline CPI above five per cent in September and towards six per cent in October-November. She sees a possible rate hike in December, with an earlier move in October should crude remain elevated and fuel prices rise. With food, fuel and geopolitics pulling in the same direction, is inflation preparing to become the RBI's monitoring pricing committee's (MPC's) newest headache?

—Ashish Sinha

India's Firepower

INDIA'S DEFENCE story is becoming difficult to ignore. Domestic production touched a record Rs 1.8 lakh crore in FY2026, rising 15.6 per cent year-on-year, while exports jumped 63 per cent to about Rs 0.38 lakh crore. A recent report by Emkay Global Financial Services says the sector is moving from import dependence towards indigenous manufacturing, technology and exports.

The government has set its sights higher: Rs 3 lakh crore of production and Rs 0.5 lakh crore of exports by FY2029. More than 80 countries now buy Indian defence products, while 3,025 of 5,012 items on indigenisation lists have shifted to domestic production.

The money trail is muscular. Of the Rs 1.4 lakh crore modernisation budget for FY2027, 75 per cent is earmarked

for domestic industry. Private players accounted for 24 per cent of production in FY2026, up from 22 per cent, with about Rs 0.347 lakh crore of capital acquisition earmarked for private industry. Private capability is no longer confined to build-to-print work. Indian companies are moving into

build-to-specification, build-to-design and build-to-requirements roles, while developing lead-system-integrator capabilities spanning complex platforms, systems integration, sensors, electronics, aerospace and unmanned technologies.

That broadens their role from suppliers to partners in designing and delivering systems. The order pipeline is shy: 55 proposals worth Rs 6.8 lakh crore received

Acceptance of Necessity, while contracts worth Rs 2.3 lakh crore were signed in FY2026. With exports, technology and private capacity rising together, can execution match this ambition?

—Ashish Sinha



Photograph courtesy: PIB

One Grid, One Clock

INDIA'S PUSH TO MAKE Indian Standard Time (IST) the common reference for critical infrastructure may sound like a matter of synchronising clocks, but for the power sector it could mean another round of modernisation. More than 20 crore smart meters have been sanctioned under the government's distribution reform programme and over seven crore installed. Add to these SCADA systems, Phasor

Measurement Units, disturbance recorders, digital substations and control centres, and the grid is already producing enormous volumes of time-stamped data. As renewables, batteries and distributed generation make electricity flows more complex, knowing precisely when an event occurred becomes critical to determining which device tripped first, reconstructing faults and comparing measurements across locations. Newer equipment may need little more than configuration or firmware changes to align with a common timing architecture; older equipment may require additional hardware, retrofits or replacement.

There is a security dimension too. An increasingly digital grid depends on accurately sequenced logs to identify failures and investigate cyberattacks; clocks that disagree can make events appear in the wrong order. Utilities will also need backup mechanisms against failures, jamming or spoofing of their primary timing source. The immediate challenge, therefore, may be less glamorous than buying new technology: utilities first need to know exactly what they already have. But that audit could reveal the scale of the opportunity for equipment manufacturers and grid-technology providers. India has spent years building towards One Nation, One Grid. Making that grid digital, automated and secure may increasingly require One Grid, One Clock.

— Urvi Shrivastav



Photograph by Esolex

Now Comes the Execution Test

INDIA'S semiconductor story has now entered a more consequential phase. For the last five years, the conversation was dominated by ambition: policy incentives, proposed fabs and the promise of becoming a global chip hub. At Semicon India 2026, the focus and debate was noticeably different. The all-important 'ecosystem' talk is beginning to happen. The first fab remains a work in progress. But now the packaging, assembly, testing, materials, equipment, design and training deals will work to create the foundations around it. Global companies are expanding their engineering and manufacturing presence, while Indian companies are beginning to push designs and products towards commercialisation.

This matters because a semiconductor industry cannot be built around a fab alone. It needs suppliers that can meet



Photograph by Awaissehar5

global standards, customers willing to qualify locally made products and companies capable of becoming indispensable in specific parts of the value chain. This is where India's next test lies. Government spending can catalyse capacity, but it cannot manufacture demand. Fujifilm's investment for a chip materials plant at Dholera, Everspin's push to understand Indian demand for Magnetoresistive Random Access Memory (MRAM), ASML assessing Indian presence, Sandisk's call for an Indian IT-equipment ecosystem and SEMI chief Ajit Manocha's call on ecosystem strength, point to the same challenge: India must create customers alongside capacity.

The semiconductor race is, therefore, no longer simply about just building factories. It never was. It is about proving that those factories can plug into a competitive, commercially sustainable ecosystem.

— Rohit Chintapali

THE SECOND CONVERSION: FROM ECONOMIC GROWTH TO A MASS MIDDLE CLASS



The author is an economist and columnist

INDIA HAS LEARNT HOW to produce growth. It has yet to learn how to produce a middle class.

Its economy is among the world's fastest-growing, yet its middle class is not expanding at anything like the same pace. That contradiction explains more about India's future than another quarter of seven per cent GDP growth. Economic debate remains trapped between two narratives. One celebrates rapid growth, record GST collections, expanding infrastructure and rising formal employment.

The other points to subdued consumer demand, stagnant real wages and financial pressure on households. Both are accurate because they measure different parts of the economy. The GDP measures what India produces. Prosperity depends on what Indian households earn.

Mind the Gap

For three decades, India's challenge was straightforward: convert investment into growth. Liberalisation, infrastructure, digital public goods and macroeconomic stability largely solved that problem.

The supply side has strengthened dramatically. A different conversion has become the new constraint. India must now convert economic growth into middle-class households.

Countries become prosperous when

rising output expands the number of families able to save, buy homes, educate children, accumulate financial assets and consume beyond necessity. That expansion creates domestic demand and turns growth into economic security.

The Missing Middle

The first warning sign appears not in GDP data but in earnings. Labour-market analysis suggests that nearly 70 per cent of employed workers earn less than India's own per-capita income. The economy has therefore become richer faster than the average worker, with national income rising ahead of household earnings across much of the workforce.

This is usually framed as an inequality problem. It is more fundamentally a demand problem. A worker earning close to subsistence spends almost every additional rupee on necessities. A middle-class worker has room to buy a home, vehicle, insurance, consumer durables and financial products. Higher and more predictable income also makes long-term borrowing possible. Economies that successfully expanded domestic demand first expanded this income band.

India's consumption pattern reflects the gap. Premium products remain resilient because affluent households have purchasing power and accumulated wealth. Essential goods continue to sell because households cannot postpone them. The broad middle is where demand remains fragile, particularly in volume-driven categories. Consumer companies often describe this as weak confidence. But confidence cannot compensate for inadequate purchasing power.

Confidence is not the constraint. Income is.

Jobs That Don't Build Consumers

India is creating jobs, but too many are in sectors where wages rise slowly. Delivery platforms, contract staffing, logistics, security services and fragmented retail absorb millions, yet offer

India's growth story is incomplete: millions have jobs, but too few are earning enough to become confident middle-class consumers

limited progression. Employment growth alone does not create a consuming middle class.

A software engineer, delivery rider and security guard each count as one employed worker, but their economic capacity differs sharply. The engineer is more likely to qualify for a home loan, buy a car, invest through SIPs and spend on education. A delivery rider with uncertain earnings has far less capacity for such commitments. What matters for consumption is whether work delivers predictable income growth.

South Korea's industrialisation succeeded because factory wages rose alongside productivity, turning agricultural workers into middle-class consumers within a generation. China achieved a similar transformation through export manufacturing, lifting hundreds of millions into higher-income households. India followed a different route, moving towards services before manufacturing created comparable numbers of middle-income jobs. Its IT, financial services and pharmaceutical sectors gener-

workers. Future GDP growth could therefore become increasingly detached from middle-class formation.

The Metric That Matters Now

India's employment debate should move beyond how many jobs are created to how many workers cross into middle-income earnings each year. Employment without income mobility reduces poverty, but does not build a mass consumer economy.

Formalisation without wage progression expands payrolls without expanding purchasing power. Growth without middle-class formation raises output while leaving domestic demand weaker than headline GDP suggests.

That conversion requires more than job creation. India needs labour-intensive manufacturing, apprenticeships and industry-linked skilling that move workers into higher-wage occupations. It also needs a lighter tax and compliance burden as lower-income workers enter the formal economy. The objective should be explicit: productivity growth must translate into faster wage growth and greater household purchasing power.

The next phase of India's development will therefore be judged by this conversion. Growth must produce higher household incomes, stronger consumption and a broader middle class. When that chain breaks, the economy becomes larger without becoming proportionately more prosperous.

Middle Class, First Class

India's first economic success was learning how to create growth. Its second will be learning how to create a middle class. Until growth creates millions more economically secure households, India's rise will remain larger than its prosperity.

An economy becomes developed not when it produces more billionaires, but when it produces millions more families that stop worrying about next month's bills. **BW**

AI-Created Representation



ate high productivity but employ relatively few workers. Millions remain in low-productivity services where earnings rise slowly. The result is employment without sufficient income mobility.

The New Constraint

This explains why GDP alone has become an increasingly misleading measure of development.

India is no longer constrained primarily by capital, technology or infrastructure. Corporate balance sheets have strengthened and public investment has accelerated. The larger constraint is converting these gains into broad-based household income.

Artificial intelligence may widen the gap. Earlier technological waves created millions of middle-income jobs. Artificial intelligence promises larger productivity gains, but may generate more output without comparable numbers of middle-income

LET ME START WITH the first quarter (Q1) 7.8 per cent GDP growth and the recent inflow of over \$136 billion. Notwithstanding some inevitable criticism both these are a matter of pride for all, including our diehard Opposition leaders. The fact that this has happened while the United States-Iran war is on makes the achievement greater.

Then there's the news of the Iranian president seeking our PM's help in ending the war. Recent speech of the Belgian PM at CII is another glorious endorsement and his country's eagerness for multiple collaborations with us should be of great help. In the past we have only had hectoring from Europe on human rights and moral grounds. Sunday 30 August *New York Times* report about Modi's multiple outreach trips resulting in partnerships — Submarine Tech with Germany, AI with France, Norway for job creation projects, South Korea building ship here ... to mention just a few — is also a huge morale booster.

Equally heartening is the recent upgrade of our sovereign rating from BBB+ to 'A', by the Japan Credit Rating Agency. Our first 'A' since 1988 — A2 by Moody's — is a wonderful achievement as it tells the investors 'not to miss the bus and not just 'OK to invest''. Sadly, the 1988 vote of confidence turned out to be sour as we stumbled into the BOP crisis in 1990-91; but the lesson is clear: reputations once lost aren't regained easily — it took us 35 years to do so!

More Signs of Hope

A couple of months ago the Hyderabad based startup Skyroot shocked the world by launching its Vikram-1 rocket, placing multi payloads into a low earth orbit. As if on its heels, the government and ISRO have decided to transfer technology to other private enterprises and biggies like L&T, JSW and Adani are already planning submitting expressions of interest (EoIs). We should



IRONIES OF INDIA: Pride, Hope and Shame

soon see advanced space works in the private sector — generally considered 'risk averse players'.

The last few months have witnessed a frenzy in the initial public offerings (IPOs) scene, indicating a great appetite of individuals and the investment community as also their faith in the domestic corporate sector. JP Morgan's global chair of investment banking sees great prospects for India attracting international capital!

In an entirely different sector, local firm Sula Vineyards & Resorts reported that they are hosting an astonishing 400,000 visitors each year and their wine tourism business revenue has crossed Rs 100 crores. Not to be left behind, the other big wine maker Grover Zampa is seeking technology from Germany to make their vineyards move from 'reactive farming to predictive' so they can better face climate change challenges!

Even though India's own consumption of wine is less than one per cent of total alcoholic beverages, our vineyards are growing at a healthy 25 per cent CAGR — giving a boost to exports in a highly sensitive market against established wine makers like France, Italy, Spain, the US and Chile. Coffee



chain Blue Tokai, started just 13 years ago — and a strong competitor to Starbucks India — is drawing the interest of investors like Tamasek & Chrys Capital for their expansion into Japan and the United Arab Emirates.

Strong censure of governance issues at India's largest private bank HDFC is also a sign of hope. So are the intensive FDA audits and the apex court ① pulling up overzealous lawyers trying to influence NALSAR students or quashing FIRs lodged during the recent stir by students ② ordering investigation of liquor warehouses in Gurgaon over financial records, custom's dues and fire safety certificates.

Hopefully they will also audit their quality and whether they are palming off anything spurious ③ suspending jail sentence of a U-tuber despite his having criticized the judiciary ④ their concern about recurring damage to the Aravalli's eco system ⑤ scathing remarks over project deviations by the

country's biggest developer — all actions focussed on matters that concern society. A recent observation by the top court says "Poverty, inequality, illiteracy and the discriminatory environment in which a child grows trigger delinquency in minors". The epic comments hit the nail on the head, bringing centerstage the absence of good early value education.

The Delhi government's offer to install free rooftop solar panels for lower middle-class houses is praiseworthy. Even in case of the shameful incident of a young girl's rape in a running bus, immediate action by the police and arrest of the culprits is a sign of hope on the law and order front. Equally inspiring is the Haryana police commissioner seeking public feedback in decisions about station house officer (SHO) postings. Also

Our country has always been known for its ironies. As children we learnt that we had built steel plants and big dams but had to import staple pins! Even now there are issues — some make our chest swell with pride, some raise hope and yet others make us hang our heads in shame. Let me share a few ironies and we must address the shameful ones for achieving our cherished goal of becoming a 'developed country'

Our international athletes regularly failing dope tests is another serious matter and a slur on our sporting ambitions.

Mumbai civic body trying to appropriate the little spaces in the city where children play football is another matter of deep concern. And what about our potholed and perennially flooded roads in cities like Delhi and mounds of garbage everywhere estate?

marvelous was the recent news about a Maharashtra teacher trekking five km daily, through dense forest, just to ensure that two poor girls in his government school won't miss classes and another one about three Karnataka teachers reviving a century-old school shut down by the government. Check dams in Ladakh to improve water availability and economy of Ladakh is yet another good step to bring the region closer to the national mainstream.

And the Shame

But where do we hide in shame over the sexual assault on a three-and-a-half year-old boy at a play school or the overall pathetic state of our primary schools — operating under tin sheds, in parking lots, over a hundred students packed in one room, schools running with just one teacher and thousands of schools closing down. Why do we forget that we are playing with our future? Without a good foundational value education, we will only raise a generation of ruffians and rogues.

One feels proud to learn about young Pragg convincingly defeating last year's world champion but also ashamed to learn about perpetual grant of furlough to a convicted Baba in Haryana! Our international athletes regularly failing dope tests is another serious matter and



Photograph courtesy: PIB

a slur on our sporting ambitions. Mumbai civic body trying to appropriate the little spaces in the city where children play football is another matter of deep concern. And what about our potholed and perennially flooded roads in cities like Delhi and mounds of garbage everywhere not far from arguably the world's finest real estate? How can we justify the unfortunate case of a Kota girl who visited AIIMS for a congenital heart condition — since she was two — for 13 years and finally died early September 2026 or women giving birth outside hospitals and primary healthcare centres?

There are many such ironies and we have to start ensuring that happenings that make us feel ashamed must stop. Even at the cost of repetition, may I suggest much greater, mission-mode, emphasis on basic primary education is absolutely non-negotiable and this is bound to help the psyche and mindset of our children — future of the country — to become better citizens with civic sense, rational thinking and empathy. **BW**

The author is a former president, AIMA and a former member of the BoG, IIMC, Kolkata

BW BUSINESSWORLD

HealthNext

INDIA

AWARDS

HEALTHCARE IN MOTION

INNOVATION • ADAPTION • IMPACT

1ST DECEMBER 2026
NEW DELHI



#BWHealthNXTAwards

JURY PANEL

**DR. ANNURAG
BATRA**

Chairman &
Editor-in-Chief,
BW Businessworld,
& Founder,
exchange4media



**DR. SUNIL
KHETARPAL**

Deputy Director
General,
Association of
Healthcare
Providers of India



**DR. K MADAN
GOPAL**

Advisor,
Public Health
Administration



**DR. AMRIT
GUPTA**

Additional
Professor,
SGPGIMS,
Lucknow



**DR. RAMANAND
N. SHUKLA**

CEO,
NABH



**DR. SUNITA
MAHESHWARI**

Board Member,
GSK



**DR. HARSH
MAHAJAN**

Founder,
Mahajan Imaging



**DR. RAVI
GAUR**

Director & Chair
Medical Advisory
Committee,
Oncquest
Laboratories Ltd.



**DR. UMA
NAMBIAR**

Chairperson,
DHIndia
Association



**NOOR FATHIMA
WARSIA**

Group Editorial
Director
BW Businessworld



**SCAN TO
NOMINATE NOW!**

EVENT PARTNERS



For Nominations :

Shreya Narang, +91 8630209691,
shreya.narang@businessworld.in

Why Infrastructure Quality is more Important than Quantity



NO DOUBT THERE HAS BEEN a huge expansion in Indian infrastructure stock. This has also been appreciated globally. But, the continuous occurrence of structural shortcomings, even during the early days of a project's delivery, is a matter of grave concern. Incidents of surface slippage, cracks, subsidence and potholes have been reported widely in the mega-budget, newly commissioned Lucknow-Kanpur Expressway and Ganga Expressway, and earlier the Delhi-Dehradun and Delhi-Mumbai Expressways. All of them had been inaugurated with spectacular fanfare. The monetary loss may be counted in crores, but the ensuing trust deficit between citizens and the government is profound.

Vikramshila Setu Near Bhagalpur

On the night of 3 May 2026, a 33 metre slab of the Vikramshila Setu near Bhagalpur gave way in two stages, splitting a 4.7-kilometre structure into two and cutting off the shortest link between south and north Bihar. Commuters were forced onto a 161-kilometre detour, then onto boats, until the Army and the Border Roads Organisation could throw together a Bailey bridge. A key part of the Aguwani to Sultanganj bridge collapsed, not once, but three times — in three consecutive years, between 2022 and 2024. In May 2025, a reinforced earth (RE) wall failed on the Ramanattukara-Valanchery stretch of NH-66 in Kerala as the project neared completion. In August 2025, a hundred-metre protection wall on the Chakki bridge corridor between Himachal Pradesh and Punjab — built some months earlier — came apart. Two months later, a 9.4-metre RE wall approach to a vehicular underpass collapsed at Mylakkadu on NH-66. In April 2026, the carriageway settled near an RE wall underpass on NH-32 in Tamil Nadu.

Even the Railways have their share of problems, only fewer because they have, over several decades, built better systems of quality assurance. The recent collapse between Thakurwadi and Monkey Hill on Central Railway's (CR) Bhor Ghat sec-

tion caused unprecedented damage. Nearly 50-60m of railway line between the two locations was washed away, leading to the cancellation of around 30 trains.

Not Scattered Bad Luck

These are not cases of scattered bad luck. The causes for such breakages can be identified as: inadequate geotechnical investigation, ground improvement measures that were skipped, drainage provisions that cannot cope with monsoon saturation, reinforced-soil wall technology deployed in terrain that it was never suited for, and a supervisory architecture so diffused between designers, concessionaires, independent engineers and NHAI's own field staff that when something goes wrong, no one is quite sure whose failure it was.

It is tempting to treat each collapse as a local story — a bridge here, a wall there — and move on once the debris is cleared. Every rupee spent rebuilding a wall, a carriageway or a bridge span that should never have failed in the first place, is a rupee not spent creating new infrastructure or maintaining what al-



AI Created Representation

It is tempting to treat each collapse as a local story — a bridge here, a wall there — and move on once the debris is cleared. Every rupee spent rebuilding a wall, a carriageway or a bridge span that should never have failed in the first place, is a rupee not spent creating new infrastructure or maintaining what already exists. It is also a rupee spent twice — once to build and then once to rebuild

ready exists. It is also a rupee spent twice — once to build and then once to rebuild. Add to this the indirect costs like diverted freight, lost productivity from hours-long detours, the fishing boats now doing the work bridges were meant to replace. Most importantly, the slow erosion of the government's own brand.

The Technical Backbone of Projects

Industry voices will point to the incentive problem instead of the genuine technical one: that quality suffers because government tenders are awarded to the lowest bidder — that nobody is willing to spurn this for fear of scrutiny from auditors and investigative agencies. It is indeed true that contractors who win projects with unsustainably low bids have only one place to recover margin — by cutting corners on materials, ground investigation, and workmanship — the very inputs that determine whether an RE wall or a bridge survives its first monsoon. Sometimes, sub-contracts are made to other parties that have the acumen to martial huge legal claims to compensate for the shortfall. But that alone is not good enough reason.

Detailed Project Reports and ground assessments are the technical backbone of every project. Often they are rehashed from earlier projects with little adaptation to the specific geology, water table or flood history of a new site or are mere desk-top reports. Independent engineers, whose function is to catch these gaps before concrete is poured, often lack either the experience, authority or incentive to hold up a project over what appears to be trivial — an incorrect soil report, an imperfect alignment or design issue. They are prone to be inefficient and poorly-staffed when selected on low bids. After a structure is built, transfer of ownership leaves the project with successor agencies, not always well-versed with the past problems encountered by that project during its construction.

The remedies are neither exotic nor expensive relative to the losses at stake. In-



Photographs by Manoejp7

Government must ensure that they get the best out of their contractors. It is important to keep the eligibility and qualification bar sufficiently high rather than to succumb to the populist temptation to relax the criterion merely to encourage small players to participate in bids. Weak contractors, if selected, have to be supervised carefully and provided a helping hand within the parameters of legality — rather than be allowed to flounder and fail; the loss is ultimately the government's

dependent, mandatory design vetting is a must for RE walls and bridge structures, informed by confirmatory soil investigation and at least a decade of monsoon and flood data rather than routine DPR-stage assumptions. Field and laboratory testing of settlement and drainage at defined milestones are needed, not left to visual inspection. Deterrent accountability for design consultants is required when their geotechnical assumptions turn out to be wrong. Empanelled, technically qualified specialist agencies for RE wall execution should be deployed if the original contractors lack that expertise. A structural-health monitoring and maintenance regime is necessary for the thousands of bridges and walls already standing. A well-built structure left unmaintained for two decades will fail just as surely as a poorly built one does after its opening.

Eligibility and Qualification Bar

The government must ensure that they get the best out of their contractors. It is important to keep the eligibility and qualification bar sufficiently high rather than to succumb to the populist temptation to relax the criterion merely to encourage small players to participate in bids. Weak contractors, if selected, have to be supervised carefully and provided a helping hand within the parameters of legality — rather than be allowed to flounder and fail; the loss is ultimately the government's. Agencies adept in testing and retesting of structural designs should be enlisted to undertake scrupulous scrutiny of projects, even at government expense.

Most critically, India should stop taking pride and glorifying the speed of building infrastructure. Beyond optics, in deference to our *Viksit Bharat* goal, we should, instead, find satisfaction in quality over quantity, durability over appearance and effectiveness over expediency. **BW**

The author is a former Secretary, GoI and a former Chairman, NHAI



NOMINATE NOW

#BWPeopleHR40Under40



Celebrating Top 40 Under 40
in Human Resources

#BWPeopleHR30Under30



JURY MEMBERS



Dr Annurag Batra
Chairman & Editor-in-Chief,
BW Businessworld &
Founder, exchange4media



Ganesh Baliga
Head
Citi Solutions Center, India



**Sanjeev Kumar
Gupta**
CEO, Karnataka Digital
Economy Mission (KDEM)



Veda Persad
Head of Service Level
Governance & Reporting,
Country Executive, India,
Northern Trust



Madhavi Lall
Managing Director,
Head HR India,
Deutsche Bank



Raja Jamalamadaka
Managing Director,
Roche Digital Center of
Excellence, India



Ramkumar Narayanan
EVP, AI Technology Enablement,
Head of India &
The Philippines, FIS



Jaideep Agarwal
India GBS Leader,
Warner Bros. Discovery



John Dawber
Vice President &
Managing Director,
Novo Nordisk GBS, India



Krishna Kumar
Managing Director, Harman India
& SrVP India Business &
Automotive R&D Country Lead



Rajesh Mani
Managing Director,
Citizens Financial
Group India GCC



Atul Chanani
Head of Global Finance,
Citi India GCC



Kamal Sharma
Global Connected Hubs
Leader & CSAME CIO,
Carrier



Dr M Muneer
Founder Director &
Chief Evangelist,
Medici Institute, New York



Dr Sanjeev Rastogi
Head-Group Policy Services,
Adani Group Board
Member-Global SSON



Sudipta Adhya
Co-Head,
Bank of New York, India



Ram Subramaniam
Vice President & GCC Lead
Qualcomm



Rajat Sinha
Managing Director,
Head HR, BNP Paribas,
India & The Philippines GCC



Rohit Chowdhry
GCC Leadership Advisor,
Executive Coach & Author



Dr Anshumaan Y
General Manager,
Leica Biosystems,
Danaher, India & South Asia

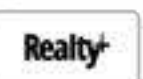


Noor Fathima Warsia
Group Editorial Director
BW Businessworld



Hoshie Ghaswalla
CEO and Managing Director
BW Businessworld

EVENT PARTNERS



For Nominations:

Rohit Arora | +91 9217955188
rohit.arora@businessworld.in

For Speaking Opportunities:

Ashish Kumar | +91 9717922747
ashish.kumar@businessworld.in

For Industry Collaborations:

Bilquis Naqvee | +91 9910382910
bilquis.naqvee@businessworld.in

The Urban Climate Nexus is Not a Sector



Clockwise from the left :
Amit Kapoor & Meenakshi Ajith

IN AN ERA MARKED by structural global transitions, cities have become critical arenas for climate action and for socio-economic progress alike, which is why the number of urban heat resilience plans, city climate action plans and municipal net zero pledges has climbed so sharply in recent years. These efforts have advanced at different speeds, with some running in full mission mode, money and deadlines and a ministry attached, while others are still building the evidence and the institutional arrangements to match. A heavy downpour is a weather event.

It is also a design problem, because a city that has paved its ground and built over its drains leaves the water nowhere to go. But, for the urban population and their lived experience, the consequences are deeply enmeshed in each other. The lost day of work, the flooded road, the broken surface afterwards and the borewell that has to go deeper next summer are one continuous experience that intersect on the ground. Policy has not learnt to reflect that intersectionality, which is why cities end up holding a potpourri of plans that rarely speak to one another.

India's own programmes show how much is lost in the sorting. In 2022 the housing ministry began sinking recharge wells in ten cities under Shallow Aquifer Management, part of AMRUT 2.0, since extended to 75 more. It raises groundwater levels, reduces street flooding and keeps contaminants out of shallow reserves, and it does something else besides, since recharge also displaces the energy spent

pumping water in from distant sources, which no city counts.

That is adaptation and mitigation in the same trench. It is also attached to livelihoods and to everyday living in a way that few climate interventions are, since a working shallow aquifer is what a *dhobi*, a dairy household or a small workshop depends on. The scheme is administered as water supply rather than as climate action.

Adaptation & Mitigation

The binary between adaptation and mitigation is the one that most needs breaking, because it holds nowhere on the ground. Each additional degree of warming raises peak electricity demand by close to four per cent globally, and in India in 2024 it worked out at roughly seven gigawatts per degree.

Chennai's own inventory put 71 per cent of the city's 2018 emissions in buildings, most of it thermal power burned for cooling. Shade along a street is therefore not a lesser measure taken because mitigation is unaffordable. For a hot, dense, fast-growing economy, adaptation is a pathway to mitigation, and

Urbanisation in India is driven in mission mode, through the Smart Cities Mission and AMRUT, and a mission expires. Climate obligations have to sit where they outlast a funding cycle, which means the statutory planning system, since development control regulations, building rules and open space reservations are made under state law and bind whoever is in office

often the cheapest one available.

At city level, sectoral action plans on their own are insufficient for a second reason, which is that people fall out of them. Plans count tonnes by source and assets by exposure, and vulnerability tends to enter as a chapter rather than as a criterion for spending. Even the careful work is bounded by what municipal records hold. The Tamil Nadu

Agra found outdoor workers losing around 24 days of work a year to heat, close to a tenth of annual earnings. Census 2027 is enumerating housing, amenities and assets as this is written, which is the first chance in 16 years to build that layer properly.

The data has the same problem as the plans. It is collected sector by sector, so a scheme delivering water,

tional forecasting system rather than in place of it.

All of this stays advisory until it enters something with legal force. Urbanisation in India is driven in mission mode, through the Smart Cities Mission and AMRUT, and a mission expires. Climate obligations have to sit where they outlast a funding cycle, which means the statutory planning system, since development control regulations, building rules and open space reservations are made under state law and bind whoever is in office.

The master plan is the usual candidate and a poor one on its record, being slow and often decades stale. But the instruments beneath it move faster and carry the same authority. What is lacking is the machinery, since NITI Aayog found the states need over 12,000 town planners against fewer than 4,000 sanctioned posts, half of them vacant.

Cities in India have grown less as they were planned than as they were financed, and ground once set aside for tanks, drains and open space did climate work at no cost to the exchequer. Much of it has since been read as land lying idle, available to be built over.

Getting the urban climate nexus right does not need another mission or another plan. It needs the ones already in place to stop treating climate as a sector of its own. That work belongs in the statutory framework, which is the only place where a city's obligations outlive the government that wrote them. Restoring public purpose to it is a question of conscience, not capability. **BW**

Amit Kapoor is Chair, Institute for Competitiveness & Meenakshi Ajith is development policy lead at the Institute for Competitiveness



Photograph by Indiapicture

ward-level heat study by ICLEI South Asia and the state's Green Climate Company settled its indicators around ward data availability, so vulnerability came to mean slum population, age profile, sex ratio, chronic illness, and the density of parks, clinics, roads and green cover.

The index is scored by residential ward, which counts a person where they sleep. A vendor who sleeps in a cooler ward and spends her working day in a hotter one appears nowhere, even though IIED's survey of informal worker households in Ajmer, Delhi and

drainage, energy and health at once has no ledger to be counted in. It is also collected at district scale, which averages away what matters, since heat risk varies sharply between wards inside a single city.

Cities Need Observatories

The same assessment measured a ward's safety partly by how many automatic weather stations stood in it, treating the capacity to observe as a form of protection. Cities need observatories of their own, dense enough to read a street, sitting beneath the na-

M

OST EMPLOYEES learn their boss's habits before they fully understand the company's culture. Who wants bad news immediately? Who needs a solution before hearing about the problem? Who prefers a call to an email? Who reacts badly to surprises? Who can handle a challenge in a crowded meeting but becomes defensive when questioned one-on-one? These may sound like minor observations, but they become useful workplace knowledge. Employees learn quickly that doing a good job also involves knowing how the person above them thinks and reacts.

This is usually called 'managing up', and some of it is simply good professional judgment. Every experienced employee knows that the same piece of information can land very differently depending on how, when and by whom it is presented. The trouble begins when people become so good at managing their boss that they start managing what the boss gets to know.

A senior executive once told me about a project that was several weeks behind schedule. The team knew it. The functional head knew it. The senior manager knew it. Yet the chief executive continued receiving updates saying the project was "broadly on track". Nobody had fabricated numbers. Delays became "dependencies", risks became "issues being worked through" and missed milestones became "revised timelines". Each statement was defensible. Taken together, however, they concealed the seriousness of the situation.

When the problem eventually surfaced, the CEO asked a familiar question: "Why didn't anyone tell me?" People believed she reacted badly to setbacks and that bringing a problem without a ready solution would damage their credibility.



Employees Learn to Manage Their Bosses. That Can Be Dangerous

They had learnt to protect the boss from bad news while protecting themselves from the boss's reaction. That is how information gets edited inside organisations. Employees are rarely calculating only whether something is true. They are also thinking about timing, relationships, careers and consequences.

A manager who dislikes surprises may receive problems late. A leader who responds sharply to disagreement may receive fewer dissenting views. A boss who rewards certainty may gradually create a team that becomes uncomfortable admitting uncertainty. People learn these rules by watching what happens to colleagues. If someone challenges authority and is dismissed, interrupted or quietly left out of the next important conversation, others notice.

If another executive changes course after hearing a strong contrary view, that also becomes part of the organisation's memory. Culture often travels through these small moments.

This can become particularly pronounced in India Inc., where hierarchy still shapes how information moves through many organisations. The senior-most person may not ask for a formal update before a major decision, yet everyone knows that the decision will eventually pass through that office. A junior manager may spend more time figuring out how to present a problem

AI Created Representation



than solving it. A middle manager may soften bad news because they know that a raw version will trigger three levels of escalation. By the time an issue reaches the top, it may be perfectly polished and considerably less useful.

A CEO I know noticed something similar after a series of senior management meetings. Important decisions were routinely brought to her only after executives had discussed them extensively among themselves. She initially saw this as unnecessary caution. Then she examined her own behaviour. She had developed a habit of responding almost immediately when someone proposed something she disliked, sometimes before the person had finished making the argument. Her team had adapted. They were not avoiding decisions. They were avoiding the first reaction.

She changed one habit. Before responding to a difficult proposal, she began asking, "What am I missing?" It did not transform the culture overnight. But gradually, people started bringing unfinished thoughts, contrary evidence and uncomfortable information earlier.

When employees learn to manage their bosses, leaders can slowly lose sight of reality

That matters because the most important information in an organisation rarely arrives neatly packaged. A customer relationship may be weaker than the sales report suggests. A forecast may rest on an assumption nobody has challenged. A project may be slipping despite reassuring updates. Someone usually sees the warning sign first. Whether that person speaks openly depends partly on what they have learnt about the consequences of doing so.

Artificial intelligence adds a new wrinkle. Senior leaders now have access to dashboards, predictive models and AI-generated analysis at a scale that was unimaginable a decade ago. Yet more information does not automatically create more visibility. An AI system can identify a pattern, but someone still has to question the context, explain what the data misses and say when the recommendation does not match what is happening on the ground.

If human beings have already learnt to filter inconvenient information, better technology may simply produce a faster version of the same problem.

The danger of being managed too well by employees is subtle. There may be no deception, no conspiracy and no deliberate withholding. Reality simply begins arriving in increasingly acceptable language. Risks sound smaller. Problems arrive later. Disagreement becomes diplomatic. Bad news acquires softer names.

The strongest leaders therefore notice who becomes quieter when they enter a room, who agrees too quickly and which difficult subjects surface only after decisions have been made. **BW**



Do Introverts Make Better Leaders?

W

HAT IF THE LEADER who speaks the least in the room is actually the one listening the most?

For decades, leadership has been associated with charisma, confidence, fast decisions and the ability to command attention. But Susan Cain, whose book *Quiet* changed how the world thinks about introversion, challenges this assumption.

In her recent conversation with Nicolai Tangen, CEO, Norges Bank Investment Management, Cain argues that introverts can be just as high-agency as extroverts, particularly when they care deeply about a goal, project or people. Their leadership may be quieter, but their commitment can be intense. The real question, therefore, may not be whether introverts make better leaders. It is whether organisations have become too obsessed with leaders who “look like leaders”.

The Power of Deep Commitment

One of the most overlooked strengths of introverts is their ability to focus.

Cain points out that introverts often concentrate on a few goals and relationships that genuinely matter to them. If they commit to a company or leadership role, that commitment can be remarkably persistent.

Psychologist Elaine Aron’s work on highly sensitive people, for example, suggests that a significant minority of people process stimulation more deeply. Such individuals may be more reflective and sensitive to subtle details in their environment — qualities that can become valuable when leadership requires careful observation rather than instant reaction.

Consider Warren Buffett. His lead-



Great leaders do not simply communicate; they absorb. Introverts often bring a natural tendency towards observation and listening. In organisations, this can be a significant advantage because employees do not always need another person telling them what to do

ership has rarely depended on theatrics. His reputation has been built on patience, disciplined thinking and long-term conviction. The lesson is simple: “leadership does not always announce itself. Sometimes it compounds quietly”.

Listening Before Leading

Great leaders do not simply communicate; they absorb. Introverts often bring a natural tendency towards observation and listening. In organisations, this can be a significant advantage because employees do not always need another person telling them what to do. Sometimes they need someone who genuinely hears them.

Cain draws on research showing that people can unconsciously associate greater verbal assertiveness with intelligence and leadership — even when talking more does not necessarily mean thinking better. This helps explain why extroversion can be overvalued in organisations: the person who

speaks first, fastest or most confidently can appear more capable than the person quietly processing the issue.

Adam Grant, organisational psychologist and social scientist, provides another important research-backed perspective. His research on leadership found that introverted leaders can be particularly effective with proactive employees because they are more receptive to suggestions and less likely to impose their own ideas simply to establish authority.

The broader lesson is important: “when leaders listen, people contribute. When people contribute, organisations learn”.

The Quiet Leader Can Create a Stronger Team

Cain makes another important point: the strongest teams are not necessarily those filled with one personality type. She advocates a mix of introverts and extroverts because the two can complement each other.

This idea has roots in organisational research. Cain discusses research by Adam Grant, showing that the effectiveness of an introverted or extroverted leader can depend partly on the nature of the employees they lead. Proactive employees may thrive under quieter leaders who are willing to listen, while less proactive teams may benefit from leaders who provide more direction and energy.

Think of an Orchestra. Some musicians command attention. Others create depth, rhythm and balance. The performance succeeds because different strengths work together.

The same is true in business. An extroverted leader may energise a room, while an introverted leader may identify the idea everyone else overlooked.

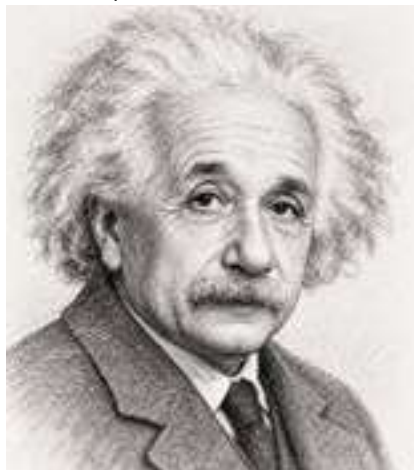
“The objective should not be to make introverts more extroverted — or extroverts more introverted. It should be to make both better leaders”.

The Quiet CEOs Who Changed the Stereotype

Cain’s *Quiet* offers a striking reminder that effective leadership has never belonged exclusively to the charismatic. She points to effective CEOs including Charles Schwab, Bill Gates, Brenda Barnes, former CEO of Sara Lee,

We can start confusing confidence with competence, visibility with influence and charisma with character. Albert Einstein was not celebrated because he dominated rooms. His influence came from the depth of his thinking. Rosa Parks did not lead through volume; her quiet act of resistance became a defining moment in the American civil rights movement. The common thread is not introversion itself. It is substance.

AI Created Representation



AI Created Representation



and James Copeland, former CEO of Deloitte Touche Tohmatsu. Their examples challenge the assumption that commanding presence is a prerequisite for commanding an organisation.

Cain also draws on management thinker Peter Drucker, who observed that effective leaders could be highly sociable or deeply reserved. What mattered was not charisma, but effectiveness, dedication and the ability to get the work done.

The message is powerful: “leadership can emerge through thoughtfulness, expertise and dedication — not just personal magnetism”.

When Silence Becomes a Strategic Advantage

Large meetings often reward those who speak quickly and confidently. But Cain highlights a problem: a small number of people can dominate the conversation, potentially leaving valuable ideas unheard.

Research in social psychology also demonstrates how “groupthink and conformity” can suppress dissenting views. When everyone follows the most

vocal opinion, organisations can mistake consensus for good judgement.

This is where the quieter leader can change the dynamic. Instead of asking, “Who has the strongest voice?”, an effective leader asks, “Whose perspective have we not heard?”

That simple question can uncover risks, alternative solutions and insights that would otherwise remain invisible. Leadership is not about winning the conversation. *It is about improving the conversation.*

The End of the “Charisma Equals Leadership” Myth

Cain describes a cultural shift from a “culture of character” towards a “culture of personality” — a world increasingly shaped by presentation, personal branding and the pressure to perform. The danger is obvious. We can start confusing confidence with competence, visibility with influence and charisma with character.

Albert Einstein was not celebrated because he dominated rooms. His influence came from the depth of his thinking. Rosa Parks did not lead through volume; her quiet act of re-

sistance became a defining moment in the American civil rights movement.

The common thread is not introversion itself. It is substance.

Introverts and the Age of AI

The rise of artificial intelligence makes this conversation even more relevant. Cain suggests that introverts may benefit from AI because it can provide additional channels for communication and allow people to work in ways that suit their natural preferences. But she also cautions that technology could simply become another stage for self-presentation.

The people most likely to remain “robot-proof”, she suggests, may be those who protect “human authenticity and genuine connection”. Artificial intelligence can generate information. It cannot replace human judgement, trust, empathy or the feeling that someone genuinely understands you. Remember, HI — Human Intelligence — will always matter. After all, there is a human being behind every algorithm.

Perhaps the real question is whether we have been measuring leadership by the wrong standards.

The future may belong to leaders who listen before speaking, think before reacting, commit deeply, respect others and give them room to contribute and remain authentic when the world rewards performance.

The best organisations will need both the energy of extroverts and the depth of introverts.

Because leadership is not a personality contest. It is the ability to bring out the best in people — respect every employee and stakeholder. BW

The author is Managing Partner, Leadership Access LLP



RECENT RESEARCH has amplified the disquiet about the growing power of Artificial Intelligence (AI). Fears that it is fast outpacing humans have been exacerbated by

MIT (USA) research that talks of “cognitive surrender”, with students depending ever more on AI.

At the school level, the internationally respected PISA test shows the average scores for science (for OECD-23 countries) have decreased over the last 20 years; those for reading and mathematics, even more precipitously so. Any wonder, then, that there are concerns about how machines may dominate us.

For many, this would be *déjà vu*: they would remember strict parental and teacher warnings from the past that the latest device would dumb us down: TV sets, calculators, VCRs, CD players, PCs/laptops, mobile hand-sets, and smartphones. Yet, it is not clear if we grew up any dumber. Maybe we did! Irrespective, we now dutifully pass on such dire worries to the next generation.

There is, of course, some evidence of a reduction in attention span, in limited

Increased Intelligence: Why Worry?

abilities to concentrate for long or for serious reading of longer texts, like books. Whether this makes the next generation less intelligent is a moot point, though.

SHOULD WE AT ALL DEPEND ON HUMAN INTELLIGENCE?

The question, however, is whether lost abilities, if any, are useful and important in the context of today (and tomorrow). Take memorisation of multiplication tables: those above 50 might recall, even now, learning these “by heart” (rote) up to 20x20. Some further honed their memory and learned multiplication of fractions! Yet, how useful is it today to know these tables? How useful is human memory itself? At a time when devices can perform the same function faster, more accurately, and with greater efficiency, why should we depend on fickle, sometimes error-prone human beings?

Which leads us to the broader issue: should we at all depend on human intelligence? It is often slow, prone to biases, and may not be able to immediately foresee all consequences of a decision. Many fear that this path, combined with the very rapidly-growing capability of AI will mean that it will soon be more powerful than humans.

However, history should reassure us. Centuries ago, power was based on physical strength: either of the individual or collective (community/army). Later, individual weapons were added and then machines. In factories, machines — more capable than humans — supplemented and sometimes supplanted human workers. To that extent, they were certainly a threat to jobs. But, there was no panic about machines “taking over”.

Why the fear now? Is AI really so “different”? After all, it is only one more tech that is superior to human capabilities in some dimensions. Don’t millennia of human experience and wisdom give us the capability to handle this new challenge? On another AI related worry, look at a simplistic analogy. Tigers, far more powerful than humans, are sometimes held in zoos. Occasionally — if only very rarely — one may escape its cage, triggering

fears and possibly actually creating mayhem somewhere. It may even learn new skills. Yet, we don’t fear a takeover by the animal kingdom!

More powerful, self-learning AI, with capabilities greater than humans? Fine; why worry?

The more important questions may be: with AI, has human life suffered or been enriched? Has the life of the “last person” been improved? **BW**



The writer loves to think in tongue-in-cheek ways, with no maliciousness or offence intended. At other times, he is a public policy analyst and author. His latest book is Decisive Decade: India 2030 Gazelle or Hippo (Rupa, 2021)

MARKETING AND ADVERTISING

IN FOCUS

India's media mix is undergoing a structural shift wherein digital is no longer merely a performance or targeting medium but is increasingly shaping brand discovery, engagement, commerce and even how consumers search for products.

Digital accounted for 59 per cent of India's total ad spend in 2025 and is expected to grow 18.6 per cent in 2026, with FMCG digital spends rising to 64 per cent from 53 per cent in 2024, according to the Dentsu-e4m Digital Advertising Report 2026. However, the shift is not about TV being replaced by digital, but channels converging and the media mix being reorganised around digital.

Focus on experiences

For Anuj Bansal, Chief Business Officer, ITC Yoga Bar, the strategy starts with Gen Z, whose trial often influences the wider household. The brand spends 10–15 per cent of revenue on marketing, focusing on social media, influencers, digital platforms and consumer experiences.

"It's important that we reach out to them not only on social media, but also through experiences," Bansal said, framing it

as a matter of where the brand sits in its journey rather than a snub to traditional formats. "Traditional media will also play a role whenever one-way communication is required. But at this point, we are more into our journey of hard work, where we reach out to people in the form of experiences and trials, tasting it. And we don't want to compromise," he said.

remain a very important piece for discovery, for trials, for repeats and for business," he added.

Arithmetic is shifting

However, the story is less about a digitally native brand and more about a legacy staples business recalibrating in real time for KRBL. "For us, the entire organised retail today now contributes to about 40 per cent of

urban, tier-one and tier-two skew. "Inherently, our consumer is more on digital, which is skewing our investments more towards digital, even from a marketing standpoint," he said.

Even so, Sharma was clear that television remains the anchor for now. "Traditional today would contribute about 60 per cent and 40 per cent would be purely digital.

The Great Media Mix Rebalancing

TV remains relevant, but CTV, creators, OOH, quick commerce and AI-led search are now altering how marketers allocate budgets, engage consumers and build brands **By Reema Bhaduri**

That trial-led approach dovetails with commerce. "A big chunk of our business, almost 50 per cent, comes from online commerce, which includes our own website, ecommerce platforms and marketplaces," Bansal said, with quick commerce doing much of the work of converting first-time tasters into repeat buyers. "They

our consumer pack business, which is higher by any FMCG standards. FMCG today operates at 18–20 per cent; we're at 40 per cent. We're over-indexed," said Kunal Sharma, Vice President - Marketing and Organised Trade, KRBL, attributing the gap to the bulk, convenience-led nature of the rice category and its

Within digital, there is about 50 per cent which still goes into the Meta, YouTube, Facebook, and Instagram ecosystem," he said, with the rest going to influencers and content creators, though he added, "it won't be long before digital will take the forefront."

Sharma also pointed to a newer line item entering

“A big chunk of our business, almost 50 per cent, comes from online commerce, which includes our own website, ecommerce platforms and marketplaces. They remain a very important piece for discovery, for trials, for repeats and for business”

ANUJ BANSAL,
ITC Yoga Bar



◀ “Inherently, our consumer is more on digital, which is skewing our investments more towards digital, even from a marketing standpoint”

KUNAL SHARMA,
KRBL



▲ “Quick commerce is not a discovery platform. It is still a search-driven platform... In quick commerce, brand building has to happen outside the platform”
SMIT SHUKLA, Philips Personal Health

the mix with Answer Engine Optimisation (AEO) and Generative Engine Optimisation (GEO), as consumer search increasingly migrates “from a Google search into the whole GPT ecosystem.” His caution on quick commerce is instructive: while it builds saliency, it is “not the right medium for a brand to talk about larger communications,” highlighting the distinction between performance spends and

brand-building dollars in KRBL’s playbook.

A Search for disruption

If Yoga Bar and KRBL are brands in transition, Philips Personal Health India is fully on the other side. “We are 100 per cent digital. We are a digitally native brand. There is absolutely no TV that happens,” said Country Head Smit Shukla, describing a media vocabulary that has itself shifted. YouTube and Instagram, he

said, are now “traditional digital,” while the brand chases Gen Z onto Reddit and Discord.

Creators and UGC account for 20–25 per cent of Philips’ spends, with the company having doubled down on the segment over the past 18 months.

Quick commerce has emerged as one of Philips Personal Health’s top three channels within 18 months, with category share rising from high single digits to 45–50 per cent and 15–20 per cent of total business now coming through the channel. But Shukla pointed out its limits, stating, “Quick

Commerce is not a discovery platform. It is still a search-driven platform... In quick commerce, brand building has to happen outside the platform.” That belief has driven shareable stunts, from live blind-shave demos and intimate razor boxes to a breast-pump ramp walk with Masaba and Neena Gupta, alongside a growing OOH push that Shukla sees as a counter-intuitive disruptor amid crowded digital feeds.

At the moment, digital is taking the largest share of advertising. As AI becomes table stakes and firmly entering the marketing mainstream, the road ahead promises another reshuffle, one where media, commerce, content and discovery increasingly converge into a single consumer journey. **BW**

reema@businessworld.in

MARKETING AND ADVERTISING

IMPROMPTU

InMobi's next AI bet is conversational, visual & commerce-driven

ABHAY SINGHAL, InMobi's Co-founder and CEO, InMobi Advertising, speaks to BW Businessworld's **Reema Bhaduri** on the shift from traditional discovery to outcome-led advertising, conversational formats and the rise of brand agents. Excerpts

What are the insights behind the MorePower2You campaign? What was the one decision that helped InMobi stay relevant through nearly two decades of technology shifts?

It's less about one decision and more about a series of many decisions. At the core of those decisions, we are known for taking ambitious moves with limited data. For example, going and trying to become global in the mobile era at a time when there was no company in programmatic advertising, or jumping into agentic commerce, where there is nobody to follow. And each one of those decisions has shaped us in various ways.

At the core of those decisions is our belief and our trust in the people that we have surrounded ourselves with, and the optimism that the future is going to be much better than the present. These two are big core beliefs that almost drive us every single day.

As AI reshapes the industry, where will InMobi focus its investments over the next year?

There are two to three areas where we have anchored all

of our investments. In the world of AI, there are two things that are extremely critical. As the cost of production is going down, the cost of distribution is increasing because now there are more choices for consumers to choose from.

One, we are investing our time into experimenting with hundreds of hypotheses. We've changed our entire development methodology

to an experimentation stage. Do hundreds of experiments, test them out in the world and then see which one sticks. This is relevant in the context of formats and creative testing.

The second place where we are

investing our time and energy is into generating these conversational interfaces, visual conversational interfaces, whereby a consumer can be influenced by or inspired by something visual. And then you drag the consumer in to have a conversation with an agent.

Glance, as an agent, is available on various surfaces because we believe that, as a consumer, you can be anywhere on the screen, and you should have this intelligence of Glance with you. That's the second area where we are investing our time and energy.

The third place where we are investing our time and energy is to be able to develop small language models in the company. We're training small language models that are built for commerce, for advertising and for creative. And we're training these models on top of the open-source models, but we are training them with our own proprietary data to be able to be relevant in the world.

Why is it important? It is important because the only way to survive in this industry and thrive is when you control the consumer experience to the model weights end-to-end. **BW**

(Full interview on www.bwmarketingworld.com)

reema@businessworld.in



MARKETING AND ADVERTISING

AD INFINITUM

Vi's 'Vi Pe Sab Hai VIP' campaign starts with a simple conceit: Shah Rukh Khan assumes that the network's latest upgrades and offerings have been introduced especially for him. He then discovers that the benefits are available to everyone on Vi.

The campaign builds on the brand's 'We Love All' positioning, using 'VIP' not as a marker of exclusivity, but as an expression of inclusivity.

Why SRK works

The smartest part of the campaign is how Shah Rukh Khan is used. Rather than simply putting a famous face behind a telecom message, the creative makes his superstar status central to the idea. His assumption that Vi is upgrading itself for him sets up the reversal: if even SRK gets the same treatment as everyone else, everyone is a VIP.

That makes the celebrity feel intrinsic to the execution rather than ornamental. It also gives Vi a simple storytelling device in a category often overloaded with functional claims.

The contradiction

The campaign's strongest brand idea lies in redefin-

ing VIP. Typically, being a VIP means getting something others don't. Vi flips that expectation to say its latest benefits are for everyone. The thought is easy to understand and fits naturally with the 'We Love All' platform.

As Avneesh Khosla, CMO of Vi, puts it, the

The gap

'Everyone is a VIP' is a strong communication thought, but it is not, by itself, a competitive proposition.

For consumers, VIP treatment from a telecom network ultimately has to translate into something tangible — a better network experience, useful benefits, improved service or greater value.

If those upgrades re-

philosophy. It is trying to communicate a transformation. Saying Vi has changed is one thing. Giving consumers a reason to believe and experience that change is another.

The opportunity

The campaign has the makings of a platform rather than just a one-off celebrity film. Vi can build on the idea by showing what 'VIP treatment' actually means across different consumer needs, connecting its emotional promise of inclusivity with tangible product benefits.

The creative team at Ogilvy has kept the central thought deliberately simple, with Chrome Films bringing the campaign to life.

The verdict

'Vi Pe Sab Hai VIP' has a clean premise, a natural role for Shah Rukh Khan and a smart reinterpretation of a familiar term.

Its weakness is not the idea, but the distance between the idea and the product proof.

For the campaign to do more than entertain, Vi needs to show consumers what being a VIP actually gets them.

The advertising says everyone gets VIP treatment. The brand now needs to make that treatment impossible to miss. **BW**

soumya@businessworld.in

The ViP Flip



Vi's latest campaign smartly flips VIP from a symbol of exclusivity into one of inclusivity, but the brand will need tangible product proof to make the promise stick **By Soumya Bhutani**

campaign is meant to signal that the company's transformation is already underway and that its improved experiences and benefits are "for everyone to experience." But that is also where the campaign's biggest challenge begins.

main broadly defined, the campaign risks communicating an attitude without giving consumers a compelling reason to choose Vi.

That distinction matters because Vi is not simply selling a brand

MARKETING AND ADVERTISING

IMPROMPTU

S4 Capital's first-half numbers show a striking contrast -- like-for-like net revenue declined 4.7 per cent, while operational EBITDA rose 82.7 per cent and the margin increased from 6.3 per cent to 12.3 per cent. How do you assess the company's recovery?

We are better on margins and liquidity, but not on the top line. That remains the challenge. There are three big KPIs for us: top-line growth, margin and liquidity. We have done very well on liquidity, and margins are improving. Our longer-term ambition is to return the margin to around 20 per cent and move net debt towards zero.

But top-line growth is what will validate the business model. We must translate the stronger financial base into sustainable growth.

S4's net revenue is declining even though digital advertising expenditure continues to grow. Technology clients also account for 42 per cent of the business. Why is that market growth not flowing through to S4?

A significant factor is the hyperscalers' shift from operating expenditure, including marketing, towards enormous capital expenditure on AI infrastructure. They are committing

hundreds of billions of dollars to that build-out. It is similar to the development of the railways: there will be successes, failures and eventually a culling. The investment must ultimately generate a return, and competitive pressure should drive spending back towards marketing.

That creates a timing problem for us, although also a substantial future opportunity. For now, client caution and longer decision cycles are affecting the top line.

What is S4 doing to move from a margin-led recovery to a revenue-led one?

We are dependent on im-

plementing AI at scale. Monks.Flow is our product for doing that across approximately ten product sets in an end-to-end model. We must accelerate adoption and move clients from pilots to scaled implementation.

The strongest response is in industries facing an existential threat. Established automotive companies face Chinese electric-vehicle manufacturers; financial institutions face fintech platforms such as Nubank and Revolut; and packaged-goods companies face pricing and supply-chain pressure. Where the pressure to transform is greatest, we win. Suc-

cessful companies often change too slowly because, if it is not broken, they feel no compulsion to fix it.

The number of Monks fell 10.5 per cent year-on-year to 6,156. How much of the improved profitability is cost-led, and how much reflects genuine AI productivity?

We have been disciplined on costs, which is reflected in margins and liquidity. Across the industry, however, headcount reductions are too readily described as AI-driven. Much of the restructuring announced by the large groups began before AI had a meaningful operational impact.

The bigger disruption lies ahead. Producing creative work faster and at lower cost is relatively

“Top line remains the challenge”

Eight years after founding S4Capital/ Monks, **MARTIN SORRELL**, Executive Chairman, gets candid about its unfinished business. In the first half of 2026, like-for-like net revenue fell 4.7 per cent to £308 million, even as operational EBITDA rose 82.7 per cent to a record £38 million. The margin reached 12.3 per cent and net debt fell to £66.3 million. In this interview with BW Businessworld's Group Editorial Director Noor Fathima Warsia, Sorrell explains why the top line is now the central test, how Monks.Flow should drive growth and why S4 must achieve greater scale in India. Excerpts



petition for revenue. The better structure is country first, client second and capability third, supported by one P&L and a view of total client profitability. Media economics must also become “transparently transparent”.

Rebates, proprietary trading and other frictions will become increasingly visible to clients through technology and AI. A model reliant on opacity cannot last.

By S4 Capital's tenth anniversary in 2028, what would constitute proof

“The bigger disruption lies ahead. Producing creative work faster and at lower cost is relatively small compared with what will happen in media”

small compared with what will happen in media. Planning and buying still conducted on spreadsheets will become increasingly automated. AI is not simply a rationale for reducing people; it requires a different operating model.

APAC generated £16.1 million, or only 5 per cent of S4's first-half net revenue, and declined 12.5 per cent like-for-like. How are you looking at India within that performance?

The picture across Asia is

mixed. We are doing better in Japan; China, Singapore and Australia are satisfactory, while Malaysia works well as a hub. India is performing reasonably, but we need to be bigger here. India can be all three things for us: an important client market, a delivery centre and a base for developing AI and technology solutions for the world. It also represents the shift in global economic power. As companies reconsider concentration in China, they will increasingly examine India, Indonesia, Vietnam,

Thailand, the Philippines, Malaysia and Singapore.

You expect digital advertising to surpass \$1 trillion this year. What does that mean for the traditional agency model?

Digital already accounts for roughly three-quarters of the industry and is moving towards 80 per cent. Algorithms will dominate and the business will become increasingly automated. The traditional holding-company model, organised first by separate capabilities, creates internal com-

that the model has succeeded?

The measures remain top-line growth, margin and liquidity. The longer-term margin objective is around 20 per cent. On liquidity, the objective is net debt of zero, and we are moving closer. But, above all, it is about the top line. We have strengthened the margin and balance sheet. Now we must demonstrate that our AI-led model can deliver consistent organic growth. That is the remaining test. **BW**

nfw@businessworld.in

“We are a very acquisitive company”

RAMESH SWAMINATHAN, Executive Director, Global CFO and Head of IT and API Plus SBU at Lupin, discusses with BW Businessworld’s **Savi Khanna** the board-approved capital allocation framework behind the company’s GLP-1 licensing deals, the Kaveri Therapeutics spin-out, its continuing appetite for specialty M&A, and much more. Excerpts

You’ve licensed GLP-1, spun out oncology into Kaveri Therapeutics as a minority stake, yet still want outright M&A in ophthalmology, pulmonology and rare neurology. What actually decides which route an opportunity takes, and does this signal a permanent shift away from big acquisitions?

To the contrary, I’d say each of these is charting a growth path for itself. We are a very acquisitive company, though our capital allocation sits within a framework approved by the board. We’re currently debt-free, with some cash on our balance sheet, and we have the ability to borrow at least twice our EBITDA. If you look at our EBITDA today, that’s close to Rs 8,000 crore, so we could borrow up to Rs 16,000 crore. Add the Rs 3,000-4,000 crore already on our balance sheet, and we could go up to about Rs 20,000 crore when it comes to acquisitions.

We’re focused on specialty. We’ve expanded into ophthalmology — we acquired VISUfarma, and followed that with a further acquisition in the ophthalmology space through Tenpoint as well.

Clearly, the proposition has to be compelling. When it comes to carve-outs, we’ve spun our OTC and wellness business into a separate company, carved out a CDMO business, and carved out Kaveri Therapeutics as our oncology spin-out. All of this is done with

a purpose — we’d like each of these businesses to grow and spin on its own axis. It gives us the focus that they deserve. A diagnostics business is very different from our core pharmaceuticals business.

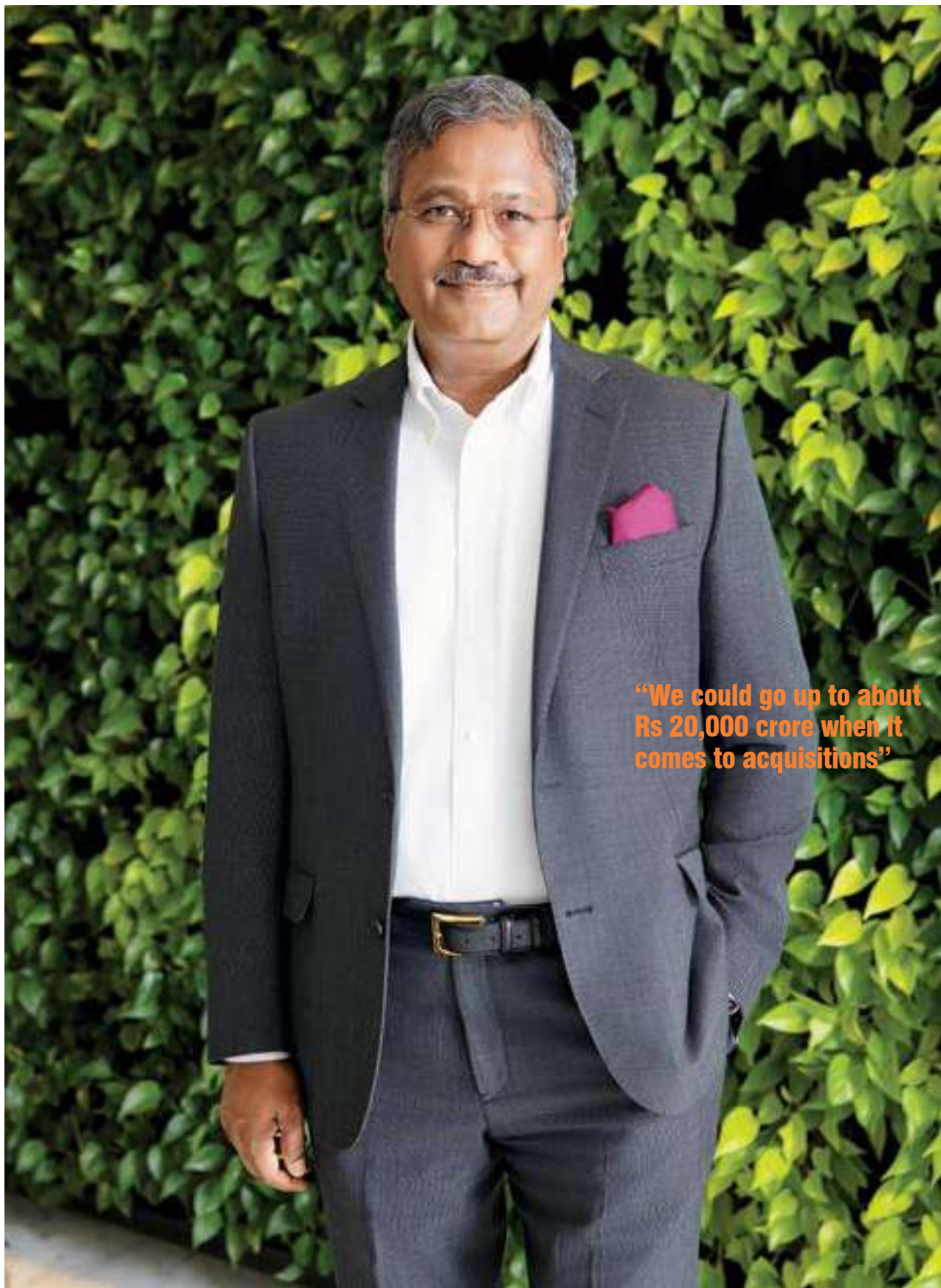
By carving these out into subsidiary companies, it also opens the door to partnerships — either with a strategic partner or a passive financial partner, as in the case of private equity. The idea is to grow all of these businesses without losing focus on our core business of pharmaceuticals, which will remain the dominant theme at Lupin, while these adjacencies grow at their own pace.

Citi just downgraded Lupin to Sell, cut FY27 EPS estimates 14 per cent, and flagged weak US base-business sales and margin pressure — directly against your 24-25 per cent FY27 EBITDA guidance. Which part of that case do you think is wrong, and what single number should investors watch this year?

We’re upfront about the nature of this industry — there’s typically a big upside on the launch of certain products, followed by a continuous downside. In the case

of Mirabegron, we introduced it about seven-eight quarters ago, and it’s had a very good run. We’ve also settled our cases with Astellas, providing continuity up to September 30. There’s still some steam left in it,

“We would like each of the carved-out businesses to grow and spin on its own axis”



**“We could go up to about
Rs 20,000 crore when it
comes to acquisitions”**

despite additional competition coming in through the MSN-Amneal combination.

Tolvaptan is a more difficult product, given the REMS framework required to introduce it into the market. It had an extended run simply because there was no competition — that didn't mean there would be no competition forever. We indicated as much even when we guided for this year's results, so from our perspective, this is in line with what we expected.

What we're really talking about is a secular trend of EBITDA improvement. If we define our core EBITDA at around 22-23 per cent, there's an upside when individual products are launched, and thereafter it erodes and comes back to that level. But the base itself keeps rising, based on new products we introduce and the efficiency gains we focus on. The idea is to focus on every line of the P&L — improving gross margins, bringing down

the cost of conversion, and reducing erosions like idle time. We do this through a number of initiatives — traditional ones, such as alternate route synthesis and alternate vendor development, and increasingly, a number of cases using artificial intelligence.

Generics are currently exempt from the new US pharma tariffs. With the US at 42 per cent of sales, how much of a tariff exemption is already stress-tested into your FY27 numbers?

It really comes down to the kind of products we bring to market. Today, Mirabegron and Tolvaptan together have taken us to a high of \$1.3 billion, but with that exclusivity wearing off, we will see a dip in that turnover, and newer products will come in. That might not necessarily translate into growth quarter-on-quarter, but I think the secular growth rate will be sustained. That's because we have a number of products coming through in fairly complex areas — respiratory products, a number of biosimilars, and complex injectables as well. The specialty business will also start contributing.

Water security is one of your two CDP categories, and API manufacturing industry-wide has been flagged for antimicrobial-resistant effluent. What

concrete steps have you taken on effluent treatment, and do you expect tighter permitting to hit capacity or capex?

We've been extremely conscious of our ESG responsibilities, and the fact that we're ranked number one across the entire universe of pharmaceutical companies globally reflects that. We scored 91 on the S&P index, among the top 750 companies in the world. ESG is extremely important to us — whether it's water, carbon capture, or the use of renewable energy, we cover the entire gamut of measures to protect the environment.

We've been particularly successful when it comes to water — we run a number of programmes to manage our water consumption and to replenish water resources in the areas where we operate. On antimicrobial resistance, we've taken a number of measures that look at the entire lifecycle of our products, cradle to grave. We've done as-

essments across a number of products to ensure that the impact on the environment is minimised.

You've also entered GLP-1 as a B2B licensing supplier rather than building your own branded molecule. Is that a durable earnings driver, or do you think it's a bridge until better-margin specialty assets scale?

Diabetes has been one of our big focus areas — in India, we've had a strong presence in cardiovascular, diabetes and respiratory. We've been among the early entrants in the GLP-1 space, and we've made a big success of Semanext, which we introduced to the market — it's done a fairly good job, among the top three molecules in this space. We're conscious of wanting to maintain this lead, given our equity with doctors in the diabetes space.

We've also in-licensed Bofanglutide from Gan & Lee, which will give us a significant boost, given that it's unique in some ways — a long-acting molecule in this space. It's a fast-evolving space: we now have dual-receptor molecules in the GLP-1/GIP class, and there are triple-receptor molecules coming up as well.

On a separate note, what does the future finance office look like to you?

Finance is a critical function for any organisation, and its touch points, both





external and internal, are practically infinite. With artificial intelligence coming in, there's a lot of possibility to take this to a very different level.

Finance carries out four functions. The first is the custodial function — protecting the resources of the company. We're in a much better position to do that now, with technologies in place to protect the value of the company. The second is releasing value — making processes easier and simpler for adoption and implementation across various functions, and AI has a role to play there too. The third is partnering with the various businesses — we do this through various platforms, capturing data and helping with its interpretation. And the fourth is communicating value — keeping shareholders, investors and other stakeholders informed of what's happening at the company.

Looking ahead, AI will play a very important role. Efficiency will go up considerably with more agentic AI — agents handling a lot of transaction processing as well as data crunching. That makes things far more real-time

“The idea is to focus on every line of the P&L — improved margins, bringing down the cost of conversion, and reducing erosions like idle time”

for the partners we engage with. It also means you'll need fewer people over time. I think there's going to be a lot of reskilling required for finance professionals to deliver on what's expected of them, but equally, the number of people required to do this work will come down. I see a lot of possibility, both on the

efficiency front and the effectiveness front.

How is AI changing what you look for when hiring and upskilling for finance today?

I'd look, firstly, at the ability to adapt to changing circumstances. It's a fast-evolving world, and how someone approaches their individual processes reflects that ability to adapt and adopt new practices. A particular technology might be path-breaking today, but tomorrow it could be something very different. So the ability to imbibe new skills and work with new technologies is, for me, the leading reflection of someone's capability. **BW**

savi.khanna@businessworld.in

FOR A GLOBAL building-materials major like Saint-Gobain, India is no longer merely a high-growth market. It is becoming something considerably more strategic: a manufacturing base, innovation hub, export platform and increasingly important profit centre. The scale of the opportunity is reflected in a business that has quadrupled over the past decade and now sits among its parent group's top five global profit centres.

Saint-Gobain India generates annual turnover of around Rs 13,500 crore to Rs 14,200 crore. About 95 per cent of the products sold in India are manufactured locally across 82

FROM INDIA TO THE WORLD

Saint-Gobain India is scaling glass, gypsum and insulation capacity while building an export and innovation hub — but can execution match ambition?

By ASHISH SINHA



plants, giving the business one of the Group's most diversified industrial footprints.

For Sreedhar N., CEO – APAC and India Region, Saint-Gobain India, the opportunity goes beyond conventional market growth. "India is much more than a growth market for Saint-Gobain." That distinction is important because India's construction cycle is changing. Rapid urbanisation, infrastructure expansion, housing demand and rising attention to energy efficiency are creating space for materials that can reduce construction time, resource consumption and lifetime operating costs.

The company is consequently setting itself a demanding target: triple

revenue to Rs 36,000 crore by 2032 and reach Rs 50,000 crore by 2035, as per reports. The numbers are ambitious, but so is the investment behind them.

Capital to scale

Saint-Gobain plans to more than double its investment rate in India to €1 billion over the next five years, equivalent to roughly Rs 11,000 crore, building on nearly Rs 9,000 crore invested during the previous decade.

A broader Rs 6,000 crore to Rs 8,000 crore capital expenditure programme is also being pursued across the business. The focus is capacity expansion in light and sustainable construction solutions, along with

acquisitions and integrated manufacturing ecosystems.

Glass remains a central pillar. Production capacity is being increased by 20 per cent to cater to rising demand from housing and automotive applications. Gyproc, meanwhile, is preparing for a 30 per cent increase in line capacities. The business already commands around 65 per cent of India's plasterboard market and contributes roughly one-third of the subsidiary's revenues.

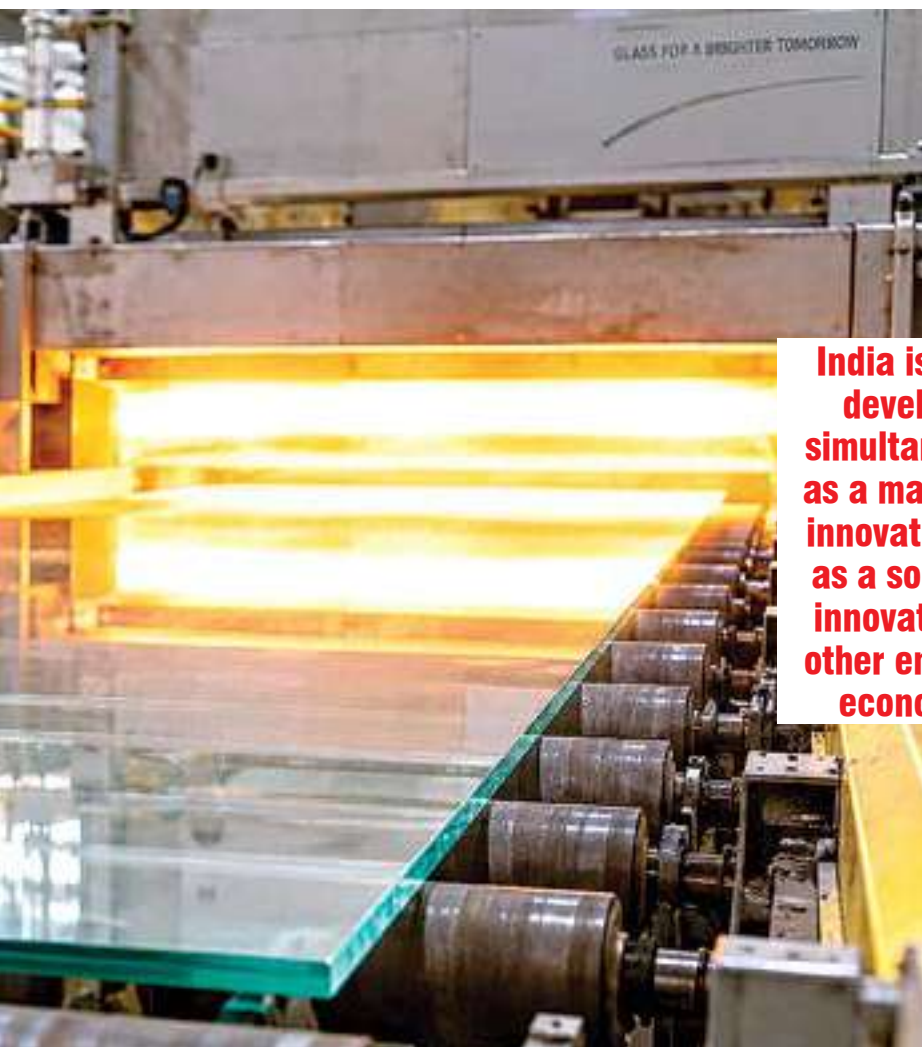
Tamil Nadu is another major investment destination. A Rs 3,400 crore investment pact is aimed at expanding production of plasterboard, glass wool and stone wool. The Oragadam campus near Chennai, spread across 122 acres, already integrates glass, gypsum, ceilings and insulation and ranks among Saint-Gobain's largest industrial hubs globally.

The strategy is not simply to produce more. It is to create manufacturing ecosystems that can serve multiple segments while allowing the company to move towards higher-value solutions.

That becomes particularly relevant as Saint-Gobain expands beyond its traditional product categories. Construction chemicals, insulation, acoustic solutions, high-performance façades and performance partition systems are expected to contribute increasingly to the next growth phase. Globally, the Group has invested more than €4 billion in construction chemicals, a category that can improve durability while reducing clinker and cement consumption.

India goes global

India is increasingly being positioned not just as the destination for Saint-Gobain's products, but as the source from which products are supplied to other markets. The compa-



India is being developed simultaneously as a market for innovation and as a source of innovation for other emerging economies

ny already exports to Southeast Asia, Australia and the Middle East, and intends to increase regional exports from about 5 per cent of its business to 15 per cent over the next five years.

The World Glass Complex in Rajasthan captures that ambition. Spread across 70 hectares and built around highly automated manufacturing, the facility produces ORAÉ, described by the company as India's first low-carbon glass.

The export strategy also gives Saint-Gobain another reason to deepen its manufacturing footprint. Indian plants can potentially serve both domestic demand and regional markets, improving utilisation while creating a pathway towards higher-value exports.

Innovation from India

Innovation is becoming another piece of the puzzle. Saint-Gobain's Chennai Innovation Centre houses more than 300 researchers and has contributed to a portfolio of more than 250 patents in low-carbon materials, energy-efficient technologies, digital solutions and sustainable construction.

That creates an unusual proposition for India. The country is being developed simultaneously as a market for innovation and as a source of innovation for other emerging economies.

The construction industry itself, however, remains the harder part of the equation.

India has traditionally relied heavily on bricks and concrete, and changing established construction practices is rarely achieved by simply introducing a technically superior product.

The case for drywall illustrates the point. Saint-Gobain says drywall systems can be installed more than four times faster, require up to 95 per cent less water and weigh around one-tenth as much as conventional brick walls. Insulated gypsum walls can also deliver substantially bet-

BUILDING BETTER

India is becoming Saint-Gobain's global growth and innovation hub, reshaping construction through sustainability, technology and scale, **SREEDHAR N.** tells Ashish Sinha. Excerpts

On India's strategic importance

India is much more than a growth market; it is one of Saint-Gobain's most strategic global platforms, combining scale, innovation, manufacturing excellence, sustainability and talent. It is among the Group's fastest-growing and most profitable markets, with an ambition to triple revenue over the next decade while consistently outpacing India's GDP growth. Around 95 per cent of products sold in India are manufactured locally, while the country is increasingly a high-value export hub.

On the investment roadmap

India will remain among Saint-Gobain's highest investment priorities globally. The Group has announced plans to more than double its investment rate to €1 billion over the next five years, building on nearly Rs 9,000 crore invested over the past decade. Investments will focus on manufacturing capacity, light and sustainable construction solutions, construction chemicals, integrated industrial ecosystems and locally relevant innovation.



ter energy performance in relevant applications. But the company recognises that adoption depends on changing the way customers calculate value.

Value over cost

"The conversation has to move from

cost to value," says Sreedhar. That is increasingly relevant in a construction market where developers face pressure to complete projects faster while managing environmental impact. A material that appears expensive at the point of purchase can look different when energy savings,



On the next growth engines

Growth is currently supported by glass, gypsum, insulation and construction chemicals. The next phase will increasingly come from light and sustainable construction, including performance partition gypsum systems, mineral-wool insulation, waterproofing, acoustic solutions and high-performance façades. Construction chemicals will be particularly important because they can improve durability, reduce clinker and cement consumption and lower construction's carbon footprint.

On barriers to drywall adoption

The barriers are primarily awareness, skills and long-standing perceptions rather than technology. Drywall can be installed more than four times faster, use up to 95 per cent less water and weigh around one-tenth as much as traditional brick walls. Saint-Gobain is addressing adoption through education, skill development, installer training and demonstration projects.

On the 2030 vision

By 2030, Saint-Gobain wants to help transform how India designs, builds and experiences buildings, with greater energy efficiency, resource productivity, healthier spaces and lower-carbon materials. Energy security, insulation and smarter buildings will be central to this transition.

ashish.sinha@businessworld.in

maintenance, durability and occupant comfort are calculated across the building's lifetime.

Saint-Gobain estimates that sustainable construction solutions can reduce energy consumption by up to 40 per cent and lower maintenance costs, while some insulation technologies have demonstrated substantially higher energy savings globally. This also explains the company's push from products to integrated solutions. A homeowner wants comfort and lower energy bills; a hospital needs hygiene, acoustics and indoor-air quality; an airport needs durability, safety and sustainability. The pitch is therefore shifting from selling individual ma-

terials to combining technologies around the outcome required.

An ecosystem play

That transition cannot happen in isolation. Architects, developers, consultants, contractors, applicators, academia, policymakers and regulators will all influence the speed of adoption. Saint-Gobain's Rs 20 crore partnership with CEPT University and its skill-development initiatives are intended to address precisely that ecosystem gap.

The larger bet is clear. India's construction boom could become a multi-decade opportunity, but capturing it will require more than add-

ing plants. It will require changing construction practices, developing skills, scaling exports and convincing customers that the economics of a building extend far beyond its initial material bill.

For Saint-Gobain, the prize is equally clear: a larger profit centre, a regional manufacturing and export hub, and an innovation base capable of serving markets well beyond India.

The execution test

The challenge is execution. Capacity has to find demand, acquisitions have to translate into synergies, exports have to become meaningful and sustainable construction has to move from niche preference to mainstream practice. As Sreedhar puts it, "India cannot afford to build buildings today that will become obsolete tomorrow." **BW**

ashish.sinha@businessworld.in

The strategy is not simply to produce more. It is to create manufacturing ecosystems that can serve multiple segments while allowing the company to move towards higher-value solutions

I

ndia's startup ecosystem has evolved from a small, metro-centric technology community into a significant engine of innovation, employment and enterprise creation. Since the launch of the Startup India initiative in 2016, the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT) has recognised more than two lakh startups, which together have generated over 21 lakh direct jobs.

Over the past decade, the startup landscape has broadened geographically and sectorally. Bengaluru remains a major innovation and funding hub, while Delhi-NCR, Mumbai, Pune, Hyderabad, Chennai and emerging Tier-II cities are developing stronger founder, incubator, talent and

away from valuation-led growth towards disciplined capital deployment, profitability, better governance and clearer paths to scale. Growth-stage funding rose more than 14 per cent year-on-year to US\$ 4 billion in 2025, even as late-stage funding declined to about US\$ 6 billion amid fewer megarounds. Seed-stage funding stood at US\$ 793 million, indicating that investors are writing fewer but more selective early-stage cheques.

Sectors In Spotlight

Fintech remained the largest startup-funding category, attracting more than US\$ 2.5 billion across 120 deals in 2025. Enterprise technology followed with about US\$ 1.8 billion, while e-commerce raised roughly US\$ 1.7 billion and recorded the highest number of deals, at 206. Emerging areas, including AI, deeptech and real-estate technology, each received around US\$ 500 million; healthtech and consumer

Celebrating Innovation

From Nothing India and Rapido to Nykaa and Chalo Mobility, the tenth edition of BW Disrupt 40 Under 40 spotlights founders driving India's next wave of entrepreneurial growth **By Kalyan Shobhana**

investor networks.

Capital Becomes More Selective

The funding environment in 2025 demonstrated both the resilience and increasing maturity of India's startup ecosystem. Indian startups collectively raised around US\$ 11 billion across more than 936 deals during the year, compared with about US\$ 12 billion across 993 deals in 2024.

While the overall value was lower than the funding peak of 2021, when startups raised approximately US\$ 42 billion, the current cycle reflects a shift

services drew about US\$ 700 million each, while cleantech attracted approximately US\$ 600 million. The broader private-capital market also remained strong. India attracted US\$ 60.7 billion through 1,475 PE/VC transactions in 2025, an 8 per cent increase in investment value and a 9 per cent rise in deal volume year-on-year, according to EY. This transition matters for entrepreneurs and business leaders.

India's next phase of startup growth will be shaped by founders who can build durable companies, turn



Photograph by Naval Kishor

research into products, create sustainable business models and compete in global markets. Recognising such leadership is therefore important, it strengthens the visibility of role models, gives emerging sectors a platform and reflects the diversity of businesses contributing to India's innovation economy.

About The Initiative

To recognise this new generation of business leaders, BW Disrupt, in association with BW Businessworld, organised the tenth edition of the BW Disrupt 40 Under 40 Awards. The platform honours entrepreneurs and intrapreneurs under the age of 40 who are building disruptive ventures or



Winners of the 10th Edition of BW Disrupt 40 Under 40 Awards

reshaping established organisations through innovation, strategy and execution.

This year, BW Disrupt received over 125 nominations spanning diverse sectors including FMCG, mobility, fintech, D2C, AI, and education. After rigorous evaluation, the entries were whittled down to a carefully curated shortlist of 118 nominees who were invited to present before the eminent jury panel. Each nominee underwent a multi-tier screening and evaluation against a defined set of parameters, major accomplishments, contributions to organisational growth, leadership journey, strategies for scale and

milestones.

The prestigious jury comprised some of the most respected names from the world of venture capital, private equity, entrepreneurship, and industry leadership; Annurag Batra, Chairman and Editor-in-Chief, BW Businessworld and Founder, exchange4media Group; Apoorva Sharma, Managing Partner, Stride Ventures; Nikhil Vora, Founder and CEO, Sixth Sense Ventures; Sanjay Mehta, Founder, 100X.VC; Radhesh Kanumury, Managing Partner, Suvan Ventures; Ankur Bansal, Co-Founder, BlackSoil; Jyoti Khetrapal, Executive Director, Centre of Startup Policy; Nikhil Bhandarkar, Found-

ing Partner, Panthera Peak Ventures; Vikram Gupta, Founder and Managing Partner, IvyCap Ventures; Imran Jafar, Executive Director, Gaja Capital and Kushaagra Nandan, Chairman, The Nandan Group.

The evaluation process considers several parameters, including an individual's professional journey, key achievements, contribution to organisational growth, leadership capability, market impact, strategic vision, innovation, scalability and sustainability. The platform recognises not only startup founders but also leaders within established companies who are driving transformation from within.

THE WINNERS

NAME	DESIGNATION	COMPANY
Abhimanyu Asija	Chairman & MD	Sommet Group
Abhinav Parashar	Co-founder & CEO	Digio
Adrija Agarwal	President	Sattva Group
Adwaita Nayar	Co-founder & Executive Director & CEO	Nykaa
Akis Evangelidis	Co-founder & India President	Nothing
Ambrish Miyani	Co-founder & Managing Director	Indo Era
Ankita Aditya Parakh	Chief Strategy Officer	Ashoka Health City
Ankur Tyagi	Founder & CEO	Rosier Foods
Ashonal Clery Pereira	Founder & CEO	Mancunianz
Avinash Chenreddy	Co-founder & CTO	Constelli Signals
Bhuman Dani	Founder & CEO	WickedGud
Binitha Manohar Dalal	Founder & Managing Partner	Mt K Kapital
Binnita Shah	Founder	Venbridge Real Estate Advertising
Dhruv Sayani	Founder & Managing Director	Ccigmaa Lifestyle
Hamza Patel	MD & CEO	AP Group
Harday Gupta	Founder	The Right PR
Himanshu Ratnoo	Co-founder & CEO	EMotorad
Keshav Bhajanka	Executive Director (Board of Directors)	Century Plyboards
Kritika Singh	Co-founder & Chief Strategy Officer	HiVoco Studios
Mangesh Zope	Founder	Peaceful Loans
Mohit Gulyani	Co-founder & Director	RexEdge & Recommercex
Niharika Joshi	Co-founder	Cumin Co.
Nitin Vinod Kalra	Founder, CEO & CMO	Let's Try
Piyush Goyal	Co-founder & CEO	Volks Energie
Priyam Parikh	Whole Time Director	Gujarat Tea Processors & Packers
Ragini Varma	Chief Business Officer	Fynd
Rishikesh SR	Co-founder	Rapido
Saloni Satish Wagh	Managing Director	Supriya Lifescience
Shreya Verma	Founding Member & VP- Product & Customer Success	Skills Caravan
Sneh Shah	Whole Time Director	Aimtron Electronics
Sneh Sharma	Co-founder & CMO	Dogsee
Sneha Roy	Co-founder & COO	Murf.AI
Sridhar Sampathirao	Founding Partner & CXO	Thoucentric
Swati Babel	Founder & CEO	Globizera Services FZCO
Taranjit Shah Singh	Founder & CEO	Berry Brothers
Uplaksh Tewary	Chief Operating Officer	Campus Activewear
Varun Karad	Co-founder & CEO	REnergy Dynamics
Varun Kumar Modi	Co-founder & CTO	Bright Money
Vijay Kumar Gond	Co-founder & CEO	Peakamp
Vinayak Bhavnani	Co-founder & CTO	Chalo Mobility
Viraj Sheth	Co-founder & CEO	Monk Entertainment
Yashovardhan Agarwal	Managing Director	Sintex & Welspun BAPL

#BWAIforIndiaAwards

BW BUSINESSWORLD

www.businessworld.in

INDIA EXCELLENCE AWARDS

Where Excellence Meets Intelligence

21st January 2027

Mumbai



SCAN TO NOMINATE
YOUR ENTRY

NOMINATE NOW

JURY MEMBERS



Dr Annurag Batra

Chairman & Editor-in-Chief,
BW Businessworld &
Founder, exchange4media



Shri Sujeet Kumar

Member of Parliament,
Rajya Sabha



Neeta Verma

Chief Advisor (IT)
Election Commission of India



Jagdish Mitra

Founder & CEO,
Humanize



Kiran Karnik

Author, Former President
NASSCOM



Kavita Bhatia

COO
IndiaAI Mission



Ravi Nawal

Board Member,
Responsible AI Foundation



Dhananjay Tambe

Former Deputy MD,
SBI



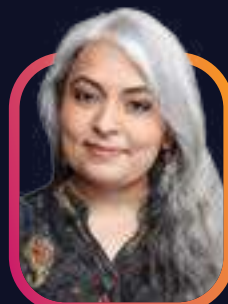
Kersi Tavadia

Independent Director,
Axis Securities



CP Gurnani

Co-Founder &
Vice Chairman, AIONOS



Noor Fathima Warsia

Group Editorial Director
BW Businessworld

For Nominations: Chetna Malhotra | +91 87960 22292 | chetna.malhotra@businessworld.in

For Sponsorship & Enquiries: Manvi Vats | +91 8860 510296 | manvi.vats@businessworld.in

Pragya Singh | +91 87567 44100 | pragya.singh@businessworld.in

Smarter products, stronger growth

ABHIMANYU ASIJA on why India's next growth phase will depend on innovation, material efficiency, disciplined capital allocation and measurable customer value **By Kalyan Shobhana**



Abhimanyu Asija
Chairman & MD, Sommet Group
Sector: Manufacturing
Age: 39

“growth at any cost”. Capital, he argues, should fund a stronger core proposition, not customer acquisition or subsidised sales. The focus must shift from chasing growth to building businesses that create durable value.

His approach has shaped Sommet's growth over the last decade. With infrastructure expanding and demand for metals remaining strong, the company has focused on understanding changing market requirements, developing a differentiated business model and creating products that customers value. The strategy is helping Sommet cross Rs 1 billion in revenue this year.

A largely bootstrapped business, access to smarter working capital finance remains a challenge for Sommet. This has limited the pace at which it can pursue op-

portunities.

Closing that funding gap will be a priority in the next phase. Over the next three to five years, Asija aims to build on Sommet's existing foundation and take the business to Rs 500 crore, with infrastructure and electronics as key growth markets. The focus will remain on developing products and solutions that deliver greater customer value.

For Asija, the next phase will require the same balance that has shaped Sommet so far: disciplined capital allocation, innovation and customer focus.

Building for 2035

Looking towards 2035, Asija believes Indian entrepreneurs can play a much larger role in the country's economic transformation by tackling complex challenges rather than focusing only on low-entry-barrier B2C businesses.

The next decade, he believes, will belong to entrepreneurs who look beyond short-term growth and build businesses that create lasting value. **BW**

kalyan@businessworld.in

A

t 39, Abhimanyu Asija, Chairman & MD of Sommet Group, is building his manufacturing business on a simple premise: growth matters only when backed by a strong underlying business. As India's investment landscape turns more selective, Asija believes entrepreneurs must look beyond headline growth and focus on efficiency, innovation and measurable customer value.

This philosophy is particularly relevant to Sommet, which operates in the metals industry, where prices are at all-time highs and consumption continues to rise. For Asija, the opportunity lies in doing more with less – developing products that deliver better performance while using less material. “Smart entrepreneurs must focus on efficiency and design, minimising the quantity required to achieve the same results,” says Asija. Innovation in the value proposition, rather than growth for its own sake, will be the game changer.

He applies the same lens to startups, which, he believes, must move beyond

Digital trust drives India

ABHINAV PARASHAR on why the next decade will favour startups with sustainable models, strong governance, digital trust and a role in critical workflows **By Kalyan Shobhana**

I

ndia's startup ecosystem is entering a more selective phase, with investors placing greater weight on fundamentals, profitability and long-term value creation. In fintech and digital infrastructure, this is raising the bar for governance, technology and business models.

Abhinav Parashar, Co-founder and CEO of Digio, believes the next phase will favour businesses that become integral to critical customer workflows.

Sustainable value

For Parashar, the shift in funding markets makes one priority clear: building businesses that can withstand cycles, and create value even when capital is scarce. In fintech and digital infrastructure, that means strong unit economics, disciplined capital allocation, sound governance and a technology moat capable of enduring multiple market cycles.

He sees AI, enterprise technology, fintech infrastructure, digital identity, cybersecurity, deeptech, climate technology and healthcare infrastructure as areas with potential for durable growth.

Digio was born out of a problem Parashar saw in India's business processes, where paper-based documentation, physical presence and repetitive verification remained common. The company initially focused on making documentation and signing



Abhinav Parashar

Co-founder & CEO, Digio

Sector: Fintech

Age: 37

paperless and presence-less before expanding into a wider digital trust infrastructure platform.

"We realised that the larger challenge was building trust across the entire digital customer journey," he says. Digio now spans identity verification, digital onboarding, documentation, digital signing, payments and consent.

Over the past 12–18 months, the company has processed approximately 250 million identity verifications annually, 65 million digital signings, around 60 crore debits and nearly \$15 billion in payments. Parashar attributes the growth to increasing digitalisation and demand for integrated infrastructure.

Building for the next decade

As Digio scales, Parashar sees privacy, consent and AI as key opportunities. AI can strengthen fraud detection, risk assessment and customer journeys, while privacy infrastructure will become increasingly important as India's data protection ecosystem evolves.

By 2035, Parashar expects India's startup ecosystem to become more globally competitive, with innovation increasingly emerging from Tier 2 and Tier 3 cities and success measured by the number of companies that evolve into enduring institutions. **BW**

kalyan@businessworld.in

Product is king

AKIS EVANGELIDIS on why authenticity, community engagement and product excellence remain central as Nothing scales in India

By Resham Suhail

F

or a consumer technology brand built around a distinctive identity, scaling without losing proximity to its community remains a central challenge.

For Nothing, Akis Evangelidis believes the answer lies in retaining the principles that shaped the brand from the outset. "In today's stage, with nothing, what has worked at least is to be very authentic as a brand," he states.

Staying authentic

He says that the company has remained consistent in how it approaches products, feedback and communication, particularly in a market where consumers are deeply engaged with digital platforms. He emphasises, "For us, ever since we started, we've been very authentic in how we approach product, how we take feedback, how we co-create with our users." That proximity, he

AKIS EVANGELIDIS

Co-founder & India President,
Nothing

Sector: Consumer Technology

Age: 36



Photograph by Naval Kishor

adds, "has really proved to build like a brand equity which has created a sense of community around the brand."

The response from that community has been visible, including at Nothing's Bengaluru store opening, where "2,000 people coming up just for the store opening" reinforced the value of that connection.

Focus on volumes, growth

While capital has become more selective across the startup ecosystem, Nothing continues to prioritise expansion. While stressing on its ambition, he adds, "Different phase of the business will have different priorities, but for us, it's still growth." He says the business remains focused on "driving volumes and sustaining the level of growth," given both the scale of the industry and the company's ambition in India.

However, the growth does not alter the product philosophy. Asked what capability he wants Nothing to be known for, his answer is direct, "making the best product."

Last year, London-based Nothing raised \$200 million in a Series C round at a \$1.3 billion valuation, led by Tiger Global, with participation from GV, Highland Europe, EQT, Latitude, I2BF, Tapestry, Nikhil Kamath and Qualcomm Ventures.

Scaling every link

India's smartphone market is complex well beyond product development, with a value chain spanning supply, distribution and demand creation where "there is really room for error." Working capital, demand generation, inventory, supply and mass production must align. "Everything is very sequenced, and you need to show up on every part of the value chain," he says. For Nothing, that operational discipline compliments its community-led identity as it builds for India. **BW**

resham@businessworld.in



THE 2ND EDITION NEXT-GEN DIGICONTENT SUMMIT & AWARDS



**NOMINATE
NOW**



OCTOBER 2026 | NEW DELHI

JURY PANEL

**DR. ANNURAG
BATRA**

Chairman &
Editor-in-Chief,
BW Businessworld,
& Founder,
exchange4media



**POOJA
ASAR**

Head Marketing
EV, Tata Motors



**IPSHITA
CHOWDHURY**

Head Marketing,
Motorola Mobility



**PRIYANKA BISEN
SHAH**

Head Digital
Marketing,
Bajaj Auto



**KAUSHIK
VEDULA**

Vice President,
Marketing, Castrol



**SAURABH
MATHUR**

Senior Vice
President, GIVA



**KARUN
ARORA**

Chief Marketing
Communications
Officer, Vivo India



**SATYAJIT
BAGCHI**

Marketing Head,
Nestle Purina



**SOUMITRA
PAL**

General Manager,
Marketing -
Passenger &
Non-Vehicular
Business, Tata
Motors



**SARTHAK
VIJ**

Head of Digital
Marketing
& D2C Business, Borosil



**ADITYA
KRISHNA**

Director, Sales and
Marketing, McCain
Retail



**ABHISHEK
RANJAN**

Digital Head,
DS Group



**POOJA
MENON**

Joint Vice
President (Head
Marketing), Aditya
Birla Health
Insurance



**NIYATI
SHARMA**

Head - Brand,
Marcom & Digital
Marketing, Kohler
India



**HARSH
VARDHAN**

Global Head - Digital
Innovation, Apollo Tyres



**PARTH
DESAI**

Head - Digital,
Martech & Ecom,
Pidilite Industries



**GAURANG
THOSANI**

Head of Digital &
AI Growth, Royal
Sundaram General
Insurance



**NISHANT
MISHRA**

Chief Marketing Officer,
Apollo Hospitals



**NOOR FATHIMA
WARSHA**

Group Editorial
Director
BW Businessworld



**RUHAIL
AMIN**

Sr. Editor
BW Businessworld



EVENT PARTNERS



For more contact:

Chetan Mehra: **+91 9811702464**,
chetan.mehra@businessworld.in

Parul Gupta: **+91 9870405950**,
parul.gupta@businessworld.in

Expanding the Nykaa playbook

From shaping Nykaa's early digital and retail businesses to scaling fashion and owned brands, **ADWAITA NAYAR** has helped broaden its entrepreneurial ambition **Team BW**

F

or Adwaita Nayar, the journey with Nykaa has been one of evolving with the business as its ambitions expanded. Part of the company since its formative years, she contributed to early product and website development, onboarded its first brand partners and helped shape the organisation before it had scale or certainty.

In 2017, Nayar took on a larger mandate, leading Nykaa's entry into offline retail. She launched 30 physical stores across two formats in roughly 18 months, establishing an early omni channel footprint. Her focus, however, soon extended beyond retail and digital commerce to a larger ambition: taking Nykaa from a marketplace to a platform that could build and scale brands.

Scaling the fashion bet

At Nykaa Fashion, Nayar has driven

a 20-fold expansion in five years, taking GMV from Rs 187 crore in FY20 to Rs 3,804 crore in FY25. The business now serves more than 10 million customers, with annualised GMV exceeding \$650 million.

Its growth has been anchored in a curation-led, brand-first strategy, with partnerships spanning global names including H&M, Nike, Calvin Klein, Gap, Guess and Victoria's Secret.

Operating metrics have also improved: in Q3 FY2026, Nykaa Fashion's GMV rose 31 per cent year-on-year to Rs 1,476 crore, while its EBITDA margin improved from -5.4 per cent in Q3 FY2025 to -2 per cent.

Building the House of Nykaa

Nayar's remit has also expanded into Nykaa's owned-brand portfolio. House of Nykaa recorded Rs 872 crore in GMV in Q3 FY2026, translating into an annualised run rate of Rs 3,500 crore, with more than 16 million customers across 12 beauty and fashion brands.

Dot & Key, Kay Beauty and Nykaa Cosmetics have emerged as significant growth engines.

The broader business has continued to scale. Nykaa's consolidated Q3 FY2026 GMV reached Rs 5,795 crore, up 28 per cent year-on-year, while revenue rose 27 per cent to Rs 2,873 crore. EBITDA grew 63 per cent to Rs 230 crore and PAT surged 156 per cent to Rs 68 crore.

For Nayar, Co-founder and Executive Director of Nykaa & CEO, House of Nykaa, the past decade has been defined by expanding the scope of what she builds — from the foundations of a digital beauty platform and an omni channel presence to a broader consumer ecosystem spanning fashion, owned brands and omnichannel retail. **BW**

Adwaita Nayar

Co-founder and Exe. Director,

Nykaa & CEO, House of Nykaa

Beauty & Personal Care

Age: 36

Smarter products, stronger growth

ABHIMANYU ASIJA on why India's next growth phase will depend on innovation, material efficiency, disciplined capital allocation and measurable customer value **By Kalyan Shobhana**



Abhimanyu Asija
Chairman & MD, Sommet Group
Sector: Manufacturing
Age: 39

“growth at any cost”. Capital, he argues, should fund a stronger core proposition, not customer acquisition or subsidised sales. The focus must shift from chasing growth to building businesses that create durable value.

His approach has shaped Sommet's growth over the last decade. With infrastructure expanding and demand for metals remaining strong, the company has focused on understanding changing market requirements, developing a differentiated business model and creating products that customers value. The strategy is helping Sommet cross Rs 1 billion in revenue this year.

A largely bootstrapped business, access to smarter working capital finance remains a challenge for Sommet. This has limited the pace at which it can pursue opportunities.

Closing that funding gap will be a priority in the next phase. Over the next three to five years, Asija aims to build on Sommet's existing foundation and take the business to Rs 500 crore, with infrastructure and electronics as key growth markets. The focus will remain on developing products and solutions that deliver greater customer value.

For Asija, the next phase will require the same balance that has shaped Sommet so far: disciplined capital allocation, innovation and customer focus.

Building for 2035

Looking towards 2035, Asija believes Indian entrepreneurs can play a much larger role in the country's economic transformation by tackling complex challenges rather than focusing only on low-entry-barrier B2C businesses.

The next decade, he believes, will belong to entrepreneurs who look beyond short-term growth and build businesses that create lasting value. **BW**

kalyan@businessworld.in

A

t 39, Abhimanyu Asija, Chairman & MD of Sommet Group, is building his manufacturing business on a simple premise: growth matters only when backed by a strong underlying business. As India's investment landscape turns more selective, Asija believes entrepreneurs must look beyond headline growth and focus on efficiency, innovation and measurable customer value.

This philosophy is particularly relevant to Sommet, which operates in the metals industry, where prices are at all-time highs and consumption continues to rise. For Asija, the opportunity lies in doing more with less – developing products that deliver better performance while using less material. “Smart entrepreneurs must focus on efficiency and design, minimising the quantity required to achieve the same results,” says Asija. Innovation in the value proposition, rather than growth for its own sake, will be the game changer.

He applies the same lens to startups, which, he believes, must move beyond

Digital trust drives India

ABHINAV PARASHAR on why the next decade will favour startups with sustainable models, strong governance, digital trust and a role in critical workflows **By Kalyan Shobhana**

I

ndia's startup ecosystem is entering a more selective phase, with investors placing greater weight on fundamentals, profitability and long-term value creation. In fintech and digital infrastructure, this is raising the bar for governance, technology and business models.

Abhinav Parashar, Co-founder and CEO of Digio, believes the next phase will favour businesses that become integral to critical customer workflows.

Sustainable value

For Parashar, the shift in funding markets makes one priority clear: building businesses that can withstand cycles, and create value even when capital is scarce. In fintech and digital infrastructure, that means strong unit economics, disciplined capital allocation, sound governance and a technology moat capable of enduring multiple market cycles.

He sees AI, enterprise technology, fintech infrastructure, digital identity, cybersecurity, deeptech, climate technology and healthcare infrastructure as areas with potential for durable growth.

Digio was born out of a problem Parashar saw in India's business processes, where paper-based documentation, physical presence and repetitive verification remained common. The company initially focused on making documentation and signing



Abhinav Parashar

Co-founder & CEO, Digio

Sector: Fintech

Age: 37

paperless and presence-less before expanding into a wider digital trust infrastructure platform.

"We realised that the larger challenge was building trust across the entire digital customer journey," he says. Digio now spans identity verification, digital onboarding, documentation, digital signing, payments and consent.

Over the past 12–18 months, the company has processed approximately 250 million identity verifications annually, 65 million digital signings, around 60 crore debits and nearly \$15 billion in payments. Parashar attributes the growth to increasing digitalisation and demand for integrated infrastructure.

Building for the next decade

As Digio scales, Parashar sees privacy, consent and AI as key opportunities. AI can strengthen fraud detection, risk assessment and customer journeys, while privacy infrastructure will become increasingly important as India's data protection ecosystem evolves.

By 2035, Parashar expects India's startup ecosystem to become more globally competitive, with innovation increasingly emerging from Tier 2 and Tier 3 cities and success measured by the number of companies that evolve into enduring institutions. **BW**

kalyan@businessworld.in

Product is king

AKIS EVANGELIDIS on why authenticity, community engagement and product excellence remain central as Nothing scales in India

By Resham Suhail

F

or a consumer technology brand built around a distinctive identity, scaling without losing proximity to its community remains a central challenge.

For Nothing, Akis Evangelidis believes the answer lies in retaining the principles that shaped the brand from the outset. "In today's stage, with nothing, what has worked at least is to be very authentic as a brand," he states.

Staying authentic

He says that the company has remained consistent in how it approaches products, feedback and communication, particularly in a market where consumers are deeply engaged with digital platforms. He emphasises, "For us, ever since we started, we've been very authentic in how we approach product, how we take feedback, how we co-create with our users." That proximity, he

AKIS EVANGELIDIS

Co-founder & India President,
Nothing

Sector: Consumer Technology

Age: 36



Photograph by Naval Kishor

adds, "has really proved to build like a brand equity which has created a sense of community around the brand."

The response from that community has been visible, including at Nothing's Bengaluru store opening, where "2,000 people coming up just for the store opening" reinforced the value of that connection.

Focus on volumes, growth

While capital has become more selective across the startup ecosystem, Nothing continues to prioritise expansion. While stressing on its ambition, he adds, "Different phase of the business will have different priorities, but for us, it's still growth." He says the business remains focused on "driving volumes and sustaining the level of growth," given both the scale of the industry and the company's ambition in India.

However, the growth does not alter the product philosophy. Asked what capability he wants Nothing to be known for, his answer is direct, "making the best product."

Last year, London-based Nothing raised \$200 million in a Series C round at a \$1.3 billion valuation, led by Tiger Global, with participation from GV, Highland Europe, EQT, Latitude, I2BF, Tapestry, Nikhil Kamath and Qualcomm Ventures.

Scaling every link

India's smartphone market is complex well beyond product development, with a value chain spanning supply, distribution and demand creation where "there is really room for error." Working capital, demand generation, inventory, supply and mass production must align. "Everything is very sequenced, and you need to show up on every part of the value chain," he says. For Nothing, that operational discipline compliments its community-led identity as it builds for India. **BW**

resham@businessworld.in

Growth built on fundamentals

From profitability before expansion to AI-led forecasting, **AMBRISH MIYANI** outlines how Indo Era is building for sustainable, system-driven growth **By Kalyan Shobhana**

I

ndia's apparel industry is entering a phase where sustainable growth, manufacturing strength and customer trust matter as much as scale. For Ambrish Miyani, 37, Co-founder and Managing Director of Indo Era, the priority is to build strong fundamentals before seeking external capital. Technology, data and supply chain control, he believes, can make businesses more resilient.

As investment capital becomes more concentrated, investors are placing greater emphasis on the quality of growth. Miyani's advice is simple: "Build your fundability before you need funding." Indo Era has crossed Rs 500 crore in revenue in six years without raising an external round, relying on capital discipline, backward-integrated manufacturing and repeat customers.

For Miyani, profitability must precede aggressive expansion. "You can rent growth with someone else's money, but you cannot rent profitability," he said. At the Indo Era, this has meant focusing on sourcing, manufacturing, pricing and customer retention before treating scale as a growth multiplier.

Filling a gap in ethnic wear

The company's origins lie in a gap Miyani and his co-founders identified in India's ethnic-wear market. They saw limited choice for stylish, well-made and affordable everyday wear.

"The gap we saw wasn't a lack of ethnic wear online — it was a lack of it done right for the everyday Indian woman," Miyani explained. The company sub-



Ambrish Miyani

Co-founder & MD, Indo Era

Sector: Apparel

Age: 37

sequently combined manufacturing capabilities with technology and faster execution. Indo Era has expanded from 120 SKUs to more than 8,000, with growth supported by repeat purchases and word of mouth. Miyani attributed this to stronger supply-chain capabilities, productivity and data-led decision-making.

Scaling via systems and data

Rapid expansion brought challenges around forecasting, inventory and

sizing. Looking back, Miyani believes stronger systems could have been established earlier. "The day your business can make a good decision without you in the room is the day it's genuinely ready to grow," he noted.

The next phase will focus on more than 25 exclusive brand outlets, greater omnichannel contribution, quick-commerce expansion and AI-driven demand forecasting and personalised CRM.

"The next decade won't belong to the companies that simply grew the fastest. It will belong to the ones that created real value, built strong fundamentals, and had the ambition to take Indian businesses to the world," he said. **BW**

kalyan@businessworld.in

Healthcare growth beyond beds

ANKITA ADITYA PARAKH says healthcare growth must move beyond beds and scale to outcomes, efficiency, standardised systems and enduring institutions **By Kalyan Shobhana**

H

healthcare is entering a phase where scale alone is no longer enough to define growth. For Ankita Aditya Parakh, 36, Chief Strategy Officer at Ashoka Health City, the focus must shift towards clinical outcomes, patient trust, operational efficiency and systems that can consistently deliver quality. The challenge, she believes, is to build healthcare institutions capable of expanding without becoming dependent on individuals.

From expansion to outcomes

“The most important strategic shift is to move from asset-led expansion to outcome-led, system-driven growth,” she stated. Adding beds or entering new markets, she explained, cannot remain the primary measure of progress. Healthcare organisa-

tions must demonstrate clinical outcomes, capacity utilisation, patient trust and operational efficiency while maintaining consistent quality.

Bringing advanced care closer

Parakh’s understanding of the healthcare gap was shaped by her professional background in biotechnology and life sciences and her experience after moving to Nashik. She saw families travelling to Mumbai and Pune for specialised treatment. “The gap was not merely a shortage of beds; it was the absence of an integrated regional ecosystem capable of delivering advanced, trusted care closer to home,” she explained.

Ashoka Health City has evolved into a 600-plus-bed integrated healthcare ecosystem, supported by more than 1,100 people, 75-plus full-time consultants and over 300 visiting and specialist consultants. Its institutions have collectively touched more than six lakh lives.

People behind the system

Scaling specialised healthcare in a Tier-2 city has also meant addressing the challenge of attracting and retaining skilled professionals. Parakh believes leadership development, integrated dashboards and standardised processes should have been strengthened earlier.

“My biggest lesson has been that systems must be created before complexity arrives,” she noted. Yet systems alone cannot create an enduring institution; a strong workforce built around capability, culture and ownership is equally important.

Parakh stated, “The true success of the startup ecosystem will not be measured only by the number of unicorns it creates, but by how many enduring institutions it builds, how many meaningful jobs it generates and how effectively it improves everyday life for people across India.” **BW**

kalyan@businessworld.in

ANKITA ADITYA PARAKH

Chief Strategy Officer, Ashoka Health City

Sector: Healthcare

Age: 36

“Build profitability, think long-term”

From repeat rates to supply-chain discipline, **ANKUR TYAGI** outlines why sustainable growth, customer trust and profitability will define the next decade

By Kalyan Shobhana

What are investors prioritising as capital becomes more selective?

Investors are becoming more selective, focusing on market size, growth, profitability and a clear path to profitability. For consumer brands, repeat rates are increasingly important because they show whether customers genuinely value a product and return. The key shift is to avoid chasing growth at any cost. Businesses need a large market, strong growth, healthy economics and customers who genuinely want to return. The next cycle will be defined by the quality of growth, not simply its size.

What change must founders make to build sustainable businesses over the next decade?

The biggest shift is profitability over valuation. Founders need to focus on strong unit economics, repeat customers and a clear path to profitability. I'm bullish on consumer, food and health, manufacturing, and technology-led businesses solving real Indian problems. The next decade will belong to companies built on strong fundamentals rather than funding alone.

What market gap led you to build Rosier, and how has the business performed?

I entered the sector after seeing a lack of trust in food due to adulteration and limited transparency. I saw an opportunity to build a brand where consumers know what they are buying and

Ankur Tyagi
Founder & CEO,
Rosier Foods
Sector: F&B
Age: 37

where it comes from. In just two years, Rosier has scaled to a Rs 150 crore ARR brand, profitably, with customer trust as the biggest growth driver and a repeat rate of over 50 per cent.

What has been the biggest challenge, and what did you learn?

The biggest challenge has been the supply chain, particularly in dairy. Maintaining consistent quality while growing quickly is difficult. If I could change one thing, I would have started earlier. I started at 34 and wish I had begun five years sooner. The biggest lesson is simple: don't wait for the perfect time. Start and learn along the way.

Where will Rosier's next phase of growth come from?

Our next phase will focus on deeper distribution, exports and expanding

further into the staples category. We do not want to move too far from what is already working. The focus is simple: take Rosier to more households and markets while staying true to our core.

How can Indian startups become engines of growth by 2035?

Indian startups need to build real and profitable businesses, rather than focusing only on fundraising and valuations. They can create jobs, support manufacturing and build Indian brands for global markets. By 2035, India can become one of the world's biggest startup ecosystems, with many Indian companies becoming global leaders. The focus should remain simple: solve real problems, build profitably and think long-term. **BW**

kalyan@businessworld.in



Photograph by Naval Kishor

The growth equation

ASHONAL CLERY PEREIRA is taking Mancunianz towards a more integrated, technology-led role in clients' growth, bringing together data, strategy and full-funnel marketing

By Aditi Das



A

shonal Clery Pereira, Founder and CEO of Mancunianz, sees the future of marketing in connecting functions that have traditionally operated separately. The agency was started after he saw brands working with multiple specialists across performance, content, brand and data, without those functions necessarily working as one. Pereira saw full-funnel marketing as a structural solution rather than simply a marketing term.

Over the past 12-18 months, Mancunianz has built momentum through deeper client relationships, larger integrated mandates and greater use of technology to deliver more efficiently. The biggest driver, he says, has been the trust built by solving broader marketing problems rather than simply executing campaigns.

From growth to efficiency

Pereira sees a more selective investment environment changing what makes businesses attractive. "Fewer deals and bigger cheques mean

ASHONAL CLERY PEREIRA

Founder & CEO, Mancunianz

Sector: Media & Marketing

Age: 35

investors are looking for proof, not just sporadic growth stories," he says, with capital increasingly directed towards businesses that demonstrate defensible economics and a clear path to sustainable growth.

Agencies and marketing-led businesses will need to move beyond growth driven primarily by numbers and headcount. Building systems, data and technology that make the business more scalable and efficient will become increasingly important.

That thinking also shapes Pereira's approach to sustainable growth. "The shift that cannot be compromised is treating profitability as a design principle, not something to fix later," he states. Businesses, he believes, need to balance growth with strong funda-

mentals and genuine customer value.

Marketing as growth

The next phase for Mancunianz will focus on moving up the value chain, from being an execution partner to becoming more deeply involved in clients' growth strategies. Pereira is betting on AI, data and integrated full-funnel marketing to make marketing more connected and accountable.

"The toughest challenge has been scaling a people-and-ideas business without compromising the quality of thinking," Pereira recalls. Maintaining the quality of strategy while expanding the business will remain central to Mancunianz's next phase.

By 2035, he expects Indian startups to hold stronger global positions across fintech, AI, deep tech, healthcare and technology-led services, with more category-defining businesses being built from India for the world. **BW**

aditi.das@businessworld.in

India's deeptech opportunity

AVINASH CHENREDDY on why speed, commercial discipline and specialised talent will determine India's next deeptech growth phase **By Kalyan Shobhana**

I

ndia's next wave of technology growth could extend well beyond software and consumer startups, with defence, semiconductors, robotics and other hard-tech sectors emerging as areas of strategic opportunity. For Avinash Chenreddy, 34, Co-founder & CTO of Constelli Signals, the focus is on building sophisticated electronic warfare, radar and communications systems while proving that deeptech businesses can combine innovation with commercial discipline.

From vision to execution

As investors become more selective, having a long-term vision is no longer enough. Companies must demonstrate progress through products, revenue and real-world deployment. For Chenreddy, this means shortening development cycles and getting systems into the field earlier. "The shift our sector needs to make is speed: run tighter development cycles, get real products into the field early, and start proving out real revenue," Chenreddy stated.

Profitability remains equally important. "What we're selling today has to be profitable, and we keep growing that year on year." Beyond AI and AI sovereignty, he sees semiconductors and robotics as promising areas for India, with applications across defence, space and automotive.

Building defence capabilities

The decision to enter electronic warfare emerged from a clear gap in India's



Photograph by Naval Kishor

Avinash Chenreddy

**Co-founder & CTO,
Constelli Signals**

Sector: Defence & Aerospace

Age: 34

defence technology ecosystem. India remained heavily reliant on imports for sophisticated electronic warfare systems, while specialised talent and domestic support for developing such technologies were limited. "The battles of today and tomorrow depend heavily on Electronic Warfare systems, and India remains largely reliant on imports for them," Chenreddy explained. Constelli has grown from around 50 to

more than 150 employees in 18 months. During the period, revenue grew 100 per cent, while the company raised US\$ 20 million in its Series A round.

Scaling deeptech

The next phase will focus on networked defence systems connecting sensors, communications and intelligent software across land, sea, air and space. Constelli is also exploring markets such as Southeast Asia and Australia while expanding its R&D capabilities and developing a new 30,000 sq ft facility. Looking towards 2035, he sees India's dependence on imported technology as an opportunity for domestic innovation. **BW**

kalyan@businessworld.in



BHUMAN DANI

Founder & CEO, WickedGud

Sector: F&B

Age: 38

What gap in the food market led to WickedGud?

The food industry relies heavily on *maida*, palm oil, refined sugar and artificial chemicals, making me realise that families deserve healthier choices. This led to our mission: “Unjunk India,

One Kitchen At A Time!” At WickedGud, we combine “Wicked Taste and Gud Ingredients” to create healthier alternatives to popular foods. Over the past six months, we have doubled net revenues to a Rs 50 crore ARR. Quick commerce has been our biggest growth engine, supported by Reliance and DMart expansion. More than 40 per cent of our turnover comes from three noodle SKUs, positioning WickedGud as a healthier alternative to India’s leading noodle brand.

What has been the biggest challenge in scaling the business?

Our toughest challenge has been balancing taste, health and price. We moved from gluten-free pasta to whole-wheat noodles without *maida* and palm oil, while introducing Rs 20 packs and new flavours. The biggest lesson is that consumers want better versions of foods they already love without compromising on taste or price. Brands should innovate around existing habits rather than ask consumers to change them.

What are the key growth priorities for WickedGud over the next 3–5 years?

Growth will come from going deeper into key markets, with quick commerce as a major engine. We will focus on masala noodles, expand our noodle portfolio and enter other better-for-you categories. Our next milestone is Rs 100 crore ARR within 12 months, with an ambition to reach Rs 300 crore+ ARR in three years. **BW**

kalyan@businessworld.in

“Better products, disciplined growth”

BHUMAN DANI on healthier alternatives, profitable growth, quick-commerce and building products that bring together taste, affordability and better ingredients **By Kalyan Shobhana**

Which sectors could drive India’s next growth phase?

The fundamental shift is from growth at any cost to disciplined, profitable growth. The next wave will come from sectors solving large, everyday Indian problems, including consumer, food, healthcare, financial services, manufacturing and AI. At WickedGud, we see the biggest opportunity where rising consumption meets convenience and better products. Health and food will increasingly come together. Our aim is to make food with better ingre-

dients without compromising on taste or price.

What are investors prioritising as capital becomes more selective?

The next cycle will reward quality of growth over growth at any cost. Consumer businesses need a clear path to profitability, proven demand and a truly omnichannel presence. Online growth alone will not be enough. Brands that succeed across quick commerce, modern trade and general trade will be better positioned.

“Build for relevance, not just scale”

BINNITA SHAH on staying relevant, building through specialisation, and why creativity, systems and client trust can drive growth without chasing scale **By Kalyan Shobhana**

What fundamental shift must founders make to build enduring businesses?

I think the founders who really endure are the ones who make one non-negotiable choice: staying relevant. Markets keep changing, so you have to understand what people need today and be willing to change how you sell, hire, price and deliver. I also believe sectors where deep specialisation matters more than scale have a strong opportunity. That includes creative and professional services, category-focused products, premium consumer brands and B2B SaaS businesses with real gross margins.

What drew you to real estate, and what has driven Venbridge’s growth?

After spending 13 years with leading Indian agencies, I saw real estate as a sector with enormous demand but also a clear creative and strategic gap. At Venbridge, we wanted to change that by building stories that actually help projects sell, combining strategy, creativity and execution. Since December 2023, our cumulative business growth has been 432 per cent. We have launched 24 luxury projects worth over Rs 5,000 crore, maintained 95 per cent client retention, and 95 per cent of our first-round strategies and presentations have gone live with only minor tweaks. Referrals also account for 80 per cent of our new business.

What tested the business most as you scaled?



Binnita Shah

Founder, Venbridge Real Estate

Advertising

Sector: Real Estate

Age: 37

The toughest part was building credibility as a specialist real-estate boutique when size is often seen as a measure of capability. Clients naturally questioned whether a smaller specialist team could deliver at scale. We had to prove that through our work. One example was launching three large-scale projects on the same day during Gudi Padwa 2026. That experience reinforced something important for me: you need systems that

help teams do more in less time, and you should scale only when the work actually demands it.

Where do you see Venbridge finding its next opportunities?

I see our next phase coming from three areas: going deeper with existing clients, expanding beyond residential and entering new geographies. We want to become long-term partners across multiple projects and verticals. There are opportunities in managed farm living, plots, commercial and hospitality as well. We are also looking at the possibility of launching an Indian project abroad or working with overseas developers. **BW**

kalyan@businessworld.in

#BWSECURITYCONFERENCE

BW SECURITY WORLD

www.bwsecurityworld.com

CONFERENCE 2026

THE AGE OF ANTICIPATORY LEADERSHIP

FOLLOWED BY

#BWSECURITY40U40AWARDS

BW SECURITY WORLD

www.bwsecurityworld.com



AWARDS 2026

RECOGNIZING FUTURE MASTERS
OF INDIAN SECURITY SECTOR

3RD EDITION



NOMINATE

> NOW

JURY PANEL

NEW DELHI



Dr. Annurag Batra

Chairman &
Editor-in-Chief
BW Businessworld
and Founder,
exchange4media



Kalyan Bose

President,
British Business Group



Dr Harsh Wardhan

Author, Former CEO of
G4S and Securitas and
Prof, BITS Pilani



Col Samrendra Kumar

Co-Founder & MD,
MitKat Advisory



Lt Col Himani Thapliyal

Head Security, Pernod
Ricard India



Prof (Capt) SB Tyagi

Chief Councillor,
ICISSM



Rupal Sinha

President,
BVG India



Swaminath Roy

AVP-Administration,
Tata Capital Limited



Maj Gen Sanjay Soi (Retd)

Executive Director Centre
for Defence Analysis &
Home Land
Security Research (CDAHSR),
Special Director, Binary
Global Ltd



Rekha Gairola

Global leader,
Safety & Security



Lt Cdr Ajit Singh Yadav

India Office Operations
Director,
BCG



**Maj Vashita Mehra
(Retd)**

Sr Director – Global
Security, Marsh &
McLennan



**Capt Vikas Yadav,
CSP, AVSEC**

Head Security,
PVR INOX Ltd



Bharat Vijayant

Director Safety, Security
& Compliance, IndiGo

EVENT PARTNERS



For Nominations:
Harsh Pandit, + 91 8796881369
harsh.pandit@businessworld.in

For Speakership:
Shilpa Chandel, + 91 9958693775
shilpa@businessworld.in



Aiming for the better ride

For EMotorad's **HIMANSHU RATNOO**, growth matters only when it translates into lasting value, accessible mobility and products built to endure
By Resham Suhail

always sort of solving the problems that we sort of started the journey with," he says. That ambition includes deep rural mobility initiatives and partnerships with self-help groups, with EMotorad working towards making mobility more accessible.

Over the next two years, Ratnoo says, the company aims to become one that "truly solves mobility problem for one, for people looking for a lighter commute option and for people who cannot afford a scooter or a vehicle".

The Value Reset

Ratnoo sees a similar recalibration underway across the startup ecosystem, where the emphasis is shifting towards sustainable value creation. "In the last 15 years there is increas-

ing realisation amongst promoters, amongst venture capitalists, EEs, identical founders that generating lasting value is more important than top line, bottom line and so on so forth," he explains. For founders, he says, "Your vision, your value, your ability to solve problem to its core for your target customer is more important than anything else."

Manufacturing Depth

Among sectors that remain under-penetrated, he identifies "manufacturing". He believes the sector needs greater startup participation, while noting that government initiatives and supply-chain integration are beginning to create momentum.

For EMotorad itself, the defining capability over the next two years is unequivocal, "I think quality." As an OEM, he says, "We need to be known for endurance and something that stands the test of time and odds of climates and weather and so forth." **BW**

resham@businessworld.in

Photograph by Naval Kishor



Himanshu Ratnoo

Co-founder & CEO, EMotorad

Sector: Mobility

Age: 38

E

Motorad's growth over the past 18 months has been accompanied by a sharper focus on the mobility problems that the company set out to solve. As the electric bicycle maker expands its footprint in India and overseas, Himanshu Ratnoo, Co-founder & CEO, EMotorad, says the business has made "significant stride in the last one-and-a-half years",

with growth increasingly being measured alongside the impact it seeks to create.

Scaling With Purpose

On the business trajectory, Ratnoo states, "Our exports have grown up to 10 to 15 times." He adds that "Our business has seen significant growth of 40-50 per cent in last one year and bottom line has also shown significant promise."

However, he maintains that financial performance is only one part of the company's larger mandate. "For us the more important piece is

“Building for the long run”

As **CENTURYPLY** targets Rs12,000 crore by FY31, its leadership weighs disciplined capital, organisational capability and the shift towards enduring businesses **By Resham Suhail**

How do you see India's startup ecosystem evolving by 2035?

By 2035, I would expect the startup ecosystem to be much broader than the consumer-internet ecosystem we have known over the last decade.

I would expect to see more deep-tech businesses, more manufacturing-linked innovation, more AI-led companies and more Indian businesses building products for global markets.

But ultimately, I don't think the success of the ecosystem should be measured by how many startups we have or how much capital they raise.

It should be measured by how many enduring companies they build, how much productivity they create and how much value they add to the economy.

What is the roadmap to take CenturyPly to new heights?

The last 12–18 months have been encouraging. Our consolidated revenue increased from around Rs 4,528 crore in FY25 to approximately Rs 5,397 crore in FY26, a growth of around 19 per cent. PAT increased by approximately 44 per cent to around Rs 268 crore.

So, Rs12,000 crore is an important milestone, but the larger objective is to build a much stronger and more diversified building-materials company, with manufacturing, brands, people and technology all working together.

We have a fairly clear roadmap. The immediate ambition is to take CenturyPly beyond Rs 12,000 crore of revenue by FY31.

The important thing is that we are not relying on one business to get there. Across plywood, laminates, MDF and



Keshav Bhajanka

Executive Director (Board of Directors), Century Plyboards

Sector: Manufacturing

Age: 37

particle board, we have a clear runway for growth.

What has scaling taught you about building an organisation?

I have learnt that failure is not necessarily the problem. The bigger problem is being afraid to make a decision because you are worried about getting it wrong. If I look back, I think we could have institutionalised certain capabilities earlier.

The biggest lesson for me is that

scaling a business is not about making it bigger. It is about making the organisation capable of being bigger.

What is changing in the way investors deploy capital?

If I had to identify one strategic shift, it would be from growth at any cost to growth with capital discipline. The businesses that know where the next rupee should go, and can demonstrate that it is creating long-term value, will continue to attract capital.

I don't think the concentration of capital necessarily means that investors are becoming less confident about India. If anything, the amount of capital being raised suggests the opposite. **BW**

resham@businessworld.in

From content to consumer intelligence

HiVoco Studios's **KRITIKA SINGH** sees behavioural insights, vernacular AI and hyperpersonalisation shaping the next frontier of branded content **By Pooja Patil**

F

or Kritika Singh, Co-founder and Chief Strategy Officer at HiVoco Studios, the next phase of India's branded-content industry will not be won by producing more campaigns. It will be won by understanding what consumers actually do when they encounter them.

Singh joined HiVoco as a client before becoming a co-founder, and saw a gap between creative execution and consumer understanding. "The question of how a campaign would actually land with a real person... was not being asked consistently enough," she says. That insight has since become central to the studio's strategy.

From Execution To Intelligence

Singh believes the concentration of private equity and venture capital is sending a broader signal: investors are becoming more selective, favouring businesses that can demonstrate tangible proof rather than potential alone. For the branded-content and AI marketing space, she sees the strategic shift as a move from services to insights.

HiVoco studies behavioural signals such as what keeps consumers on a page, what gets clicked or shared, and whether an interaction leads to another engage-

KRITIKA SINGH

Co-founder & Chief Strategy Officer, HiVoco Studios

Sector: Media & Entertainment

Age: 32



ment with a brand. The company says it does not store or access personal data, instead building cohort-level intelligence from consumer behaviour. "Companies that can demonstrate that their work changes consumer behaviour, not just consumer sentiment, will be the ones investors back in the next cycle," Singh says.

Scaling With Discipline

The shift has accompanied HiVoco's own expansion. The bootstrapped company has grown from a small core team to 24 employees, while revenue has more than doubled, according to Singh.

She says one of the company's early challenges was pricing. HiVoco was delivering work it considered above-market while charging below-market rates. Raising prices, she argues, also changed how the business was positioned. The next stage will focus on institutional clients, strategic partnerships and potentially external funding.

The India Opportunity

Singh's growth thesis centres on hyperpersonalisation, with HiVoco exploring voice AI for vernacular communication. She also sees a larger opportunity for Indian startups in building products around the country's linguistic, cultural and behavioural complexity. **BW**

pooja.patil@businessworld.in

Putting the borrower first

Peaceful Loans' **MANGESH ZOPE** is building a tech-enabled, advice-led home-loan model for premium borrowers, with transparency at its core **By Pooja Patil**

F

or a segment accustomed to aggressive sales calls and commission-driven distribution, Peaceful Loans is betting on a different proposition: make the borrower, rather than the lender, the centre of the home-loan journey.

Founded by Mangesh Zope, Peaceful Loans advises high-income households seeking home loans, particularly borrowers earning more than Rs 50 lakh annually and buying homes worth over Rs 2 crore. Zope believes this segment remains underserved despite being among the most credit-worthy borrowers in the market.

"The gap is Peaceful-Loans," Zope says, pointing to what he sees as a structural conflict in the traditional advisory model, where intermediaries are typically compensated by lenders. The company's proposition is built around unbiased advice, transparency, and helping customers make informed borrowing decisions.

A Scalable Business

The model has so far been built without external capital. Zope says Peaceful Loans operates at an 80 per cent-plus gross margin and has remained cash-flow positive, with organic content serving as a key customer-acquisition channel.

The company's growth has accelerated over the past year. Home-loan sanctions rose from Rs 15 crore in Q3 FY25-26 to Rs 27 crore in Q4, and then to Rs 48.5 crore in Q1 FY26-27. Zope



Mangesh Zope

Founder, Peaceful Loans

Sector: Fintech

Age: 39

says the company is on track for Rs 75 crore in the current quarter, with AUM growing about 70 per cent quarter-on-quarter.

Customer referrals are another important component of the model. According to Zope, customers who save money through the advisory often become the company's strongest brand advocates. The company claims customers can save Rs 15-20 lakh over the tenure of a Rs 1 crore loan, depending on the loan and terms.

Technology As The Moat

Scaling personalised financial advice, however, comes with a consistency challenge. To address this, Peaceful Loans has built "Joy", a proprietary intelligence layer that captures institutional learning from individual cases and translates it into standard operating procedures across banks, cities and even individual bankers. Zope says the technology is designed to ensure that the quality of advice does not depend on a particular employee's experience.

The company's next phase will focus on deepening its presence within the premium borrower segment rather than expanding across every home-loan category. **BW**

pooja.patil@businessworld.in

From materials to capability

RexEdge's **MOHIT GULYANI** is scaling advanced engineering, manufacturing and exports to capture India's industrial infrastructure opportunity and build a capability-led business

By Resham Suhail

A

s industrial infrastructure becomes increasingly demanding, RexEdge is positioning itself around advanced engineering products for power and cooling infrastructure, with applications spanning oil and gas, data centres, defence, chemicals and other infrastructure industries. "We are building advanced engineering products for power and cooling infra," says Gulyani, who sees a large industrial opportunity in India and globally alongside "a very visible inefficiency in the way resources are used."

The company has set up a large factory in Ahmedabad and has more than doubled its business over the past 12 months. It is currently at "an ARR of profitable Rs 250 crore" and expects to "further double the same in next 6-8 months." He attributes this growth to the com-

MOHIT GULYANI

Co-founder & Director,
RexEdge and RecommerceX

Sector: Manufacturing

Age: 37



pany's increasing proximity to end customers. "Instead of competing purely on price, we are increasingly competing on quality, reliability, technical capability, traceability and sustainability."

Moving Up The Chain

RexEdge plans to expand from materials into engineered and application-specific products, including "heat exchangers and liquid-cooling systems for data centres," he discloses while significantly scaling its tube and pipe business across high-specification industries. Exports are also expected to become "at least 50 per cent of our topline," he shares.

He identifies scaling manufacturing while maintaining quality, working-capital discipline and customer confidence as the toughest challenge. "One of the biggest lessons I have learned is that a founder can personally drive a business to a certain scale, but beyond that point, the organisation has to become stronger than the founder." In B2B manufacturing, he adds, "trust compounds."

The next phase of growth, he says, will come from expanding from materials into engineered and application-specific products, while also significantly scaling its tube and pipe business across oil & gas, chemical, pharma, energy, defence and other high-specification industries.

From Growth To Capability

At the broader startup level, he believes "The fundamental shift is from growth as the objective to value creation as the objective." He is particularly optimistic about manufacturing, technology, energy transition, climate solutions, industrial infrastructure, Data centres and supply-chain localisation.

By 2035, he expects Indian startups to be increasingly "innovation-led, manufacturing-led and capability-led." **BW**

resham@businessworld.in

Cooking up a category

Cumin Co.'s **NIHARIKA JOSHI** on building a complete kitchen ecosystem, owing customer repeat and creating brands from India for the world **By Resham Suhail**



C

umin Co.'s journey began with a problem at the dining table. "We found flakes of non-stick coating on our daughter's plate." What followed was a larger question, "why is finding healthy, beautiful and easy-to-use cookware so hard?" For Niharika Joshi, Co-founder, Cumin Co., that gap became the foundation for building a kitchenware brand around health, design and everyday usability.

From Product To Category

The company's recent growth has been driven by depth. "Revenue has grown many times over," she shares. Cumin Co. has expanded from one shelf to four, spanning cookware, bakeware and serveware, tools and accessories, and storage, while moving from a handful of products to more than two hundred.

Joshi attributes that expansion to four factors, channel expansion, faster launch velocity, depth and building what customers actually asked for. The approach has also shaped product development. "When custom-

Niharika Joshi

Co-founder, Cumin Co.

Sector: Consumer Goods

Age: 38

ers told us what was holding them back, we treated it as an engineering brief rather than an objection to argue with," she points out. Scaling, however, meant building more than a brand. "The hardest part was not building a brand. It was building a category," she describes.

Owning The Repeat

For her, the broader consumer opportunity is now moving beyond acquisition. "The one thing that cannot be compromised is the shift from acquiring customers to retaining them," she stresses. Her prescription is direct, "own the customer, own the repeat". As distribution becomes increasingly accessible across mar-

ketplaces, quick commerce and advertising platforms, she argues that "unit economics" is the enduring differentiator.

Building For The World

Cumin Co.'s next phase rests on three areas, materials, channels and depth, with the ambition of creating a "complete Cumin Co. kitchen ecosystem" across the Indian kitchen.

For Joshi, that ambition extends beyond India. "The next decade belongs to brands built from India for the world," she says, arguing that companies must build to a higher global standard from the outset.

By 2035, she believes the opportunity will depend not merely on the size of India's market, but on the capability of its companies to create products and playbooks that travel globally. **BW**

resham@businessworld.in

The consumer play

NITIN VINOD KALRA is scaling Let's Try from a snacking proposition into a broader Indian consumer brand built around taste, accessibility and sustainable growth

By Aditi Das

I

ndia's snacking market has long balanced familiarity with changing consumer preferences. Nitin Vinod Kalra, Founder, CEO & CMO of Let's Try, saw an opportunity between traditional Indian snacks and the newer healthy-snacking category, with a proposition centred on making everyday favourites better without compromising on taste, variety or affordability.

One of the company's key moves was replacing palm oil with groundnut oil, aligning its products with changing consumer expectations while retaining their familiar appeal. Over the past 12-18 months, Let's Try has scaled rapidly, reaching around Rs 500 crore in annual recurring revenue while expanding across categories and channels.

Growth With Discipline

Kalra sees the changing investment environment as a shift towards quality rather than growth at any cost. "The concentration of capital shows that investors are becoming more

NITIN VINOD KALRA

Founder, CEO & CMO, Let's Try

Sector: F&B

Age: 38

selective and increasingly looking for companies with sustainable business growth rather than simply burning cash," he states. That approach has shaped his view of how consumer businesses should scale. Strong product-market fit, consistent year-on-year growth, improving unit economics and disciplined cash management are becoming increasingly important as businesses compete for capital.

"The toughest challenge has been scaling fast without compromising the fundamentals of the business in terms of product, quality, consistency, supply chain and consumer experience," Kalra says. The experience also changed how he thinks about operational readiness.



Photograph by Naval Kishor

Looking back, he would have invested earlier in stronger systems and processes rather than solving problems as they emerged. Sustainable scale, he adds, depends on putting the right foundation in the right place early.

A Wider Consumer Brand

Let's Try's next phase will involve expanding beyond its identity as a snacking company. The business plans to enter new categories, strengthen its presence across channels and reach consumers across more occasions and needs, while continuing to develop products rooted in Indian tastes and consumer insights.

The ambition is to turn that expansion into lasting consumer loyalty rather than relying primarily on discounts or paid growth. "The next big milestone for us is to become a household brand with strong consumer loyalty and sustainable, profitable growth," Kalra believes. **BW**

aditi.das@businessworld.in

Building what matters

PIYUSH GOYAL is building Volks Energie around a simple premise: durable growth starts with solving hard, real-world problems **By Aditi Das**

I

ndia's energy transition is creating a new set of demands beyond generation. For infrastructure operating in remote and difficult environments, reliability can determine whether a project works as intended, making the systems that keep critical installations running as important as the power they consume.

That is the space Piyush Goyal, Co-Founder and CEO of Volks Energie, has spent the past 15 years building in. A chemical engineer by training, Goyal started Volks in 2011 and chose to build the company without external capital, focusing on mission-critical energy infrastructure where execution could matter as much as technology. "Stop selling capacity announcements and start showing commissioned, revenue-generating assets," he says.

Built For Reliability

The approach has taken Volks into some of India's most demanding operating environments. The company has crossed 500 mission-critical projects, including Nickel-Cadmium battery banks for Power Grid in Kargil, Dehradun and Ambala, as well as solar-plus-storage projects for BPCL, GAIL and Oil India and work for the BSF.

Volks recorded a topline of around Rs 60 crore in FY26, nearly three times its level 24 months earlier. For Goyal, the hardest projects have also become the company's strongest references.



Piyush Goyal

Co-founder and CEO,

Volks Energie

Sector: Energy

Age: 35

Discipline Over Growth

Building without outside capital has shaped his approach to growth. "Every rupee of growth should be earned from the business itself, not borrowed against the next round," he says. That discipline extends to deciding what not to pursue.

Long payment cycles on capital-intensive PSU projects have made cash management a challenge, but they have

also taught Goyal that a growing order book is not necessarily the measure of a healthy business. "Deciding which projects to say no to matters as much as winning the ones you chase," he says.

The next phase is focused on behind-the-meter and mission-critical storage for factories, data centres, pipelines and PSU infrastructure, alongside precision cooling, AI-led systems and proprietary technology.

Goyal also plans to double the business over the next 18 months and take Volks into international markets, with MENA emerging as a key opportunity. **BW**

aditi.das@businessworld.in

“Sustainable profitability will be the new growth metric”

PRIYAM PARIKH on why sustainable profitability, stronger fundamentals and cash generation will define investment-worthy companies as India's startup ecosystem enters its next phase

By Resham Suhail

With capital becoming more selective, what strategic shift must companies make to remain investment-worthy?

Capital is no longer chasing possibilities, it is chasing conviction and sustainability. Investors are increasingly preferring fewer companies with stronger fundamentals, better governance, clearer paths to profitability, and the ability to scale sustainably.

In my view, the one strategic shift companies must make today to remain investment-worthy tomorrow is moving from growth-led valuation to capability-led valuation. Sustainable profitability will become the new growth metric.

What attracted you to the consumer goods and beverage industry, and what has driven growth?

What attracted me to the consumer goods and beverage industry is its unique combination of scale, emotional connection and societal impact. The opportunity I saw was the ability to modernise a traditional category while preserving the trust built over generations.

Over the last 12 to 18 months, our business has demonstrated healthy growth driven by three factors, premiumisation of our portfolio, distribution expansion and stronger consumer engagement through modern channels.

The biggest driver of growth has been our ability to combine a trusted legacy brand with evolving consumer

preferences.

What has been the biggest challenge and the key lesson?

The biggest challenge over the last two years has not been growth. It has been managing growth in an environment characterised by volatility. One lesson stands out, never confuse short-term performance with long-term competitiveness. The organisations that win today are not always the fastest. They are the fast learners.

For your company, where will the next phase of growth come from?

The next phase of growth will come from three major opportunities. Premiumisation, new consumption channels, adjacent categories and innovation. The major bet over the next five years is on building a stronger consumer ecosystem rather than simply selling more products.

What could India's startup ecosystem look like by 2035?

The next chapter cannot be built purely on consumption. It must be built on innovation. Most importantly, I believe India will move from being known as a startup hub to being known as an innovation powerhouse. The next decade is about proving that India can become a scale innovator. **BW**

resham@businessworld.in

PRIYAM PARIKH

Whole Time Director, Gujarat
Tea Processors & Packers

Sector: F&B

Age: 37



Beyond the sale

RAGINI VARMA is helping Fynd move retail technology from disconnected systems to measurable outcomes across markets, products and customer journeys **By Aditi Das**

F

rom the outside, a retail transaction can take seconds. Behind it sits a far more complicated chain: storefronts, inventory, marketplaces, logistics and supply networks, often running on systems that were never designed to speak to one another. It was this fragmentation that first drew Ragini Varma, Chief Business Officer - India at Fynd, to retail technology.

Her route into the sector was not planned; curiosity and a taste for complex problems led her towards a business where technology could change not just the customer experience, but the machinery behind it.

Fynd has since built an AI-native unified commerce platform spanning storefronts, stores, marketplaces, supply chains, logistics, manufacturing and customer experience. Today, Fynd works with more than 2,300 brands, supports over 20,000 stores and serves more than 300 enterprise customers.

Making Technology Count

Varma's focus is increasingly on what happens after technology is



Ragini Varma
Chief Business Officer
— India, Fynd
Sector: Ecommerce
Age: 39

deployed. In a more selective investment environment, she sees a shift from selling capabilities to proving outcomes, including better inventory utilisation, faster fulfilment, higher conversion and lower cost to serve. Her hardest challenge has been helping retailers adopt new technology without disrupting existing operations.

Rather than replacing everything, Fynd connects with the systems businesses already use. "The biggest lesson is that signing a customer is only the beginning." Lasting growth, she says, comes from making technology work in the customer's everyday business and consistently delivering what was promised.

From India, Outward

Fynd Create extends the business further into design, sourcing and production, connecting demand intelligence with product development and manufacturing through a network of more than 800 vendors, fabric mills and manufacturing partners. Early deployments have reported improvements of up to 60 per cent in design productivity. AI is also moving into customer-facing workflows: by April 2026, Fynd's conversational commerce agent had processed more than 4.3 million interactions and served over 1.1 million users.

Over the next three to five years, Varma sees Fynd building deeper enterprise relationships across the GCC, UK, South Africa and Southeast Asia, with repeatable deployments and a stronger international revenue contribution. **BW**

aditi.das@businessworld.in

“Density without discipline is a fragile company”

Rapido's **RISHIKESH SR** on taking affordable mobility deeper into Bharat, scaling with discipline and using technology to build a denser, more efficient network
By Resham Suhail

What gap in India's mobility market led to Rapido, and what has driven its growth?

We started Rapido around that simple observation, that India needed mobility that was not only convenient but accessible too. The biggest driver of growth has been that we have moved beyond thinking of Rapido as only a bike-taxi company. We have expanded the network across mobility categories while continuing to focus on the same underlying consumer need: affordable, reliable, and convenient intra-city transportation.

What has been Rapido's toughest scaling challenge?

The toughest challenge of the last two years, scaling across Bharat while competition, local market behaviour, unit economics, and regulation all moved at once. Over the past few years, the volume outran some of the systems



RISHIKESH SR

Co-founder, Rapido

Sector: Mobility

Age: 39

that should have grown with it. It is easy to focus on the next milestone and underestimate how much complexity gets added when you operate at a national scale. “we’ll fix governance later” is not a strategy. The biggest lesson is that density without discipline is just a larger fragile company. Demand and supply have to balance without a permanent bribe.

Where will Rapido's next phase of growth come from?

The next phase of growth will come from deepening the mobility network rather than simply expanding for the sake of expanding. There are two areas we are particularly focused on. The first is Deeper Bharat, not another metro war. We spent years stuck behind an artificial “top 70–80 cities” line. That line is gone. Eighteen months took us from ~90 cities to 400+. The next 18 months should add another large block, district headquarters first, then taluks and towns where there is no metro and barely a bus. Motorcycles already live there. The product is last-mile that public transport never built. Bike taxi remains the fastest-growing engine and still gets the bulk of capital.

Second is using technology to make the entire network more efficient - better matching, lower waiting times, better utilisation for Captains, more predictable earnings, and a better experience for customers.

How can startups become engines of India's growth by 2035?

For startups to become engines of India's growth, they have to solve problems at India's scale. By 2035, I expect India's startup ecosystem to be much broader than the current technology-led narrative. We should see globally competitive companies coming out of areas such as manufacturing, mobility, logistics, climate, healthcare, financial services, and deep technology, alongside consumer internet. **BW**

resham@businessworld.in

From science to scale

At Supriya Lifescience, **SALONI SATISH WAGH** is expanding beyond APIs into specialised products, regulated markets and a broader global pharmaceutical footprint **By Aditi Das**

F

or **Saloni Satish Wagh**, Managing Director at Supriya Lifescience, the next phase of the business is about creating greater depth across science, manufacturing and global reach. At Supriya, she saw an opportunity to build on its API base while moving into more specialised products, regulated markets, formulations and CMO/CDMO opportunities.

The strategy is reflected in the numbers. In Q1 FY27, revenue rose 30.8 per cent year-on-year to Rs 189.75 crore from Rs 145.07 crore in Q1 FY26, while EBIT-DA stood at Rs 47.46 crore.

Deepening The Business

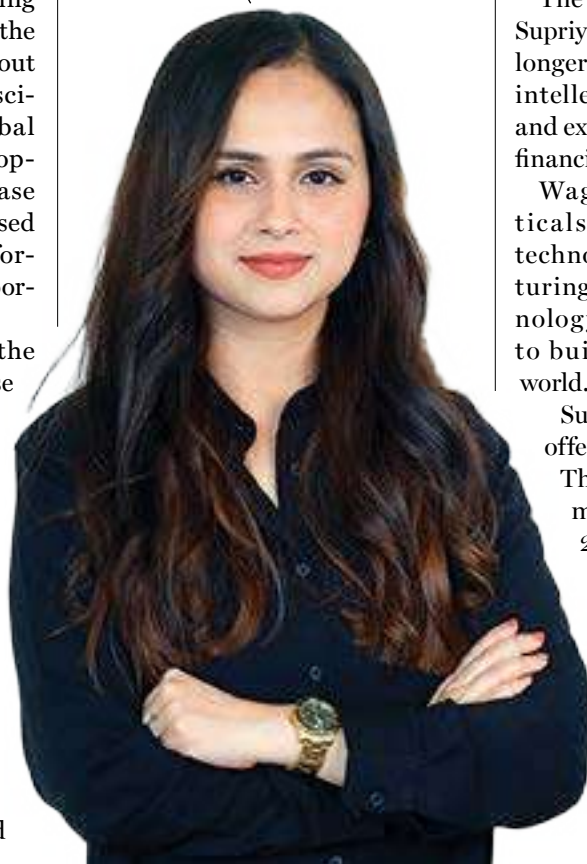
For Wagh, the next stage is about strengthening the business from within. “The shift I would make is towards greater depth in the business,” she says, pointing to investments in backward integration, R&D and new products, alongside CMO and

Saloni Satish Wagh

Managing Director, Supriya Lifescience

Sector: Healthcare

Age: 35



CDMO opportunities and finished formulations. In Q1 FY27, 72 per cent of revenue came from backward-integrated products and 81 per cent from exports.

“The toughest part has been managing expansion without losing focus on the business that is already running,” Wagh recalls, describing the work at Supriya’s Lote facility, where maintenance and improvements affected production during part of FY26 while the new Module E expansion progressed. By Q1 FY27, total reactor capacity had reached 932 KLPD across five manufacturing blocks.

Expanding Horizons

The next three to five years will focus on new products, regulated markets, finished formulations and CMO/CDMO. Supriya is planning two launches in anaesthetics and two in ADHD in FY27, while its R&D team has grown to more than 68 scientists across Lote and Ambernath.

The opportunity extends beyond Supriya. “These businesses may take longer to build, but they can create intellectual property, skilled jobs and export opportunities alongside financial value,” she states.

Wagh adds that pharmaceuticals, biotechnology, medical technology, specialised manufacturing, chemicals and clean technology are areas with potential to build from India and for the world.

Supriya’s international footprint offers a measure of that ambition. The company has a presence in more than 120 countries. By 2035, Wagh wants to see more Indian companies develop expertise, talent, and manufacturing capabilities at home while earning a meaningful place in global markets. **BW**

*aditi.das@
businessworld.in*

From learning to impact

Skills Caravan's **SHREYA VERMA** on why the next phase of HRTech will be defined by measurable business impact, AI-led workforce intelligence, and sustainable growth **By Sonali Chawhan**

A

s India's startup ecosystem moves away from growth at any cost, HRTech and LearningTech are also being pushed towards a more measurable model of value creation.

Shreya Verma believes the next phase will be defined by platforms that can connect workforce capability directly to business outcomes. That means moving beyond simply digitising existing learning processes.

Enterprises, she says, will increasingly ask not how many people are using a platform, but what business problem it has solved — from improving productivity and closing skill gaps to reducing time-to-competency and strengthening internal mobility.

Skills Caravan is building around AI, skill intelligence and personalised development to address these needs.

"The next generation of HRTech will not be judged by how much learning it delivers, but by how much business impact it creates," states Verma.

Her view also reflects a broad-change in startup economics.

SHREYA VERMA

Founding Member & VP – Product & Customer Success, Skills Caravan

Sector: Education

Age: 36

Verma says founders are increasingly building for profitability from day one, prioritising runway and sustainable growth over repeated fundraising.

The company has grown more than two-fold year-on-year over the past 12–18 months, according to Verma, supported by higher average contract values, a growing client base, renewals and stronger platform adoption.

The larger shift, she says, has been from being viewed as a learning platform to becoming a strategic partner for organisations seeking skill intelligence and improved L&D returns.



Photograph by Naval Kishor

Building For Outcomes

One of the toughest challenges has been balancing three stakeholders: L&D teams seeking adoption and measurable outcomes, CXOs focused on productivity and business performance, and employees looking for relevant, personalised career development.

The experience has reinforced a central lesson for Verma: products need to create value across the entire ecosystem, not only for the person who buys them.

Over the next three to five years, Skills Caravan plans to deepen its AI-led workforce intelligence and skill-building capabilities, expand across white-collar and blue-collar workforces, increase enterprise adoption and enter more geographies.

Verma describes the ambition as moving from an LXP that helps people learn to an AI-powered platform that helps organisations understand, develop and deploy talent better. **BW**

sonali.chawhan@businessworld.in

And It Begins.

The search for India's most impactful **organizations** and **leaders** starts today.

Award Applications Open Now



Share Your Impact Story



BWDISRUPT

www.bwdisrupt.com

5TH EDITION

**SOCIAL
IMPACT**

A W A R D S 2 0 2 6

Scan to
Nominate



NOVEMBER 2026 | NEW DELHI

Contact Us:

Sahil Saha | sahil.saha@businessworld.in | +91 9674217523

Engineering India's electronics edge

SNEH SHAH is scaling Aimtron through design-led manufacturing, specialised capabilities and intellectual property as India's electronics opportunity expands **By Pooja Patil**



Sneh Shah

**Whole-Time Director,
Aimtron Electronics**

Sector: Technology

Age: 33

A

t 39, **Sneh Shah**, Whole-Time Director at Aimtron Electronics, is building his case for the next phase of India's electronics manufacturing story, where companies compete not merely on capacity, but on design, engineering and intellectual property. Part of a select list of entrepreneurs under 40, Shah sees a significant opportunity for Indian manufacturers to move up the value chain

and own more of what they build, especially as capital grows selective.

July PE/VC investments in India stood at \$4.1 billion, even as deal volumes fell 7 per cent year on year to 111. Fundraising, however, reached a record \$23.7 billion in the first seven months of 2026. He believes the changing funding environment is placing greater emphasis on execution, cash conversion and visibility over growth narratives.

From capacity to capability

Shah's approach at Aimtron reflects his belief that electronics manufacturers need to move beyond contract assem-

bly towards design-led manufacturing. "When you own the design IP and the qualification, you are not displaced by whoever quotes two per cent lower next quarter," he says.

The strategy is reflected in Aimtron's performance. FY26 consolidated revenue grew 89.2 per cent year-on-year to Rs 301.2 crore, while profit after tax rose 79.4 per cent to Rs 46 crore. Its unexecuted order book stood at about Rs 604 crore as of June 30, 2026.

Aimtron is building capabilities across design, original design manufacturing (ODM) and box-build manufacturing, focusing on network security, green energy, industrial IoT and AI. Shah sees potential in electronics components and ESDM, energy storage, defence and aerospace, industrial automation, robotics and medical electronics. What links these sectors, he says, is the complexity of

their qualification process.

"Eighteen to 24 months of audits and documentation" can make these markets difficult to enter, but also harder to displace competitors once established. Aimtron is expanding into railway signalling, defence and aerospace, medical electronics and battery energy storage, while strengthening its international presence.

Its Vadodara greenfield facility, planned for production in Q4 2027, is expected to add SMT, injection moulding and sheet-metal capabilities.

For Shah, India's emergence as a global electronics hub ultimately depends on how much intellectual property and engineering capability its companies control. "Incentives can buy capacity. They cannot buy capability," he says.

By 2035, Shah expects a smaller number of larger, globally credentialled Indian electronics companies, with India evolving from a build location into a source of designs, components, systems and IP. **BW**

pooja.patil@businessworld.in

From Himalayan roots to global petcare

SNEH SHARMA is scaling Dogsee from a Himalayan-origin pet treat brand into a global, multi-category pet-wellness business
By Pooja Patil

S

neh Sharma, Co-founder and CMO of petcare startup Dogsee, is building a global consumer brand around an unlikely Indian advantage: the country's manufacturing, sourcing and craft capabilities. Part of a select list of entrepreneurs under 40, Sharma believes the next generation of enduring Indian companies will be those that use these strengths to build brands for consumers beyond India.

Dogsee's growth reflects this ambition. The company closed FY2025-26 with \$7.56 million in revenue and is targeting \$15.8 million in FY2026-27. Ecommerce revenue grew 359 per cent year-on-year in the first five months of the current fiscal, with its contribution rising to 49 per cent from 40 per cent in FY2025-26.

Secured supply chain

Sharma believes the changing funding environment is rewarding businesses with capital

efficiency, defensible economics and a credible path to exits. At Dogsee, that has meant owning manufacturing and building a direct sourcing network of more than 25,000 Himalayan farmers instead of relying on intermediaries.

The model requires greater upfront investment but, Sharma argues, creates an advantage that capital alone

cannot easily replicate.

Dogsee's origins lie in chhurpi, a traditional hard cheese made from yak milk. Inspired by Sharma's dog Mowgli chewing the product, Dogsee positioned the Himalayan treat as a natural, long-lasting alternative to conventional rawhide chews. It now says it serves more than a million pet parents across 30-plus countries, with 95 per cent of revenue generated outside India.

The US remains Dogsee's largest market, with Amazon USA growing at close to 10 per cent month-on-month. The company has also expanded through Walmart, Chewy, TikTok Shop and its own D2C platform. Tariffs have tested the model, with Indian-origin goods facing rates of up to 50 per cent during the latter part of FY2025-26. The effective rate on current shipments is 15 per cent, she says.

From chews to pet wellness

Dogsee plans to enter supplement chews, food toppers, dental treats and omega oil, targeting a combined US addressable market of about \$1.67 billion annually.

It is also entering Canada and the EU with local entities and warehousing, while building a UK D2C presence. By mid-2028, Dogsee plans to enter the cat-care segment through Catsee.

For Sharma, the larger goal is to evolve from a Himalayan chew maker into a global pet-wellness brand, and provide a proof point for Indian companies seeking to build globally recognised consumer brands. **BW**

pooja.patil@businessworld.in



Photograph by Naval Kishor

Sneh Sharma

Co-founder & CMO, Dogsee

Sector: Petcare

Age: 37

**SNEHA ROY****Co-founder & COO, Murf AI****Sector: Artificial Technology****Age: 38**

She also sees a greater opportunity for Indian technology companies to build for global markets from the outset. AI infrastructure, in particular, is an area she expects to generate significant opportunities, with voice AI evolving from a content-creation tool into infrastructure for AI agents.

Murf was founded around a simple problem: producing high-quality voice content was slow and expensive. Today, Roy says, the company has over 10 million users, works with 300+ Forbes 2000 companies and reaches customers across 190+ countries. Its API is also used by developers and enterprises for production-grade voice agents.

Making voice AI scale

SNEHA ROY is helping Murf AI build a globally scaled voice technology business focused on proprietary technology, efficiency and durable growth **By Sonali Chawhan**

A

t Murf AI, Sneha Roy, Co-founder & COO, is helping build a voice AI company with ambitions that extend well beyond content creation. Roy believes the next phase of technology entrepreneurship will be defined by durability – proprietary technology, efficient economics and the ability to build for global markets.

“The strategic shift has to be from building for adoption to building for durability,” Roy says. She sees lasting

advantage coming from differentiated infrastructure, proprietary data, efficient architectures and strong distribution. At Murf, she says, efficiency is treated as part of the product itself, particularly in voice AI, where model quality must be balanced with latency and cost.

From growth to value

Roy believes India’s startup ecosystem is entering a phase where founders must move from “growth at any cost” towards compounding value. Product-market fit, capital efficiency, customer retention, contribution margins and technology or distribution advantages, she says, will become increasingly important.

Making voice infrastructure

Roy identifies scaling complexity without losing speed and focus as one of the toughest challenges of building a global voice AI business. Different languages, accents, code-mixed speech, network conditions, latency requirements, security needs and regulatory environments create challenges beyond controlled demonstrations.

Looking ahead, Murf’s growth strategy centres on making voice a foundational layer for AI applications. Roy points to customer service, sales, healthcare, financial services and commerce as areas where voice-enabled AI agents could expand.

The company’s focus includes lower latency, multilingual and code-mixed speech, context-aware models, global reliability and enterprise governance. She also expects voice to increasingly work alongside text, images and video.

For Roy, the larger opportunity for India lies in building technology that travels beyond its domestic market. “The next decade should therefore be about moving from built in India to built in India, for the world.” **BW**

sonali.chawhan@businessworld.in

Engineering better outcomes

SRIDHAR SAMPATHIRAO is steering Thoucentric towards measurable outcomes as AI changes the economics of technology and consulting **By Sonali Chawhan**

F

or Sridhar Sampathirao, Founding Partner & CXO, Thoucentric, the next phase of technology and consulting will be defined by value creation rather than growth alone. As investors become more selective, Sampathirao believes companies need to demonstrate customer value, repeatable economics and a defensible moat from the outset.

The changing investment environment, he argues, is already signalling this shift. In July, investment value rose 3 per cent year-on-year even as deal volumes declined, with 10 large deals accounting for 68 per cent of total investment. For companies seeking to remain investment-worthy, he believes profitability and differentiation need to be built into the business from the start.

For technology and consulting companies, Sampathirao believes the focus must move beyond selling capabilities to delivering measurable business outcomes. As AI reshapes the economics of technology and services, value creation, he argues, will increasingly matter more than team size, revenue growth or project volumes.

Redefining growth

Sampathirao believes India's next startup phase will require founders to rethink what growth means. Deep customer understanding, products that solve genuine problems, discipline around unit economics and cash, and organisations that can scale beyond their founders are, in his view, essential to building enduring businesses.

He sees deep-tech as a significant



Sridhar Sampathirao

Founding Partner & CXO,

Thoucentric

Sector: Technology

Age: 39

opportunity, supported by increasing public-sector risk capital and entrepreneurship. Sports-tech and faith-tech, he adds, remain relatively under-capitalised areas with potential.

AI sits at the centre of many of these opportunities. Sampathirao expects it to become embedded in how businesses are built and operated, rather than simply being added as another product feature.

Building for outcomes

At Thoucentric, Sampathirao is putting this philosophy to work through an AI-native Forward Deployment Engineering model. Consultants work alongside clients to understand problems, rapidly prototype solutions and deploy them within the client environment.

The objective is to take consulting beyond recommendations towards building, deployment and measurable value realisation. Looking ahead, he sees AI-led business reinvention and early-stage entrepreneurship as interconnected growth areas. He also expects AI to lower the cost of building companies, enabling small teams to orchestrate multiple AI agents across functions. **BW**

sonali.chawhan@businessworld.in

The durability imperative

SWATI BABEL is building Globizera into a multi-market trade finance platform by combining execution, institutional partnerships and disciplined growth **By Sonali Chawhan**



F

or Swati Babel, Founder & CEO, Globizera Services FZCO, the next phase of entrepreneurship is about building businesses that can withstand cycles rather than simply chase the next funding round. As investors become selective, she believes companies need stronger revenue quality, governance, profitability, scalability and resilience.

That philosophy is reflected in Babel's approach to building Globizera, a trade finance and working-capital solutions provider. Drawing on two nearly decades of experience in cross-border trade finance, she repeatedly saw credible businesses with confirmed orders struggle to access working capital because available facilities did not match their geography, tenor, collateral or cash cycle. Globizera was built to bridge that

gap by structuring trade requirements and connecting businesses with banks, private credit providers, insurers, export credit agencies and development finance institutions.

Building for durability

Babel sees the opportunity in shifting trade finance from founder-dependent, relationship-led operations towards to institution-led, data-backed businesses. Repeatable origination, disciplined credit assessment, compliance, concentration controls and clear portfolio visibility, she says, are critical to building an investment-worthy financial business.

The Dubai-based venture has grown into a multi-market operation, with a Mumbai branch and a ten-member team. It became profitable in its first year, and generated \$1 million in revenue in its last completed year, with a profit-after-tax margin of around 60 per cent. Transaction volume rose from \$100 million in Year 1 to \$250 million in Year 2, while its Year 3 pipeline crossed \$500 million in the first quarter.

Babel attributes the growth to execution, repeat mandates and client referrals. Scaling however has reinforced the need for people and processes to keep pace with earlier hiring, standardised deal screening and clearer transaction ownership helping reduce founder dependence. The company is now targeting the India-Middle East corridor, Africa and Southeast Asia, while expanding into receivables and payables finance, supply-chain finance, inventory-backed facilities and more complex institutional funding.

Beyond finance

By 2035, Babel expects technology-led companies to be embedded across manufacturing, healthcare, energy, agriculture, trade and public infrastructure, with startups increasingly measured by how much they improve productivity and competitiveness beyond their own businesses. **BW**

sonali.chawhan@businessworld.in

SWATI BABEL

Founder & CEO, Globizera

Services FZCO

Sector: Fintech

Age: 39



Scaling with discipline

TARANJIT SHAH SINGH is building Berry Brothers into a profitable F&B brand by prioritising viable stores over rapid outlet expansion **By Sonali Chawhan**

Taranjit Shah Singh

Founder & CEO, Berry

Brothers

Sector: F&B

Age: 39

F

or **Taranjit Shah Singh**, Founder & CEO, Berry Brothers, growth is about more than adding outlets or chasing scale. As the startup ecosystem shifts towards quality of growth, Singh believes expansion must be rooted in sound economics.

As a bootstrapped and profitable business, Berry Brothers has taken a different route from the capital-intensive models that have defined parts of the startup ecosystem. Singh believes consumer F&B needs to move from growth-led economics to economics-led growth, where every new outlet, market or format adds meaningfully

to the business.

Growth by design

“The fundamental shift is from ‘growth at any cost’ to ‘sustainable growth by design,’” Singh says. For him, profitability, repeat customers, revenue quality and disciplined capital allocation are becoming stronger indicators of business health.

Singh entered the fresh beverage space after identifying a gap between traditional juice outlets and the premium, organised beverage experience emerging consumers were seeking. He built Berry Brothers around fresh juices, smoothies and beverages positioned within premium retail environments.

Over the past 12–18 months, the company has continued to grow while remaining bootstrapped and profitable. Berry Brothers now operates across

leading malls in multiple Indian cities, with annualised revenue of approximately Rs 4.5–5 crore and year-on-year growth of around 15–20 per cent.

Singh attributes this performance primarily to disciplined location selection and strong store-level economics.

Beyond outlet count

The next phase will focus on deeper penetration of premium retail destinations, expansion into high-potential cities and adjacent concepts around healthier, fruit-led consumption. One such initiative is Tropiq, a fruit-led concept centred on fresh fruit bowls, açai bowls and fresh fruit desserts.

For him, the larger objective is to demonstrate that an Indian, founder-led and bootstrapped F&B brand can scale nationally while remaining fundamentally profitable. “Not every opportunity to expand is an opportunity to grow,” he says, underlining the importance of repeating profitable formats rather than simply increasing store numbers.

Looking towards 2035, Singh expects Indian entrepreneurship to become increasingly defined by the value businesses create through employment, supply chains, brands and profitable operations. For founders, the question, he believes, will increasingly shift from how much capital they have raised to what they have built. **BW**

sonali.chawhan@businessworld.in

“Growth through pricing power”

Campus CEO **Uplaksh Tewary** explains to **Resham Suhail** why consumer brands must prioritise pricing power, profitability and premiumisation, while building deeper consumer pull beyond metros



Photograph by Naval Kishor

As capital becomes more selective, what shift must consumer brands make to remain investment-worthy?

For consumer brands, the one strategic shift is to grow through pricing power, not just pairs and doors. Investors will increasingly reward quality of growth, not reach alone. As the market becomes more selective, companies will need to demonstrate that scale is translating into healthier margins, stronger cash flows and better realisation. That means building differentiated products, strengthening the premium end of the portfolio and creating genuine consumer pull, rather than relying purely on distribution expansion.

What principle must founders embrace to build sustainable businesses, and which models could drive the next growth phase?

Profitability needs to be a design principle from day one, not a milestone to reach later. The next phase of India's startup growth is likely to be led by Bharat-first consumer brands offering aspirational quality at accessible

UPLAKSH TEWARY

Chief Operating Officer, Campus Activewear

Sector: Retail/Footwear

Age: 39

price points, particularly across tier 2-4 markets; manufacturing and supply-chain businesses benefiting from global sourcing diversification; and AI-native software solving tangible operating challenges for enterprises and MSMEs.

What market gap shaped Campus's proposition, and what has driven its growth?

The gap was clear. India's sports and athleisure footwear market was largely split between expensive global brands and unbranded products. There was a large, aspirational consumer, particularly beyond the metros, looking for a combination of style, comfort and durability at an accessible price point. That is the consumer Campus has built its

proposition around. The biggest driver has been our ability to combine scale with sharper consumer understanding, particularly as sports and athleisure become increasingly integrated into everyday lifestyle and fashion.

What has been the key headwinds and lessons from the journey?

The biggest challenge has been building for scale while retaining the agility to respond quickly to a rapidly changing consumer and business environment.

The biggest lesson is to confront the brutal facts early. The problems that hurt the most are often visible in the data months before they become obvious in the P&L.

What is the roadmap for the next phase of growth?

Our next phase of growth will come from premiumisation, led by sneakers and athleisure, deeper plays in women's and kids' categories, and building adjacencies in apparel and accessories. **BW**

resham@businessworld.in

Making bioenergy work at scale

VARUN KARAD is building REnergy Dynamics around a simple proposition: clean-energy infrastructure must prove its economics in the field, not just on paper **By Pooja Patil**

I

ndia's bioenergy opportunity is shifting from capacity announcements to execution. For Varun Karad, Co-founder and CEO of REnergy Dynamics (RED), the test is whether Compressed Biogas (CBG) plants can consistently convert waste into commercially viable fuel.

Karad believes investors are increasingly backing businesses with greater confidence in execution, economics and scalability, even as large transactions can skew monthly funding numbers. In bioenergy, he says, the sharper test is operating performance.

From design to delivery

"A 20-TPD CBG plant should ultimately be judged by how much gas it consistently produces and sells," says Karad. That depends on reliable feedstock, technology suited to Indian waste conditions, execution and clarity on gas offtake and payments.

Drawing on his pre-RED experience in bioenergy, Karad identified a gap in treating feedstock, technology, engineering and construction as separate components despite their interdependence.

RED was built to integrate these capabilities. By August 2026, its confirmed order book crossed Rs 1,000 crore, with operations across 12 states and a CBG project portfolio of about 150 TPD. The company has remained profitable since its first year. Karad attributes the growth to greater control across the project lifecycle and stronger execution certainty.



Varun Karad

Co-founder and CEO, REnergy Dynamics

Sector: Technology

Age: 37

Building for the long cycle

Scaling has brought its own challenges. CBG plants combine biology, equipment, engineering and feedstock, while waste composition and contamination can vary materially across sites.

Karad says he would have invested earlier in a deeper second line of project leadership and more rigorous equip-

ment validation under actual operating conditions. His lesson: delivery capability must grow alongside its order book.

RED's next phase will span project development, feedstock aggregation, technology, equipment manufacturing, automation, gas upgrading, operations and asset ownership. It is also eyeing farm and industrial organic waste, and municipal solid waste-based CBG projects. Separately, through LNK Energy, the company is planning a 6 GW integrated solar manufacturing facility, spanning ingots and wafers to cells and modules, with a planned investment of about Rs 10,000 crore. **BW**

pooja.patil@businessworld.in

**VARUN KUMAR MODI****Co-founder & CTO,****Bright Money****Sector: Fintech****Age: 38**

the business,” Modi says.

Bright’s own strategy reflects that philosophy. Its consumer fintech platform uses data and AI to address

debt, credit, savings and access to financial products.

The company sees an opportunity in the fragmented nature of US consumer financial services.

Bright’s ambition is to move beyond solving individual financial problems and become an “intelligence layer” across a consumer’s financial life. AI agents are expected to play a central role, helping consumers understand their financial position, identify appropriate actions and eventually execute them. The company is betting on what it calls “agentic financial commerce” across debt, credit, insurance, lending, mortgages and commerce.

Data as the growth engine

Scaling Bright has also exposed a less visible challenge: building data-led discipline without sacrificing speed. As the company grew, conventional reporting was no longer sufficient. It began developing predictive systems spanning acquisition, product, risk, monetisation and operations.

The co-founder says the company would have invested earlier in these learning foundations across people, processes and systems.

For India’s startup ecosystem, the broader opportunity lies in creating economic capability rather than merely capturing consumption -- through intellectual property, productivity, exports, global products and high-value jobs.

By 2035, Modi argues, the measure of India’s startup success could increasingly be the number of globally important companies built from the country—not simply the number of unicorns it produces. **BW**

pooja.patil@businessworld.in

The intelligence layer in finance

Under **VARUN MODI’S** leadership, Bright Money is shifting from solving individual financial problems to building an AI-led intelligence layer for consumers, with global ambitions from India **By Pooja Patil**

T

he next phase of fintech may be less about how much capital a company can raise and more about how effectively it can turn data into durable growth. For Bright Money, that shift is shaping its next leg of expansion.

The US-focused consumer fintech, co-founded by its CTO Varun Modi, has crossed \$75 million in annual recurring revenue (ARR) over the past 12–18 months while maintaining growth and profitability. It is targeting \$150 million ARR in 2027.

Modi believes the next decade of Indian entrepreneurship will favour businesses that combine capital-efficient growth with technology and data advantages.

For startups, that means becoming “exit-ready, not just fundraising-ready”, with predictable revenue, retention, healthy unit economics, governance and a credible path to cash generation.

“Capital must become an accelerant to the business, not the engine of

Closing the loop

VIJAY KUMAR Gond is building PeakAmp around the infrastructure needed to collect, recycle and reuse batteries as India's EV ecosystem expands **By Aditi Das**

I

ndia's electric vehicle transition is creating a challenge beyond manufacturing and charging: what happens to batteries once they reach the end of their first life? For Vijay Kumar Gond, Co-founder and CEO of PeakAmp, the fragmented ecosystem around collection, grading, reuse and recycling presented an opportunity to build the infrastructure connecting those pieces.

The business has scaled rapidly over the past 12-18 months. PeakAmp grew revenue from Rs 1.6 crore in FY25 to Rs 34.5 crore in FY26, while recycling more than 1,500 tonnes and deploying over 7,500 batteries. Its annual recurring revenue stood at more than Rs 120 crore as of April 2026.

Building the chain

For Gond, the next phase of climate and infrastructure businesses is one where capital efficiency matters as much as growth. "The biggest shift is to build with capital efficiency and long-term resilience from day one," he says, urging founders to build repeatable operating models where every rupee of capital creates measurable enterprise value.

For PeakAmp, that discipline applies to an industry still taking shape. "The toughest part has been building a new industry while the ecosystem itself is still evolving," Gond says, citing the intersection of technology, logistics, regulation, commodity markets and customer behaviour in battery recycling.

The experience has also shaped the company's approach to scale. Gond says he would have invested earlier in



Vijay Kumar Gond

Co-founder & CEO, PeakAmp

Sector: Cleantech

Age: 37

a stronger operational and data layer around battery quality, sourcing, movement and economics. Technology may create an initial advantage, he says, but reliable execution, partnerships and supply-chain control build durability.

Powering circularity

PeakAmp's next phase will span the battery lifecycle, with investments in collection and reverse logistics, testing and grading, second-life applications, recycling capacity and its technology-led battery buyback platform. It sees opportunities in using second-life bat-

teries for energy storage, and recovering lithium, nickel, cobalt and other critical materials. The larger ambition is to establish PeakAmp as a nationwide battery circularity platform through a scalable hub-and-spoke network spanning collection, reuse and material recovery, as EV adoption expands and India seeks greater domestic recovery of critical battery materials.

The opportunity reflects a broader shift in what Indian startups can build. "Indian startups will become engines of growth when they move from solving convenience problems to solving infrastructure, productivity and resource challenges at national and global scale," Gond states. Battery circularity, he adds, can create economic value and strategic resilience as India's EV and renewable-energy ecosystems expand. **BW**

aditi.das@businessworld.in

“Build for a genuine pain point”

Chalo co-founder **VINAYAK BHAVNANI** talks to **Resham Suhail** about building for real consumer pain, scaling public mobility and creating more liveable cities



What non-negotiable shift must founders make to build enduring businesses?

Focus on building a product or service that solves a genuine, significant pain point for your audience, one they're willing to pay for. That's the true test of product-market fit. Sectors like electrification, energy transition, and congestion reduction, anything that helps build more livable cities, are best positioned to lead this next phase. Most of our GDP growth will still be concentrated in the top 20-50 cities, so building solutions around them is a great bet.

What gap in India's mobility led you to build Chalo, and how has the business scaled across ridership, fleet, revenue and market penetration?

Over 80 per cent of our population relies public transportation for daily travel, yet the experience was poor and the sector was massively underinvested. That combination, a very large problem and low competition, is what drew me in. What we've built saves the average Indian commuter 40 minutes every

VINAYAK BHAVNANI

Co-founder, Chalo Mobility

Sector: Mobility

Age: 38

day, adds convenience, and genuinely improves their life. We deliver 15 million passenger rides every day across 35,000 buses, representing 20 per cent share of India's city buses. Our revenue run rate is approximately Rs 250 crore annually, up 30 per cent year-on-year.

What has been Chalo's biggest scaling challenge over the past two years?

The toughest challenge over the past two years has been accurately forecasting sales cycles with cities, since our customers are municipalities or state transport undertakings, these cycles tend to be long and unpredictable. The lessons have been twofold, keep multiple deals in the pipeline at all times to build in redundancy, and identify which markets have underlying catalysts or

momentum, and focus energy there.

Where do you see Chalo's next phase of growth emerging from?

Over the next 3 years, growth will come from three areas, scaling our fleet from 35,000 to 100,000 buses; growing our consumer platform from 5 million to 50 million monthly active users; and expanding international markets like the Philippines and Latin America, where we are already present.

Taken together, this would have Chalo delivering 50 million daily rides, generating Rs 1,000 crore in annual revenue and one step closer to building more livable cities.

What role will startups play in shaping India by 2035?

By 2035, I believe most of India's largest sectors, mobility, city operating systems, clean energy, and air taxis, will be dominated by the startups being built today, many of which will also be globally successful. **BW**

resham@businessworld.in

Beyond growth at any cost

VIRAJ SHETH has helped take Monk Entertainment beyond scale, strengthening client relationships, creative capabilities and the economics of growth **By Sonali Chawhan**

A

t 31, Viraj Sheth is building Monk Entertainment for a startup environment that is increasingly rewarding quality of growth over growth at any cost. As Co-founder and CEO, Sheth has helped take the company from a creator-focused business to a broader partner for brands, spanning creative strategy, content and execution.

“In our sector, the biggest shift is to become a more valuable partner to brands,” Sheth says. For Monk Entertainment, that means taking greater ownership of creative strategy, content and outcomes. Strong client retention, clear differentiation and healthy margins, he believes, will determine which businesses remain investment-worthy as capital becomes more selective.

That emphasis on economics also shapes Sheth’s approach to entrepreneurship. He believes founders need to understand their businesses at a granular level -- from what each customer contributes and costs to serve, to when the resulting cash actually arrives.

For Sheth, this is particularly relevant to the creator economy, where discovery and reach must increasingly translate into measurable, repeatable value. He sees creators as powerful engines for discovery, but

Viraj Sheth

Co-founder & CEO, Monk

Entertainment

Media & Entertainment

Age: 31



believes the underlying product or brand must ultimately earn the second purchase.

Scaling with discipline

Building a people-intensive business has tested Sheth’s ability to scale without compromising profitability. Larger accounts bring greater coordination, staffing and execution requirements, often alongside pressure on fees.

His response has been to sharpen the focus on account-level profitability and ownership. “The lesson has been to judge every opportunity by its contribution to the business and our ability to deliver it sustainably,” he says.

That philosophy is shaping Monk Entertainment’s next phase. The company is looking to deepen brand partnerships, expand its role in creative strategy and content production, and create new commercial opportunities for creators. Sheth also sees AI improving productivity, while placing greater value on the strategic thinking behind creative execution.

The next milestone, he says, is not simply a larger company, but “a more profitable business with stronger leadership and a larger base of ongoing client relationships.”

Sheth’s ambitions extend beyond Monk Entertainment. He sees India’s startup ecosystem becoming a broader engine of economic growth by 2035, creating skilled jobs, improving productivity and building globally competitive businesses across cities and industries. **BW**

sonali.chawhan@businessworld.in

Makers & Remakers

With BW Disrupt 40 Under 40 completing a decade, the initiative continues to spotlight entrepreneurs creating new markets and intrapreneurs reimaging established businesses, contributing to India's evolving growth story

By Resham Suhail

A

fter a decade defined by entrepreneurial exuberance, innovation and the sheer act of building, India's startup ecosystem is entering a more exacting phase. The story has travelled a considerable distance in a decade. When the government launched the Startup India initiative in January 2016, only 502 startups were recognised under the programme. By March 2026, that number had crossed 2.23 lakh, with these recognised startups having generated more than 23.36 lakh direct jobs. More than 55,200 startups were recognised in FY26 alone, the highest number in a single year.

That expansion has produced companies such as PhonePe, Zomato, boAt, Ola, Meesho, Mamaearth, among many others, while widening the definition of what an Indian startup can build. What began largely as a technology and internet story has progressively spilled into consumer brands, fintech, mobility, healthcare, climate technology, drone tech, manufacturing and deep tech. The scale of the ecosystem is no longer the question. Its next test is the quality and durability of the companies it produces.

It is within this transition that

BW Disrupt, in association with BW Businessworld, has completed the tenth edition of its BW Disrupt 40 Under 40 initiative, a platform that has sought to identify founders and intrapreneurs early and shine a spotlight on the people shaping the country's evolving enterprise landscape. From Nothing India and Nykaa to EMotorad and Chalo Mobility, this year's cohort reflects the breadth of the Indian entrepreneurial canvas.

Story of the decade

The ecosystem also acquired institutional depth. More than 1 lakh of the more than 2 lakh startups recognised by DPIIT as of January 2026 had at least one woman director or partner, while government-backed mechanisms such as the Fund of Funds for Startups, Startup India Seed Fund Scheme and Credit Guarantee Scheme have sought to address capital gaps at different stages.

The second decade, however, is likely to ask a different set of questions. Can these businesses generate durable cash flows? Can they build intellectual property rather than simply deploy accessible technology? Can founders create companies that survive multiple capital cycles? And, crucially, can investors see credible pathways to liquidity?

Equation of exits

For investors, that last question is becoming increasingly difficult to ignore. Natasha, Co-founder and Managing Partner, VG Capital, puts



AI Created Representation

the issue plainly, “In India, the biggest challenge for investors is the exit story.” She adds, “M&A has not shaped up as it has in the West.”

The concern comes against a market where exits have softened even as capital remains available. EY-IVCA data shows that PE/VC exits in India were worth \$9.4 billion across 95 exits in the first half of 2026, down 29 per cent from \$13.1 billion in H1 2025. Secondary exits stood

at \$1 billion across 19 transactions, while IPO exits totalled \$801 million across 12 listings.

However, the evolution of an ecosystem cannot be measured by M&A alone. Shashank Randev, Founder and General Partner, 247VC, identifies the broader set of mechanisms through which private companies can mature, “While M&A is one, follow-on funding is one, secondaries are an indication of how the ecosys-

tem is maturing,” he asserts.

That distinction is important. A more sophisticated startup market is not necessarily one where every company is acquired. It is one where founders, early investors and later-stage capital have multiple avenues to recycle capital and ownership, while companies have enough institutional depth to sustain successive rounds, strategic transactions or eventual public-market access.



Consumer gets choosier

The consumer economy offers an early illustration of this maturation. The D2C wave transformed categories ranging from beauty and personal care to healthy snacking, fashion and wellness, forcing established FMCG companies to respond to brands that had built direct relationships with narrowly defined consumer cohorts.

The acquisition trail has since become significant. A Crisil Ratings study published last year, covering 82 FMCG companies and 58 D2C companies, found that around two-thirds of FMCG acquisitions over the previous five fiscals were in the D2C space. Around 60 per cent of those acquisitions were in personal care, while food and beverages accounted for much of the balance, with health and wellness, specialised ingredients and premium categories among the prominent themes.

Ghazal Alagh, Co-founder and Chief Mama, Honasa Consumer, captures that operating logic, "When your product, consumer insight, distribution and communication are all working towards the same outcome, every action starts making the next one more effective," she states.

That equation is also visible in the renewed premiumisation of consumption. Healthy snacks, functional beverages, organic products and specialised food categories are finding new demand, while quick-commerce platforms are becoming increasingly important digital shelves for premium and differentiated products.

Grant Thornton Bharat's Q1 2026 consumer and retail deal tracker found investor interest concentrated around profitability-led businesses, with food processing and FMCG accounting for a significant share of deal value and premium, health-focused and brand-led consumption



**GHAZAL
ALAGH,
Co-founder and
Chief Mama,
Mamaearth**

**"When your
product, consumer
insight, distribution
and communication
are all working
towards the same
outcome, every
action starts making
the next one more
effective"**

emerging as important themes.

Sumit Marda, Co-founder, Phitku, sees trust as a parallel dimension of this premiumisation. "There is not just a price point update or an upgrade in the market right now. There is a trust update," Marda said. "What they are paying premium for is the trust and not just normal content," he added.

Factories & founders

The next frontier is moving beyond the consumer internet into the physical economy. Manufacturing, semiconductors, robotics, quantum technologies, biotechnology and industrial AI are increasingly entering the startup investment vocabulary.

The policy architecture is moving in the same direction. The government's Research, Development and Innovation scheme envisages a corpus of Rs 1 lakh crore over six years to support high-risk, high-impact R&D, including deep-tech funds of funds. In February 2026, the government also approved Startup India

Fund of Funds 2.0, with a Rs 10,000 crore corpus focused on deep tech, technology-driven innovative manufacturing and early-growth startups.

Private capital is beginning to follow. In June, IIT Roorkee, IvyCap Ventures and NuQuant announced a proposed Rs 1,000 crore Super Endowment Fund under Bharat Innovates to provide longer-term support for research, innovation and deep-tech entrepreneurship. More recently, members of the India Deep Tech Alliance were reported to have deployed around Rs 2,170 crore across 56 deep-tech startups in areas including AI, quantum computing, robotics, energy and biotechnology.

Shashank Randev argues that this could mark another stage in the ecosystem's evolution, with hardware and research-led businesses becoming more investable as the distance between research and commercialisation contracts.

Mohit Gulyani, Co-founder and Director, RecommerceX, points to another dimension: India's opportunity to participate in global supply-chain diversification. He sees the movement from Industry 4.0 towards Industry 5.0, with artificial intelligence, robotics, sensors, pre-



NATASHA,
Co-founder
and Managing
Partner, VG
Capital

“In India, the biggest challenge for investors is the exit story because M&A has not shaped up as it has in the West”

dictive maintenance and demand forecasting reshaping factory operations, while Indian companies increasingly manufacture engineered products for overseas markets.

The capital returns, selectively

The funding numbers suggest that the capital cycle has not disappeared, it has become more measured. Indian technology startups raised \$7.2 billion across 652 funding rounds in H1 2026, 12 per cent higher than the year-earlier period even as the number of rounds fell 43 per cent. The



**SHASHANK
RANDEV,**
Founder and
General Partner,
247VC

“While M&A is one, follow-on funding is one, secondaries are an indication of how the ecosystem is maturing”

same pool of capital is therefore being distributed across considerably fewer companies.

That is the crucial signal. The market is not returning to the exuberance of 2021. Instead, the emerging pattern is one of concentration, larger cheques for selected companies and greater scrutiny of the route from growth to durability.

The broader PE/VC market tells a more mixed story. EY-IVCA recorded \$20.5 billion of PE/VC investments across 604 deals in H1 2026, down 36 per cent from H1 2025, while startup investments declined 22 per cent year-on-year to \$5.3 billion across 396 deals. At the same time, growth investments rose 6 per cent in value to \$7 billion.

The next test

This is where the startup narrative begins to change character. The first decade rewarded the ability to enter markets, acquire users, raise capital and establish categories. The next will increasingly test whether those companies can convert scale into institutional strength.

The questions are consequently be-

coming harder. Investors want stronger unit economics, clearer governance and credible exit routes. Across all these categories, capital has to find businesses capable of surviving beyond the next funding round.

India's startup ecosystem may therefore become less noisy without becoming less consequential. The arithmetic of 2.23 lakh recognised startups is already too large for the sector to be treated as a niche technology phenomenon. What is changing is the nature of the ambition, from creating startups to creating companies, from raising capital to deploying it with discipline, and from celebrating disruption to building institutions that can compound.

For BW Disrupt, completing the tenth year of the BW Disrupt 40 Under 40 initiative provides a vantage point into precisely that transition. The endeavour remains to spot potential earlier, follow the trajectory of founders and intrapreneurs as their businesses evolve, and recognise those anchoring the next phase of India's growth story. **BW**

resham@businessworld.in

“Over the next five to 10 years, there is significant potential for capabilities to become increasingly indigenised. India has the talent, manpower and resources to support this growth”



“India’s Manufacturing Growth Needs More R&D & Innovation”

A S INDIA PROGRESSES towards its **VIKSIT BHARAT 2047** vision, technology and innovation are expected to play a critical role in strengthening manufacturing and infrastructure. **DEEPAK N. G.**, Managing Director, Dassault Systèmes India, discusses opportunities for his company to participate in sectors like aerospace, semiconductors and life sciences. He also emphasises the need for greater research and development, automation and skill development within Indian industry in a conversation with Sangeet Kumar Sanu of *BW Businessworld*. Excerpts:

What is SOLIDWORKS, and what is its purpose?

SOLIDWORKS is one of our applications for creating 3D data, predominantly used by specific industries and segments for design purposes. It is part of the broader Dassault Systèmes portfolio and is particularly popular among industrial equipment manufacturers, medical device companies and automotive component manufacturers and suppliers.

It enables component design, assembly and simulation and is relatively fast and easy to adopt. That is why we have a large number of users and customers leveraging the platform. Academia, colleges, students and startups also use SOLIDWORKS to develop their designs.

Where do you see Dassault Systèmes in India’s vision of turning into a developed economy by 2047? Which

sectors does the company plan to play a part in?

Three major sectors will play an important role: manufacturing, infrastructure and life sciences.

Manufacturing currently contributes to around 15 per cent of India’s GDP, but there is significant potential for growth, driven by domestic demand and India’s export opportunities. We need to continuously provide the right solutions and technology so that Indian industry remains competitive, both domestically and globally.

Infrastructure is largely driven by domestic requirements. Improving traffic management, roads and connectivity creates opportunities for new infrastructure, employment and economic growth. Better connectivity can attract businesses and talent, while development is already expanding into tier-2 and tier-3 cities.

India also has an advantage because much of the in-

frastructure being built today incorporates the latest technology. Our airports, for example, compare well with established global airports in terms of technology.

The third area is life sciences. Healthcare is critical, and the opportunity extends beyond drug discovery. India also needs to design and manufacture medical equipment and devices locally. Supporting local design and manufacturing will therefore remain important.

Aviation, particularly in defence and aerospace, is expected to grow significantly in India. How do you see the sector evolving across 10 years?

The positive development is that the budget for aerospace and defence has increased significantly. The focus is not only on procurement from outside India; there is greater support for Indian companies to manufacture locally.

Whether it is aircraft manufacturers, component manufacturers or development of new types of aircraft, there will be significant investment in research and in supporting existing fleets and capabilities.

We are seeing many collaborations, with global players establishing operations in India and becoming more comfortable manufacturing locally. India is also focussing on the quality standards required by aerospace companies.

Over the next five to 10 years, there is significant potential for capabilities to become increasingly indigenised. India has the talent, manpower and resources to support this growth.

India is investing heavily in defence and aerospace, but spending in research and development (R&D) remains relatively low. How do you view this gap?

If we compare research and devel-

opment spending with GDP, India is currently close to 0.8 per cent. We are not yet at the level of leading countries, but this is a journey that has already started.

India has a significant advantage in talent. Innovation comes from talent and the mindset with which people approach problems. We need to provide the right platforms for people to spend time on research and development. Earlier, companies may have primarily taken existing technologies and adapted them for the Indian market. Today, many

“Companies are increasingly trying to capture their knowledge and knowhow in a structured manner so that dependency on individuals can be reduced. This allows employees to spend more time on R&D and innovation”

Indian companies are looking at new inventions and innovations that they can develop to create new products. This is happening among large companies as well as startups.

That will not happen without investment in R&D. While India's spending may still appear low compared with other countries, there is incremental progress. I believe that over the next five years we could move closer to two per cent, although moving from 0.8 per cent to two per cent will not be easy.

India has a young population today, but the median age is expected to rise over the next decade. Is that a concern for manufacturing and the broader economy?

Today, we have the advantage of a young population, but we cannot ig-

nore demographic changes. We need to prepare because the nature of jobs is going to change and many new opportunities will emerge.

Companies are increasingly trying to capture their knowledge and know-how in a structured manner so that dependency on individuals can be reduced. This allows employees to spend more time on R&D and innovation. For example, if a manufacturer has 100 designers working on routine assembly, simulation and testing, automation can take over some of those processes, allowing employees to focus more on innovation.

We need to structure what we have done in the past, what we are learning today and what we will learn in the future, so this knowledge is available to the next generation. Organisations will also need to create new job roles that attract young talent and ensure continuity.

Automation is advancing rapidly in countries like China. Could India face a manpower challenge if it does not accelerate technology adoption?

Companies are already looking at automation so that they do not face this problem in the future. India is aware of the challenge and will adopt technologies and automation.

Artificial intelligence may perform certain jobs tomorrow, but the extent to which it does so and how those roles evolve are still being defined. What is important is to nurture skills around these technologies and determine what young people and the future workforce should learn to remain relevant.

Today, our advantage is our people and resources. The talent hunt is global and other countries will continue to seek Indian talent, but India has enough resources to strengthen its own ecosystem while continuing

to participate in the global talent market.

Dassault Systèmes is involved in skill development. Do you think the government is doing enough in this area?

Skill development is a continuous process. There have been several initiatives over the past five years under the Skill India programme, from creating new job roles to establishing learning centres. Companies such as ours are working with the government to create learning centres, while colleges and universities are increasingly collaborating with industry to understand what companies actually need.

The government is providing a platform and identifying areas that are important. For example, if the government announces that semiconductor manufacturing and research should develop in the Northeast, organisations can determine what skills need to be developed in that region.

There is also support through universities and government-funded laboratories. We cannot expect the government to do everything, but it is now working much more closely with industry. Private companies are also setting up laboratories and training centres through CSR initiatives and business programmes. These efforts are reaching tier-2 and tier-3 cities and, in some cases, rural areas.

India is developing semiconductor manufacturing capabilities, but some industry leaders say the country still lacks capabilities in chip design. What are your views?

I would not describe it simply as a lack of capability. We need to look at the pace at which the market is evolving. Semiconductors have suddenly become important because almost every piece of equipment now requires chips, and volumes have in-

creased significantly. Manufacturing is an important first step, but we cannot stop there. Research and design are equally important because semiconductor technology is continuously evolving.

This is the right time for India to invest in this area, and I see investments moving in that direction. State governments are supporting start-ups and incubation centres, while laboratories are bringing together technology, artificial intelligence and knowledge to develop capabilities.

The opportunity extends be-



yond chip design to manufacturing, assembly and taking products to market. India can continue strengthening manufacturing while simultaneously building its research base.

With the rapid expansion of data centres, environmental concerns around energy and water consumption are increasing. Is this development inevitable for India?

Environmentally unfriendly activities have existed for many years. What we have done is identify alternatives and find ways to reduce their carbon footprint by changing the material, process or the way a system operates.

The same principle applies to data centres. We can build a virtual twin of a data centre, incorporating racks,

switches, airflow, air conditioning, water cooling and other parameters. We can examine resource consumption and assess whether the facility can have a more self-sustaining power supply.

The objective is to avoid setting up a data centre first and discovering problems later, such as excessive heat, high water consumption, inadequate ventilation or dependence on carbon-intensive power. For example, we can assess whether solar panels could help make a data centre more self-sustainable.

These simulations can be conducted using our 3DEXPERIENCE platform.

India will need more data centres as companies move towards cloud computing and AI factories. There is no option but to build the required infrastructure, but we can be prepared and make it more sustainable.

Finally, which sector do you believe will be the backbone of the government's *Viksit Bharat 2047* vision?

I firmly believe it will be a combination of sectors. There is no single sector that can serve as the backbone. Different sectors have to complement each other.

Transportation, mobility and infrastructure are particularly important. It is a cycle: when you build more roads, you need more cars, trucks and construction equipment. When transportation increases, businesses in those sectors benefit, and the people employed in them may subsequently purchase cars or two-wheelers.

The more economic activity you generate across these interconnected sectors, the stronger the overall economy becomes. Infrastructure, mobility, manufacturing, employment and consumption reinforce one another. **BW**

sangeet@businessworld.in

“INDIA CONTINUES TO BE UNDERINSURED”

As the private life insurance space completes 25 years, **VIBHA PADALKAR**, MD & CEO, HDFC Life, shares her perspective with **ASHISH SINHA** on the way the industry has matured and how it will move forward to close India's protection and retirement gaps. Excerpts

HDFC Life and India's private life insurance industry together have completed 25 years. What have been the achievements and what remains unfinished business?

The transformation over the last 25 years has been remarkable. When private participation began, life insurance was still largely viewed through the prism of savings and tax planning. Today, the conversation has broadened considerably to protection against mortality and morbidity, longevity and interest rate fluctuation. Life insurers today manage significant pools of long-term savings that support government securities, infrastructure and other productive assets. The life insurance industry paid Rs 56,843 crore in claims in FY25 alone, which constitutes over a significant amount of the total claims paid by the insurance ecosystem, underlining the scale of the financial safety net it provides.

At HDFC Life, we have endeavoured to build an institution capable of navigating different cycles. We have experienced the global financial crisis, listed the company, integrated the erstwhile Exide Life in a pioneering consolidation, navigated the Covid-19 pandemic and adapted continuously to regulatory and technological changes.

Notwithstanding the progress, India continues to be underinsured. The barriers of awareness, accessibility and affordability have not yet been addressed at scale. HDFC Life, in sync with the industry, is keen to trigger a behavioural shift to make life insurance an integral part of household financial planning rather than an afterthought.

HDFC Life has continued to deliver growth and prof-

itability despite significant regulatory and taxation changes. How do you assess FY26 and the first quarter of FY27, and what gives you confidence that the company can sustain this trajectory?

Our focus is to be a consistent, predictable partner to our customers and distributors as the industry works through a period of regulatory transition. During FY26, we continued to maintain our position among the top three private insurers by individual WRP. Our overall market share stood at 10.8 per cent for FY26. We outperformed the broader industry in 2 key focus areas: The first one being retail protection which grew 43 per cent, and the second one being agency channel which also grew ahead of industry. Retail Protection was a clear highlight during the year, with growth of 43 per cent, supported by lower pricing post GST and a strengthened product portfolio. Annuities were another area of meaningful progress.



The ongoing build-up of the agency channel was another strong story of the year. Agency grew ahead of the company by 500 bps, maintaining a strong protection mix.

Our distribution expansion has also been broad-based. As of FY 26, we have 715 branches across India. Over 80 per cent of new branches opened during last financial year were in 'Bharat' markets — beyond the metros. Our wider ecosystem includes 2.7 lakh+ individual agents, 500+ partners and over 44,000 partner branches.

In Q1FY27, growth was underpinned by strong customer acquisition, with the number of policies growing in double digits and ahead of industry. Our product mix also continued to improve, with non-participating savings crossing 25 per cent of individual APE on a run-rate

basis. Retail protection grew 42 per cent this quarter, retail sum assured grew 31 per cent and credit protect grew close to 20 per cent. Together, these underscore the strength of our protection franchise and our continued focus on long-term, sustainable value."

Our philosophy remains consistent: disciplined risk management, a diversified product and distribution mix, customer-centric innovation and prudent expense management.

"India continues to be underinsured. The barriers of awareness, accessibility and affordability have not yet been addressed at scale"

Mis-selling, premature surrender and inappropriate product recommendations remain some of the biggest challenges facing life insurance. How does the industry ensure that trust becomes the bedrock of the in-

Industry's next growth phase?

First, we need to ensure that the customer appreciates that life insurance is a long-term product. The objective of purchasing this product is financial security along with fulfilment of long-term goals such as buying a home, paying for children's education, etc.

Thus, there needs to be an assessment of product fitment prior to purchase, which necessitates need-based selling. The seller must ensure that the product is suitable for the customer's need. Also, the financial commitment for the entire policy duration should remain affordable. Ensure that the customer understands the benefits, risks and premature exit implications.

As an industry, we need to address any anomalies at the point of sale. These aspects can be addressed with stronger need-based proposition, distributor training and governance, transparent communication and sustained customer engagement after issuance. Technology is an enabler through digital verification, analytics and more consistent underwriting and sales processes. Growth with penetration, persistency and purpose is the sustainable way ahead.

What are your plans for the near future, especially in terms of technology transformation, innovation, etc.?

I believe, technology is an enabler for the business. It has the capacity to empower employees and distributors, simplify underwriting and servicing, reduce friction and enable us to deliver more personalised solutions rather than simply replacing the human relationship.

We are undertaking one of the most ambitious technology transformations in Indian insurance through Project INSPIRE, a next generation enterprise platform that is completely reimagining customer, distributor, underwriting, servicing and employee journeys. Built on modern cloud architecture, the programme is enabling greater agility, faster product innovation and a truly digital first operating model. This transformation is powered by accelerated investments in GenAI, advanced analytics and digital infrastructure, with a sharper focus on risk management, superior customer experience and higher operational efficiency.

We have already moved beyond experimentation to scaled deployment of



GenAI across the value chain, including virtual sales assistants, AI led customer self service, complaint resolution, underwriting decision support, fraud investigation summarisation and voice based servicing. These interventions have delivered measurable impact. Post deployment, frontline sales productivity improved by around 16 per cent, AI handled more than 60 lakh customer queries and emails, and decision engines enabled nearly 30 per cent faster decision making. Internally, the philosophy is clear: technology is not here to replace human relationships but to supercharge frontline

capability, simplify processes and deliver personalised experiences at scale.

What changes are needed to enable responsible industry growth? And what legacy does HDFC Life aspire to leave in India's life insurance ecosystem?

The next phase has to be about widening and deepening the insurance market rather than simply competing more intensely for existing customers. Denser distribution in underserved markets, simpler and more modular products, lower friction in underwriting and servicing, and sustained category-level awareness around protection and retirement planning are the key areas for intervention. Customers should be offered the right solution at an apt life stage, in their language and through relevant channels.

Policy and regulation should continue to encourage innovation and customer protection while enabling different distribution models to reach diverse sections of India efficiently.

Risk Based Capital (RBC) and Ind AS 117 are the big-ticket reforms. Ind AS 117 is expected to drive transparency, and comparable ongoing disclosures should help moderate market conduct industry-wide. Risk based capital will be a favorable structural shift, aligning capital with underlying risks.

HDFC Life's longer-term ambition transcends the mission of Insurance for All by 2047. We aspire to make life insurance a vital interventional tool for facilitating financial and social resilience. 'Sar Utha Ke Jiyo' is our collective dream for every Indian family. **BW**

"We aspire to make life insurance a vital interventional tool for facilitating financial and social resilience"

ashish.sinha@businessworld.in

BWDISRUPT
DISRUPTION IN ENTREPRENEURSHIP 8th Edition

WOMEN ENTREPRENEUR IN RAPRENEURS

SUMMIT & AWARDS 2025

#BWWEISA



OCT 2026
NEW DELHI

NOMINATE NOW



EMINENT JURY MEMBERS



DR. ANNURAG BATRA

Chairman & Editor -in-Chief
BW Businessworld & Founder,
exchange4media



SUDHIR RAO

Senior Partner,
Celesta Capital



NUPUR GARG

Founder,
WinPe



NTASHA

Co-founder and
Managing Partner,
Ankurit capital



MAYURESH RAUT

Co-founder and Managing
Partner Seafund



DEEPAK SHARMA

Co-Founder and
Managing Partner,
India Accelerator



SUKHMANI BEDI

Partner,
Orios Venture Partners



YAGNESH SANGHRAJKA

Founder &
Managing Partner,
247VC



KAMINI SARAF

MD & Owner - Angasutra
and Fashion Yatra;
Director - Radha Smelters



ASHISH KUMAR

Co-Founder and GP,
Fundamentum



NOOR FATHIMA WARSIA

Group Editorial Director,
BW Businessworld

EVENT PARTNERS



For Nominations and Speaking Opportunities:

Chetna Malhotra, +91 8796022292, chetna.malhotra@businessworld.in
Chetan Mehra, +91 9811702464, chetan.mehra@businessworld.in

“I would bet on convergence”

VIRAL BANSAL, Chief People Officer at Omega Healthcare, explains to BW Businessworld’s Savi Khanna why GCCs and specialists can coexist, the talent gaps holding healthcare GCCs back, and why convergence will shape the next phase. Excerpts from the interview

Is the GCC wave an existential threat to specialised players like Omega Healthcare, or is genuine coexistence possible — and how is that uncertainty shaping your talent and business strategy?

This isn’t an existential battle — the market is moving toward a portfolio model. Companies will insource strategically important capabilities while partnering with specialists where deep domain expertise, scale or transformation would take too long or cost too much to build internally. AI innovation often needs partners with trained resources and tested pilots, saving time and money while cutting risk.

The real distinction is no longer insourcing vs. outsourcing, but transactional capacity vs. accountable capability. A GCC can own strategy, data and the roadmap, while specialised partners bring domain expertise, operational intelligence and technology accelerators — and these boundaries keep blurring.

This also changes the talent agenda. Careers can no longer be built around tenure in a process; people need domain knowledge, data fluency, technology awareness and change leadership, and businesses must shift from selling headcount to delivering measurable outcomes. Uncertainty isn’t something to avoid — it’s a signal to keep redesign-

ing the organisation before the market forces us to.

Healthcare GCCs handle some of the most sensitive, regulated data in any industry. What gaps have you seen when enterprises stand up a healthcare GCC without appreciating how different that complexity is from generic shared services?

The first gap is talent. Even with strong hires across technology, finance and operations, companies often lack people who understand healthcare regulation, clinical processes and how decisions affect patients. Compliance can be taught; judgment is harder to build.

The second gap is frontline leadership. When mid- and senior leaders lack healthcare context, they can prioritise volume over quality and overlook the impact on outcomes and the rationale behind exceptions.

The third is domain-focused career development. Many GCCs underinvest in building healthcare expertise, so employees plateau or move into other fields. The fix is embedding domain development into the operating model — healthcare academies, AI and technical certification, compliance fluency and experiential learning, not just orientation. That’s how GCCs build sustainable capability, not just capacity.

“A GCC can own strategy, data and the roadmap, while specialised partners bring domain expertise, operational intelligence and technology accelerators — and these boundaries keep blurring”



out creating uncertainty, retain key talent and manage financial pressure.

This takes business judgment — knowing which capabilities are truly critical, what can change, and how decisions ripple across the organisation. It also takes strength: during change, employees judge leaders by clarity, fairness and consistency more than polish. GCCs should build scenario plans, succession depth and crisis communication practices before the first major challenge, not after.

As GCCs mature into outcome-owning hubs, will specialised players become M&A targets for GCCs, or the reverse — and which outcome are you betting on?

I expect multiple models rather than one dominant outcome — companies acquiring capabilities to move faster, larger services firms acquiring smaller businesses or captives to scale, and joint ventures or build-operate-transfer deals enabling collaboration without full acquisition.

GCCs and specialised healthcare firms now draw from the same limited talent pool. What has that done to compensation, retention and career pathing — and who's winning?

Compensation has risen as competition grows for talent that combines healthcare expertise with AI, analytics, automation and stakeholder skills. But retention is the bigger challenge — organisations can't assume pay alone offsets poor management, limited growth or repetitive work. Top talent asks: What will I learn? How fast will I grow? Will I transform or just execute?

In response, organisations are building differentiated career paths, so domain experts don't need to become people managers to advance. No single model wins the talent battle — GCCs offer enterprise proximity and ownership; specialists offer broader exposure and mobility. The winners will be organisations offering portable careers,

“The strongest organisations won't be defined by whether they started as a GCC or a services firm, but by how well they combine enterprise context, domain expertise, technology and accountability for outcomes”

continuous learning and consistently strong leadership.

Most GCCs are only 3–5 years in and haven't been tested by a real downturn or restructuring. What leadership capability this generation hasn't had to build yet, but will need?

Resilience, the ability to make tough calls while maintaining trust and cohesion. Growth can hide problems that surface when conditions worsen. Leaders must then distinguish genuine capability gaps from unnecessary complexity, explain hard choices with-

I'd bet on convergence. The strongest organisations won't be defined by whether they started as a GCC or a services firm, but by how well they combine enterprise context, domain expertise, technology and accountability for outcomes. Acquisitions create value only when the capability-building strategy is stronger than the deal logic — buying a specialist doesn't transfer its expertise. Success depends on retaining key talent and aligning cultures, so value survives the deal. **BW**

savi.khanna@businessworld.in

What future GCCs need from their EVP

Why AI-driven GCCs need to rebuild their talent strategy around innovation, culture, mobility and global-first leadership

In an era defined by AI-driven transformation, traditional talent management models are being challenged as GCCs mature. Moving beyond legacy support and execution-oriented models, GCCs now offer a differentiated employee value proposition (EVP) anchored in strategic partnership with enterprise businesses, product and platform ownership, global leadership accountability and the mandate to create significant value through AI-driven innovation. This shift calls for a fundamental reimagining of talent practices to seamlessly align with the needs of a modern EVP.

Healthcare faces multidimensional challenges across access, quality and affordability, demanding innovation that reduces system friction, eases administrative burden and elevates patient experience. As GCCs evolve from operational hubs into end-to-end value creators, success will depend on a workforce that can navigate this complexity and realise its innovation potential. A culture of inclusion, well-being and purpose, alongside AI-ready leadership and talent mobility, can drive career growth and retention — laying the foundation for sustained growth and resilience through outcomes that are meaningful today and future-ready.

By AMIT VAISH,
Vice President & Head HR,
Optum India

Healthcare faces multidimensional challenges across access, quality and affordability, demanding innovation that reduces system friction, eases administrative burden and elevates patient experience

Driving workforce innovation

This shift requires strengthening the enterprise's innovation muscle by cultivating a culture where creativity, experimentation and cross-functional problem-solving can thrive. With innovation-first mandate depending on equipping employees with the right skills across roles, GCCs must invest in continuous learning and upskilling that deepen domain and functional expertise, build AI fluency starting with leaders, and offer role-based learning pathways building proficiency enterprise-wide. This equips the workforce to navigate complexity with confidence and cultivate future-ready skills that drive meaningful innovation, from patents and platforms to reusable IP. Over time, this shifts AI from a discretionary capability to a structural advantage.

Creating inclusive cultures

Here, culture becomes a decisive strategic asset. While the enterprise mission defines the what, it is culture that shapes the how — the enabler through which GCCs unlock meaningful performance. Values, behaviours and the leadership shadow must translate into action through collaborative goal-setting, continuous feedback loops and transparent decision-making.

Psychological safety is a critical dimension of culture in GCCs. Teams that experience higher levels of psychological safety surface risks earlier, challenge assumptions and iterate with speed. This strengthens business continuity while reducing organisational blind spots. In an environment where speed, adaptability and innovation determine success, these cultural enablers amplify mission for sustained performance.

Well-being is a non-negotiable priority spanning mental, social, financial and physical health, ensuring employees feel supported and empowered to thrive. Organisations that embrace well-being holistically will win the talent game. Because when people feel cared for, they don't just stay, they excel.



Inclusion is the cornerstone of a high-trust, high-performance culture. For GCCs, this means creating an environment where every employee feels valued, heard and able to contribute meaningfully

Inclusion is the cornerstone of a high-trust, high-performance culture. For GCCs, this means creating an environment where every employee feels valued, heard and able to contribute meaningfully. Inclusion shows up in everyday behaviours: leaders who actively seek diverse viewpoints, teams that encourage respectful debate, and workplaces designed to ensure fairness in opportunity, visibility and growth. When people experience true belongingness, they bring greater creativity, stronger collaboration and a deeper sense of ownership.

Embedding social responsibility into culture fosters pride and engagement among talent who want their work to matter beyond business outcomes, whether through sustainability initiatives, volunteering programs, or partnerships that create positive societal impact.

Expanding career pathways

Today's multi-generational workforce

prioritises fluid, purpose-driven career journeys over static ladders. Employees want the freedom to move where their skills and aspirations take them – sideways into new domains, upward into leadership paths, or diagonally into hybrid roles. GCCs should design ecosystems that expand talent mobility through cross-functional stints, mentorship networks, internal gig marketplaces, talent swaps and project-based roles. This flexible, skills-forward approach fuels engagement, preserves deep domain skills, and keeps both talent and organisations agile and relevant.

Developing global leaders

To anchor these efforts for enterprise-level impact, leadership must shift from localised, siloed operating styles to a global, enterprise-first mindset. Future-ready GCC leaders look beyond location-based structures and understand where the strongest skills reside – tapping into deep clinical expertise

in the Philippines or leveraging diverse technology talent in India – ensuring work flows to capability, not proximity. This requires leaders who own the broader context, make decisions with accountability and demonstrate ownership in solving business problems with a strong commitment to location-flexible operating models, cross-regional collaboration and a skills-first approach to staffing, development and mobility.

Making EVP matter

Shaping the future of talent depends on the ability of GCCs to unify the core elements of a modern EVP – skills, culture, innovation, mobility and leadership – into one integrated, enterprise aligned system. By moving beyond isolated initiatives and reimagining their workforce strategy through this cohesive lens, GCCs can redefine their talent narrative and strengthen their strategic mandate. The GCCs that embrace this shift set new benchmarks for modern, enterprise-ready talent leadership. **BW**

When Cash Gets Stuck

A multinational can look cash-rich on its balance sheet and still have to borrow. The real measure of liquidity is not simply how much cash a company owns, but how much it can move and deploy when it matters



FOR A BUSINESS, cash means freedom. It pays salaries, funds expansion, supports acquisitions, finances technology and provides a cushion when markets turn uncertain. Yet for a multinational company, the size of the cash balance tells only part of the story. An equally important question is where that cash is located - and whether it can be moved. A company may report billions in cash and cash equivalents while borrowing to finance a promising investment. The two facts can sit comfortably together. Some of the group's cash may be held by a subsidiary or in a jurisdiction from which it cannot be transferred quickly, cheaply or at all. This is commonly described as trapped cash. It creates a peculiar corporate paradox: a company can be cash-rich on its consolidated balance sheet and cash-poor where an investment decision must actually be made.

Ownership Is Not Accessibility

Trapped cash is not lost money, and it does not necessarily indicate a management failure. Broadly, it is cash legally owned by a corporate group but not freely available to another part of that group. The barriers vary. Foreign-exchange rules may restrict currency conversion or outward remittances. Repatriating profits may trigger taxes or withholding costs. Dividend payments and cross-border loans may require regulatory approval. Transfer-pricing requirements, local solvency rules and administrative delays can add further friction.

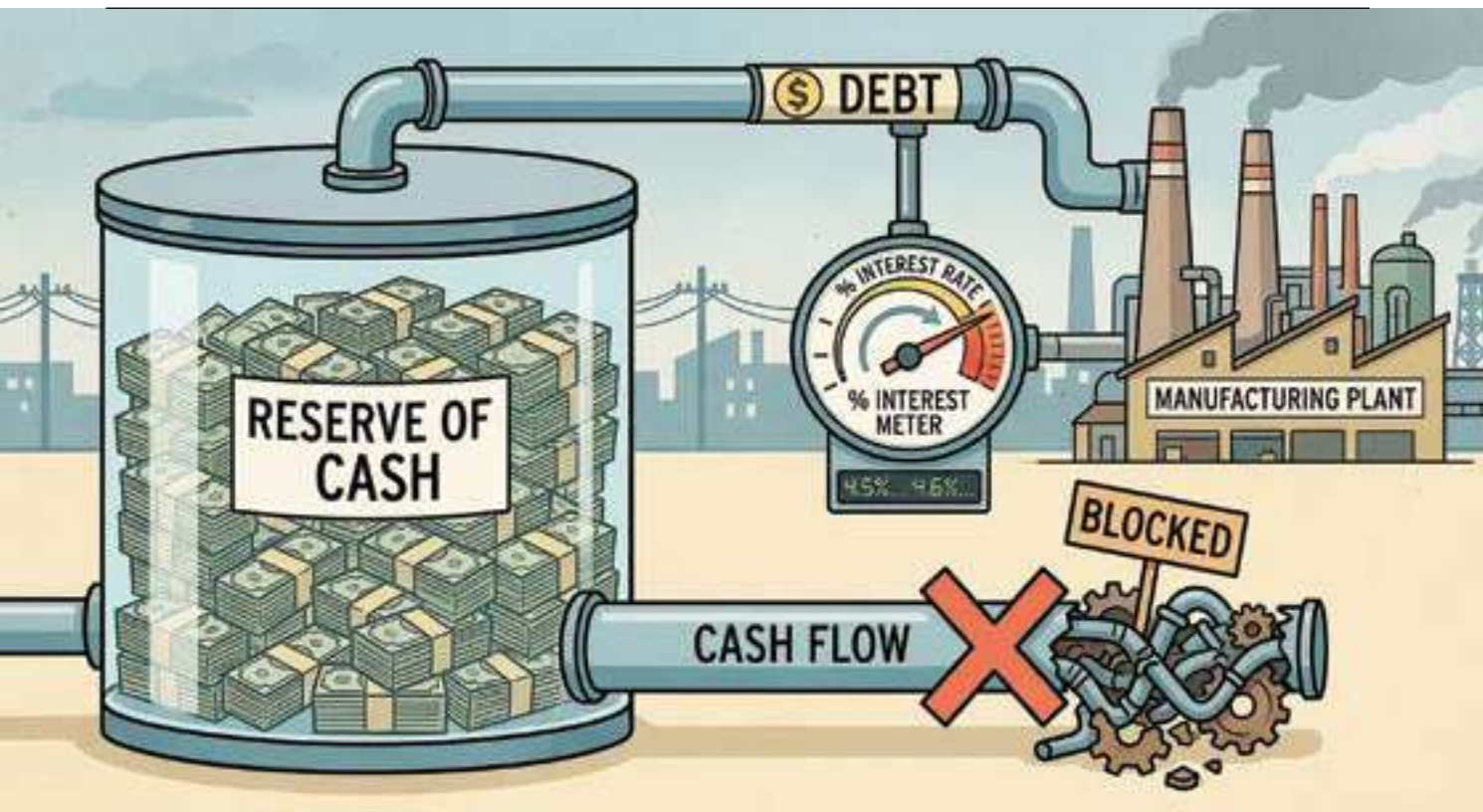
There is therefore an important difference between owning cash and being able to use it. A parent may own 100 per cent of a foreign subsidiary, but that does not mean it can direct the subsidiary to send its entire bank balance to headquarters tomorrow. For a treasury team, the relevant figure is not simply total group cash. It is deployable cash: how much is available, in which legal entity and currency, how quickly it can move and at what cost. Academic research has linked repatriation costs with higher

foreign cash holdings.

The Cost Of Money In The Wrong Place

Consider a fictional Indian consumer-goods multinational, Bharat Global Consumer Products. Its Asian subsidiary, BGCP Asia, has performed strongly and accumulated the equivalent of \$500 million. The local business does not have enough attractive opportunities to use all of it. Meanwhile, the group identifies an opportunity in another country to build a modern manufacturing plant for \$150 million. The project is strategically important and is expected to earn a return comfortably above the group's cost of capital. On paper, the financing appears straightforward: the company has \$500 million and needs \$150 million.

But the country in which BGCP Asia operates restricts foreign-exchange conversion and large overseas transfers. Moving the money may require regulatory approvals and take longer than the commercial opportunity allows. The parent therefore raises a \$150



AI Created Representation

“Reported liquidity and usable liquidity are not always the same”

million international bank loan. The consolidated balance sheet now shows an apparently contradictory position. BGCP has borrowed \$150 million while retaining \$500 million of its own cash elsewhere in the group. It pays interest on new debt even though, in accounting terms, it has more than enough money. That interest is one of the direct costs of trapped cash. The principle can also arise within a country. Large groups comprise separate legal entities, not merely divisions of one company. One subsidiary may have surplus funds while another needs capital, but the shared promoter or parent does not make transfers automatic. Moving money may require a dividend, capital contribution, inter-company loan or another permitted transaction, each carrying legal, tax and governance requirements.

Why Shareholders Should Care

Trapped cash is not merely a treasury inconvenience. It can affect returns, investment choices and the way investors interpret a company’s financial strength. The most visible cost is borrowing. If the group must raise debt because its own money is inaccessible, interest expense reduces earnings. There is also an opportunity cost when cash earns a modest return in one market instead of financing a more productive project elsewhere. The deeper risk is distorted capital allocation. Management may fund a less attractive local project because the money is already there, while postponing a stronger opportunity in another market. The location of cash begins to influence strategy more than the quality of the investment. Investors should therefore treat headline cash figures with care. Consolidated accounts may show substantial liquidity without revealing, at first glance, how much the parent can deploy immediately. Reported liquidity and usable liquidity are not always the same.

Managing Cash Before It Becomes Trapped

Multinationals have several tools, but none is a free pass around regulation. Regional

treasury centres, permitted cash-pooling structures, netting arrangements and properly documented inter-company financing can reduce mismatches between surplus and deficit entities. A subsidiary may also finance another operation directly where local law allows it. Every arrangement must comply with foreign-exchange rules, tax law, transfer-pricing requirements and corporate regulations in all relevant jurisdictions. The purpose of sophisticated treasury management is not to bypass capital controls, but to use legitimate liquidity efficiently within them.

The first requirement is visibility. Management should map cash by country, cur-

rency and legal entity, separating operational balances from unrestricted surplus and funds subject to legal or practical constraints. It should also test how long transfers could take and what taxes or transaction costs they would trigger.

Where cash genuinely cannot leave a country, productive local deployment may be the best answer. Investment in manufacturing, technology, logistics, suppliers or distribution can convert an idle balance into strategic capacity. But such spending must still meet the group's normal return thresholds; trapped cash should not become an excuse for weak investment. The issue is best addressed before the money accumulates. Decisions about how a subsidiary is funded



AI Created Representation

“Sometimes the most expensive cash a business owns is not the cash it lacks, but the cash it has and cannot use”

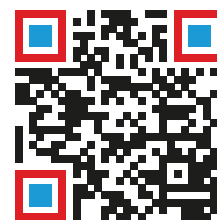
should consider future repatriation, currency exposure, local borrowing conditions and the likely destination of returns.

Liquidity Has A Geography

Governments may impose capital controls to protect foreign-exchange reserves, manage currency pressure or respond to financial instability. These can be legitimate policy goals. Yet the design and predictability of the rules matter. When companies cannot move legitimate earnings efficiently, they may borrow more, delay investment or redirect future capital to jurisdictions where funds are easier to deploy. That matters for countries competing for foreign direct investment. Investors assess not only whether they can earn profits, but also whether they can reinvest, distribute or repatriate them through a transparent process.

Cash may be finance's most liquid asset, but multinational business complicates that definition. A dollar in an unrestricted account is economically different from a dollar held by a subsidiary where conversion or transfer is difficult. Liquidity, then, is not merely the cash a company owns. It is the cash it can access and deploy, where and when it is needed, at a reasonable cost. For the CFO, trapped cash is a treasury challenge. For the board, it is a capital-allocation issue. For shareholders, it is a question about the quality of reported liquidity. In a global company, cash has a geography. Sometimes the most expensive cash a business owns is not the cash it lacks, but the cash it has and cannot use. **BW**

Suhail Hasan Khan is a finance scholar, author and researcher specialising in finance, private equity and venture capital



Special Offer

Subscribe & Save

52%

On BW Businessworld Group Magazines



MY MAGAZINE CHOICE (S) PRINT	TERM	BW BUSINESSWORLD	BW EDUCATION	BW PEOPLE	BW HEALTHCARE	BW WELLBEING	BW HOTELIER
	1 YEAR	26 Issue ₹ 5200/- ₹ 2999/-	6 Issue ₹ 1800/- ₹ 1599/-	4 Issue ₹ 1800/- ₹ 999/-	6 Issue ₹ 1800/- ₹ 1599/-	6 Issue ₹ 1800/- ₹ 1599/-	6 Issues ₹ 1800/- ₹ 1620/-
	2 YEAR	52 Issue ₹ 10400/- ₹ 5599/- Additional Benefit: Plus 6 Issues	12 Issue ₹ 3600/- ₹ 2899/-	8 Issue ₹ 3600/- ₹ 1899/-	12 Issue ₹ 3600/- ₹ 2899/-	12 Issue ₹ 3600/- ₹ 2899/-	12 Issue ₹ 3600/- ₹ 3060/-
	3 YEAR	78 Issue ₹ 15400/- ₹ 9499/-	18 Issue ₹ 5400/- ₹ 3999/-	12 Issue ₹ 5400/- ₹ 2799/-	18 Issue ₹ 5400/- ₹ 3999/-	18 Issue ₹ 5400/- ₹ 3999/-	18 Issue ₹ 5400/- ₹ 4320/-
DIGITAL	TERM	BW BUSINESSWORLD	BW EDUCATION	BW PEOPLE	BW HEALTHCARE	BW WELLBEING	BW HOTELIER
	1 YEAR	26 Issue ₹ 5200/- ₹ 999/-	6 Issue ₹ 1800/- ₹ 1299/-	6 Issue ₹ 1800/- ₹ 999/-	6 Issue ₹ 1800/- ₹ 1299/-	6 Issue ₹ 1800/- ₹ 1299/-	6 Issues ₹ 1800/- ₹ 1299/-

Visit for BW Group Magazine Subscription: <https://subscribe.businessworld.in>

Visit for Combo Offer: <https://bwsubscriptions.com>

For more information: Vinod Kumar | +91 98109 61195 | vinod@businessworld.in

SUBSCRIBE NOW!!!

THE LEGION PRO 5I GEN 10 DOESN'T TRY HARD. IT JUST IMPRESSES



On paper, the Legion Pro 5i Gen 10 pairs Intel's Core Ultra 9 275HX with 32GB of DDR5 memory and a 140W TGP variant of Nvidia's RTX 5070 Ti, positioning it firmly at the upper end of the gaming laptop stack

BY DEEP MAJUMDAR

A **RESTRAINED CHASSIS**, a 240Hz OLED panel and an RTX 5070 Ti suggest Lenovo's newest mid-range contender knows exactly what it wants to be. Gaming laptops priced under Rs 3 lakh are often more interesting than their ultra-premium siblings. A flagship's job is simply to be the best it can be, so there is little surprise left in it. It is the machines built to impress without the flagship price tag that keep things interesting, and the Legion Pro 5i Gen 10 belongs firmly in that second camp. Restraint is the first thing you notice about it.

The matte black lid, with barely a Legion logo to give it away, has

an almost corporate demeanour, right up until the specifications sheet arrives. The aluminium-alloy lid and sturdy plastic base feel appropriately premium for the price, and at roughly 2.43 kilograms, the laptop stays just about on the right side of portable for a 16-inch performance machine. A slightly extended rear section, housing part of the cooling system, adds character without tipping into the theatrical design language rival brands often favour.

Ports are spread generously across both flanks, including USB Type-A, a USB Type-C with display support, HDMI, Ethernet and a headphone jack, which means cables end up on either side of the desk, but rarely does one need to reach for a dongle. One small detail worth applauding: the power input sits at the back, a fix I wish Lenovo had also made on the pricier Legion Pro 7i.



The OLED Panel Makes its Case Immediately

If one feature defines the first few minutes with this laptop, it is the screen. The 16-inch OLED panel, running at 2560 x 1600 (WQXGA) resolution with a 240Hz refresh rate, makes an impression the moment it boots up. Blacks are genuinely deep rather than the greyish tint IPS panels tend to carry, and colours look considerably richer straight out of the box.

The screen makes an impression the moment it boots up. Lenovo claims full coverage of the DCI-P3 colour gamut, a standard that should appeal well beyond gaming circles, to photo and video editors who need colour accuracy alongside the smoothness a 240Hz panel brings to fast motion. Even scrolling a web page feels noticeably fluid, an early sign the display could end up being the standout feature once testing is complete.

The Nahimic-tuned

speakers are reasonably loud and clear too, though deep bass is in short supply, as it usually is on gaming laptops.

Design

Lenovo's Legion keyboards have long been among the more comfortable in the gaming laptop space, and the Gen 10 model continues that trend. The full-size layout includes a dedicated number pad, which feels like an odd inclusion on a gaming keyboard. An optional 24-zone RGB lighting system is available as an add-on through Lenovo's website; my review unit does not have it.

The touchpad is large and tracks smoothly, though most buyers will have a mouse plugged in within moments regardless, and its position, over to the left, mirrors the Legion Pro 7i Gen 10, for reasons that remain unclear. A 5-megapixel webcam with an IR sensor for Windows Hello, plus a physical privacy shutter, round off the top deck, both sensible upgrades over the grainy webcams many gaming laptops still ship with.

What the Spec Sheet Promises

On paper, the Legion Pro 5i Gen 10 pairs Intel's Core

Ultra 9 275HX with 32GB of DDR5 memory and a 140W TGP variant of Nvidia's RTX 5070 Ti, positioning it firmly at the upper end of the gaming laptop stack. Cooling is handled by Lenovo's Legion Coldfront Hyper system, a detail worth watching once sustained sessions come into play, since thermal management usually separates a good gaming laptop from a great one.

I have started playing Forza Horizon 6, Overwatch and Red Dead Redemption 2 on it, and will document the experience in a full review soon. At under Rs 3 lakh, the Legion Pro 5i competes in a segment where buyers have no shortage of choice, including machines that step into RTX 5080 territory for similar money. Lenovo's pitch, at least on early impressions, rests on the strength of the display and the promise of dependable, sustained performance rather than bragging rights on the spec sheet.

Verdict

Nothing about this laptop feels like a gamble. The design is understated, the OLED display eye-catching, and the keyboard feels like something Lenovo has quietly perfected over several generations.

The RTX 5070 Ti and Core Ultra 9 275HX combination offers sustained performance under extended gaming loads; the 80Wh battery holds its ground as well. The cooling system plays a vital role too. On this evidence, the Legion Pro 5i looks simply built to impress. **BW**

AT A GLANCE

• Display:	16" OLED, WQXGA, 240Hz
• Processor:	Intel Core Ultra 9 275HX
• Graphics:	RTX 5070 Ti, 140W TGP
• Memory:	32GB DDR5
• Battery:	80Wh
• Weight:	~2.43kg
• Price:	From Rs 2,20,990

I HEAR YOU, and I see how absurdly hard you're working. It's sometimes overwhelmingly frustrating to do everything "right" — your workflow, your team, meetings, those endless presentations... And on top of that, day after day, curating a meticulous high nutrient plate, building in exercise to that routine — only to wake up feeling completely drained.

You're not failing your routine; your nervous system is simply reacting to an entirely different kind of diet.

The mind digests what the mouth can't see.

Every single day, your cells tune in to a constant stream of mental consumption. The brain doesn't keep secrets, and when you anxiously scroll through market volatility, respond to stressful late-night emails, your brain immediately transmits that mental noise into a physical, chemical reality to your cells.

The Master Broadcaster is on high alert.

Your cells don't know the difference between a real physical predator and an urgent late-night email notification. They simply react to the signal of danger. In the language of biol-

ogy, stress means *survival* — not growth, repair, or recovery. When your brain transmits a message of constant urgency, it enters a state of fight or flight and pulls energy away from your gut and immune system for cellular maintenance, leaving you exhausted from inside out.

So how do we reclaim our energy?

Audit your mental data with the same rigour you apply to physical nutrients and work. Some steps:

- **Protect Your Mornings:** Give your brain a "real sunrise." You don't have to wake up at sunrise, you just have to give your emotional immune system the message of normalcy of a morning. Avoid checking emails or market updates for 30 to 60 minutes after waking. Step outside (balcony, window, walk, all three work) and let natural sunlight hit your eyes and reset your cortisol rhythm.
- **Treat data like meals:** You're not constantly

consuming meals, your data should be the same. Schedule two-to-three specific 20-minute windows to check online updates between 10 a.m. and 5 p.m. Outside of that, close those tabs. Constant micro-checking keeps your cells on a low-grade, toxic cortisol drip.

- **60-second transition pause:** When switching between different tasks or heavy meetings, take a pause. Close your eyes, stretch your arms over your head, and let out one



Are You an Exhausted Leader?



AI Created Representation

heavy sigh. You can do this in the washroom if you're not alone otherwise. Don't immediately dive into a screen or a meeting. This gives your brain a moment to digest the previous context before forcing it to swallow a new one.

- **Audit Your Audio Environment:** Your auditory system is a direct line to your survival brain. Loud, chaotic workspaces or aggressive lyric-heavy music signal a chaotic environment to your cells.

Switch to binaural beats, brown noise, or western classical music during deep work. This signals a predictable, safe environment,

for your nervous system to stay calm.

- **The Physiological Hydration:** When a stressful operational issue pops up, pause and take two quick inhales through your nose, followed by one long, slow exhale through your mouth. Then reach for water. Exhaustion is often a sign of dehydrated brain cells. This is the fastest, biologically proven way to flip your nervous system from "fight-or-flight" into a calm state. Repeat this a few times a day whenever you feel overwhelmed.

- **True Rest and Digest:** Pause working through lunch for *just 15 minutes*.

When you eat while reviewing briefs or scrolling through feeds, your body can't properly absorb high-performance nutrients. Eat without screens. Your gut will absorb and repair faster, bloating and weight reduces, and skin gets healthier.

- **Establish a "Sunset Boundary":** Pick a hard stop for sending complex, stress-inducing communications (like 6:00 or 7:00 p.m.). If you write an urgent email late at night, use the "Schedule Send" feature to deliver it the next morning. This simple boundary protects your team's mental diet, and stops you from anticipating an anxious, late-night reply.

- **Practice Active Un-focussing:** Your brain can't handle constant, intense focus without paying a metabolic price. Every 90 minutes, practice *optic flow*. Look out a window at a distant point or let your eyes drift lazily across

the room for two minutes without focussing on any single object. This physically relaxes the muscles in your eyes, which instantly sends a calming signal to your brainstem.

How to Begin

You don't need to implement all today. Pick *just one* that feels the easiest to integrate into your current schedule. As you settle into one activity, add another. Within 45 days, you'll begin feeling calm, which will help your brain work faster and be sharper.

Nutrition isn't just about what you feed your body; it's about what you feed and allow into your mind. It's time to start sending your cells a signal of safety, nourishment and calm, so they can reduce inflammation and your health and work can flourish. **BW**

The author is a well-known epigenetics, cancer, nutrition & mental health therapist who has written five books on health. She treats across 28 countries

Give your brain a "real sunrise." You don't have to wake up at sunrise, you just have to give your emotional immune system the message of normalcy of a morning. Avoid checking emails or market updates for 30 to 60 minutes after waking. Step outside (balcony, window, walk, all three work) and let natural sunlight hit your eyes and reset your cortisol rhythm

Walking through the new **Sabyasachi space** in Mehrauli, one feels like they could be walking through a museum. Opened in August, the 26,000-square-foot flagship store expands on the vision of Sabyasachi for Indian luxury, with fashion, jewellery, accessories, art and craft in one space, writes **Jyotsna Sharma**



INCULCATE THE habit of visiting museums, said Sabyasachi Mukherjee, Founder & Creative Director, Sabyasachi, at the preview of his new flagship store at The Citadel, One Style Mile in Mehrauli, Delhi.

According to him a unique voice can only be shaped by observing history at places like museums, which are recordkeepers of the past, especially now that we live in a digital world where facts are sometimes blurred.

The celebrated designer

Sabyasachi's New Space In Delhi



Sabyasachi Mukherjee, Founder & Creative Director, Sabyasachi



graduated from the National Institute of Fashion Technology, Kolkata, in 1999.

His collection of contemporary silhouettes honouring heritage crafts was showcased at the Lakme Fashion Week in 2002.

Since then, he has won several accolades for his work and has become one of the most well-known names in global fashion.

Talking about his collaboration with The Metropolitan Museum of Art in New York, he said it would allow him to draw on the museum's 5,000 years of history and culture to build a contemporary design language.

The creations will be seen at the New York Fashion Week in September this year.

Josh Romm, Head of Global Licensing & Partnerships for The Metropolitan Museum of Art, said the collaboration fits in with their vision to

encourage meaningful conversations globally about the work the museum does.

He said they value Sabyasachi's focus on craftsmanship, and it was a privilege to have worked with him and his team.

THE NEW STORE

"I have never believed that a luxury store should simply sell products. It should inspire curiosity, preserve culture and create memory. Commerce may bring people through the door, but culture is what makes them return.

As the world becomes increasingly digital, spaces that celebrate craftsmanship, beauty and human connection become more valuable than ever," said Sabyasachi.

Walking through the new Sabyasachi space in Mehrauli, one feels like they could be walking through a museum.

Opened in August this year, the 26,000-square-foot flagship store expands on the vision of Sabyasachi for Indian luxury, with

fashion, jewellery, accessories, art & craft in one space. Further, Delhi remains significant for the fact that it brings in 30 per cent of the brand's global revenue.

The designer values the importance of experience, which makes the new, thoughtfully curated store essential for showcasing his creative vision.

Visitors will journey through a series of rooms inspired by different regions of India, with a special focus on Kolkata.

Among the store's most theatrical installations is an enclosed room inspired by the tramcars of Calcutta, constructed in wood with etched star cut glass.

Inside the room sits a life-size sculptural Bengal Tiger, transforming a cherished part of the city's history into a memorable experience.

Additionally, there is a lounge inspired by the Bengal *naach ghar*, with pink marble, laterite stone, sculpture, embroidery and layered textiles, accompanied by Bengali tea rituals.

The interiors bring together approximately 120 chandeliers, nearly 200 antique carpets and around 300 original paintings created by artists of the Sabyasachi Art Foundation, alongside more than 100 antique textiles, mirrors and historic decorative objects. **BW**



[jyotsna@businessworld.in](mailto: jyotsna@businessworld.in)



Annurag Batra,
Chairman and Editor-in-Chief,
BW Businessworld and
Founder, exchange4media
Group delivering the opening
address

A MOMENT FOR FOUNDERS

India's startup landscape is acquiring a different texture, investment activity is finding its rhythm again, while the founder agenda is shifting from velocity at any cost to businesses built for durability, scale and sustained value creation. That evolution framed the tenth edition of BW Disrupt 40 Under 40, where conversations across capital, technology, consumer, mobility and emerging enterprise models traced the contours of India's next entrepreneurial cycle. The day culminated with the unveiling of this year's winners who secured the spot in the elite list **By Team BW**



Photographs by Naval Kishor

Winners of 10th Edition of BW Disrupt 40 Under 40 Awards

L-R: Swati Babel, Founder & CEO, Globizera Services FZCO; **Abhinav Parashar**, Co-founder & CEO, Digio; **Sridhar Sampathirao**, Founding Partner & CXO, Thoucentric; **Avinash Chenreddy**, Co-founder & CTO, Constelli Signals; **Vijay Gond**, Co-founder & CEO, Peakamp and (Session Chair) **Brij Pahwa**, Editorial Lead, e4m & Editor, MartechAI.com



L-R: Sneh Sharma, Co-founder & CMO, Dogsee Chew; **Niharika Joshi**, Co-founder & CMO, Cumin Co; **Sumit Marda**, Co-founder, Phitku; **Ankur Tyagi**, Founder & CEO, Rosier Foods; **Bhuman Dani**, Founder & CEO, WickedGud and (Session Chair) **Reema Bhaduri**, Senior Editorial Lead, BW Marketing World



L-R: Piyush Goyal, Co-founder & CEO, Volks Energie; **Mohit Gulyani**, Co-founder & Director, Recommere; **Varun Karad**, Co-founder & CEO, Renergy Dynamics; **Abhimanyu Asija**, Chairman & MD, Sommet Alloy & Wires and (Session Chair) **Ruhail Amin**, Senior Editor, BW Businessworld



L-R: Ashish Kumar, Founding Member, Fundamentum; **Sukhmani Bedi**, Co-founder, Orios Venture Partners; **Ntasha**, Co-founder & Managing Partner, VG Capital; **Shashank Randev**, Founder & General Partner, 247VC and (Session Chair) **Resham Suhail**, Senior Editorial Lead, BW Disrupt



L-R: (Session Chair) Soumya Bhutani, Senior Editorial Lead, BW Marketing World; **Himanshu Ratnoo**, Co-founder & CEO, EMotorad; **Ambrish Miyani**, Co-founder, Indo Era; **Vinayak Bhavnani**, Co-founder & CTO, Chalo Mobility and **Nitin Kalra**, Founder & CEO, Let's Try

“The AI race needs a recovery plan”

SANJAY MIRCHANDANI on why AI strategy is moving into the boardroom, the growing risks around non-human identities and why resilience needs to be built into AI systems from day one

On AI becoming a boardroom issue

At the board level, it is important for directors to understand how AI is being used, or not being used, inside an organisation.

There are two ways companies can think about AI. One is how they are using it for internal operations and efficiencies, and the other is how they are using AI as part of their product or service offering to customers. Both need to be looked at.

The CISO and IT conversations are more around guardrails, approaches and resilience. As companies move quickly on this journey, they need the right parameters and guardrails to make sure they are leveraging the power AI brings without taking on unnecessary risk.

The conversations are definitely at the board level. I talk to CEOs and board members about this. It is top of mind for everyone, and I believe it should be a CEO charter in every company. The CEO should directly be involved in and own the AI strategy because it is becoming a differentiator.

On AI and cyber resilience

If you look at the spectrum, it starts with identification and goes through to recovery. We add resilience because, in my simple way of thinking about it, resilience is your confidence level to do a safe, predictable recovery every time.

We are working with security partners on the frontend of the spectrum and with Google on threat intelligence to make sure what we are doing correlates to recovery. To conduct a clean recovery repeatedly and predictably, you need to know the provenance of what happened.

The resilience and recovery conversation has gone from the backbone to the core.

When I was a CIO, I was never asked, “Do you have backup?” Now the questions are: Have you tested it? Is it working? How long will it take us to come back?

Audit committees, risk committees and board members are asking these questions, and they should, because as we become completely digital, our assets need to be protected.

I always say our customers have to be safe 100 per cent of the time. Bad actors don’t have to be right 100 per cent of the time, because they just have to be right once.



“Our ability to give customers the confidence to be bold with AI while having the ability to recover if something goes sideways is important”

On the expanding risk surface

There are non-human identities proliferating, and the volume of these identities with privileges is increasing rapidly. Things can go sideways even without a cyberattack. It could be poor configuration, poor testing or simply the learning process.

Our ability to give customers the confidence to be bold with AI while having the ability to recover if something goes sideways is important.

Part of those guardrails is getting your data right, getting data access controls right, getting your data backed up and looking at the entire flow of your AI systems.

On India’s resilience readiness It is early days. One statistic I look at is that just 17 per cent of Indian companies feel they have the security and capabilities to recover today.

The number is low. Companies are still building systems and starting their AI journey.

My message would be: be active. Actively build resilience into your solution as you are building the solution. If you come to it later, you are not doing yourself any favour. **BW**

As told to Rohit Chintapali

Backache From Work ?

Change the way you work.



Pulse Chair

Kinetic Height Adjustable Tables
Change **how you feel.**



BRAND CRAFT CONFERENCE 2026

#BUILTBYBRANDS

**POWER
SPEAKERS**



**SCAN TO
REGISTER NOW**

**OCT 28, 2026
RADISSON MG ROAD,
SULTANPUR**



DR. ANNURAG BATRA
Chairman & Editor-in-Chief,
BW Businessworld, & Founder,
exchange4media



SHIVAM RANJAN
Head Marketing - APAC,
Motorola Mobility



HIMANSHU KHANNA
Group CMO,
CKA Birla Group



RAJAT ABBI
VP, Global Marketing and
Chief Marketing Officer,
Schneider Electric



NIKITA MALHOTRA
Head - Digital & Retail
Marketing, Woodland



BIMAL KUMAR SAHOO
Brand Head,
BKT Tyres



ARCHI GOGOI
Head Brand, Marketing &
Growth, Ai+ Smartphone



SAARTHAK SETHH
Sr. VP & Chief Sales &
Marketing Officer,
Tata Realty & Infrastructure



PARIDHI CHOPRA
AVP Marketing,
Niva Bupa Health Insurance

EVENT PARTNERS



For more contact:

Chetan Mehra: **+91 9811702464**

chetan.mehra@businessworld.in

Parul Gupta: **+91 9773527082,**

parul.gupta@businessworld.in

Built for the dreams that grow with time.

Presenting

ICICI Prudential

Life Cycle Fund 2031

ICICI Prudential

Life Cycle Fund 2036

ICICI Prudential

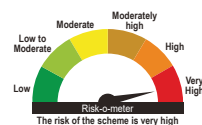
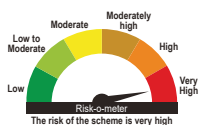
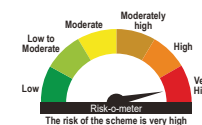
Life Cycle Fund 2041



NFO DATES August 26, 2026 to September 09, 2026

ICICI Prudential Mutual Fund, Registration No.: MF/003/93/6

Download our App **i-Invest** | Visit: www.iciciprumf.com | Contact your Mutual Fund Distributor

ICICI Prudential Life Cycle Fund 2031	ICICI Prudential Life Cycle Fund 2036	ICICI Prudential Life Cycle Fund 2041
((An open ended fund with attributes of pre-determined maturity and glide path for goal based investing) is suitable for investors who are seeking*:	((An open ended fund with attributes of pre-determined maturity and glide path for goal based investing) is suitable for investors who are seeking*:	((An open ended fund with attributes of pre-determined maturity and glide path for goal based investing) is suitable for investors who are seeking*:
- Long term wealth creation - An open ended scheme following glide path strategy based investing across asset classes, i.e. Equity, Debt, InvITs, ETCDs, Gold & Silver ETF.	- Long term wealth creation - An open ended scheme following glide path strategy based investing across asset classes, i.e. Equity, Debt, InvITs, ETCDs, Gold & Silver ETF.	- Long term wealth creation - An open ended scheme following glide path strategy based investing across asset classes, i.e. Equity, Debt, InvITs, ETCDs, Gold & Silver ETF.
*Investors should consult their financial advisers if in doubt about whether the product is suitable for them.	*Investors should consult their financial advisers if in doubt about whether the product is suitable for them.	*Investors should consult their financial advisers if in doubt about whether the product is suitable for them.
 The risk of the scheme is very high	 The risk of the scheme is very high	 The risk of the scheme is very high

It may be noted that the scheme risk-o-meter specified above is based on the internal assessment of the scheme characteristics and may vary post NFO when the actual investments are made. The same shall be updated on ongoing basis in accordance with clause 6.16 of the SEBI Master Circular on Mutual Funds dated March 20, 2026 (Master Circular).

The visual in this creative includes AI-generated images, including synthetic human faces. No endorsement or likeliness of a real person is implied.

Mutual Fund investments are subject to market risks, read all scheme related documents carefully.